Ghosts of a Scarlet Past

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Ch1 - After the Story

She wasn't always like this.
You know, scared.

Juliana woke up with a scream. Her eyes shot open, trying desperately to unsee what had just happened. She put a hand to her pounding heart, trying to calm herself. She was still panting, suppressing the urge to cry.

She was safe. It was just another nightmare, none of this was real.
She was okay. She really was okay. She wasn't back there- no, she was sitting in her dorm room at the Academy. Thank God the walls were thick- at least no one could hear her scream.

Juliana checked her phone in the dark. She had gotten about two hours of sleep tonight. If she went back to bed now she could get two, maybe three more.

She closed her eyes- and opened them again. Nope. Not yet.

How did she get to be so afraid of a good night's rest? She used to be strong, fearless. She used to dive headfirst into any situation, any challenge. She could win against all odds.

Look where it got her.

It had now been months since Area Zero, and only a few weeks since Blueberry Academy. Still, she had not been able to sleep properly ever since facing the Professor, haunted by visions of the dying woman. Maybe that was why Director Clavell had sent her to Kitakami- only things had gotten worse.

She had screwed up, again and again. Just like always. She hadn't been enough, yet she had been too much at the same time. Even at home, she had always messed things up. Maybe that was why Dad…

A tug on her sleeve brought her back from her reverie. Right, her Pokémon. Her yelling woke them up again, huh? Terapagos looked at her with wide eyes. The poor baby probably thought it was time for breakfast. She sighed. Well, at least this gave her something to do.

Juliana rose from her sitting position and made her way through the darkness to the kitchen, careful not to trip over anyone's tail. She spared a glance at the homework piling up on her desk- she'd catch up with it later.

Her eyes fell on the kitchen counter, where the Scarlet Book rested. She walked on, trying not to think about it too much. She… still wasn't sure about the implications of meeting Professor Sada's past self, nor who she should talk to about it. She was content to leave it in her room for now, gathering dust.

Finally, she reached the kitchen cupboard. Juliana took out a large bag of Pokémon Food, cut it open and poured the contents into bowls while her team lazily joined her one by one.

Juliana felt thirsty as she watched them eat. She grabbed a glass and headed to the sink.

Despite all the hardships, her Pokémon journey had been worth it, she thought. For once in her life, she wasn't on her own. She had her team to take care of her at least as much as she took care of them. And she had friends! Nemona, Penny and Arven. Carmine and Kieran too, although she hadn't heard from them in a while. The boy still didn't have a phone, and his sister was busy assisting Ms. Briar with her research the last time they spoke.

Juliana hoped they were both well now. Ms. Briar still creeped her out, and Kieran wasn't exactly well, the last time she'd seen him. They parted ways okay, but she was still hung up on everything that had happened. Had she made the right decisions? Everything had gone wrong back then. And… and this power, the nature of it, it… it still terrified her. The power that the elite of Paldea uses so casually, that ancient power that ultimately proved to be the Professor's demise. It could have killed her, and everyone she loved.

A loud noise made her jump out of her skin, interrupting her thoughts. What-oh, she dropped the glass in the sink. Luckily, it wasn't broken, somehow. She calmed her trembling hands and refilled it with water.

Juliana looked around the dark room as she drank. Her Pokémon had all finished eating and gone back to sleep, most of them choosing to stay on her bed. She went back to join them and found a spot on the mattress. Not wanting to go back to sleep just yet, she pulled out her phone once again to check her notifications.

A couple of messages from Professor Jacq. She'd been helping the man with his Pokémon research in conjunction with the League, namely on Paradox Pokémon.

Another one had escaped from the crater.

She sighed. For some unknown reason, this was happening more and more these days. Surely, she would receive an official request from the League first thing in the morning to take care of it. She opened her calendar app to add a reminder about it,

just in case. She already had a pretty full day: classes, helping out Arven with his revisions… oh and the monthly Academy Tournament. She hadn't had time to do any serious battling the last few days, the Tournament would be good for her team.

But she needed to be well rested… or at least as well rested as she could be if she wanted to compete. The competition had gotten tougher since she returned from Blueberry! She couldn't wait to face her friends and teachers in battle once again. Maybe even get a rematch with Team Star's Bosses?

With renewed excitement Juliana set an alarm for early in the morning and went back to sleep, hugging tight her Clodsire.

Ch2 - Cracks in the Spotlight

“All right ladies and gentlemen, make some noise! Here comes the grand finals of today’s Naranja Academy tournament!”

Juliana sighed as she tried to relax backstage. As usual, Giacomo had volunteered to cast this edition of the tournament. And as always, his boundless energy kept her on edge as she tried to prepare for the battle ahead. She forced herself to tune him out and closed her eyes.

She had made it to the finals. No surprise there: while Naranja Academy had very good trainers, only a select few could actually rival her team. Her opponent was one of those few.

Nemona entered the arena with a grin. Of course she’d be facing her, who else? No one else in Paldea could challenge her like she could. Nemona always pushed her further in battle, past her limits.

Juliana entered from the left, waving to the large crowd that had gathered for their battle. She had gained quite a following, since her meteoric rise to Champion as well as several appearances on Iono’s show. It was surprising to her just how much her popularity seemed to keep growing day by day, even after all this time.

Of course, she was still overwhelmed by the sudden attention she received from so many, but she made sure to put up a smile for those who looked up to her. She focused her attention back on the battlefield after one last wave.

Finally, she was face to face with her rival.

“Are you ready, Jules?” The girl had the biggest grin imaginable on her face.

“Always Nemona!” Somehow, Juliana matched it.

As the crowd settled down, they both threw a pokeball at the same time.

“Let the battle BEGIN!”

The battle was hard. Really hard, she had to admit. Nemona might be the only person with Kieran who could consistently give her a run for her money. But still, Juliana usually came out on top.

Like, 50% of the time.

This time was no different. As always, Nemona gave her all in this match, and Juliana struggled to match her intensity.

It came down to this. They were both down to their last Pokemon. Juliana had just sent out Skeledirge, silently strategizing and going over all the options in her mind, when she realised that Nemona was holding a Tera Orb on the other side of the battlefield. Powerful energy swirled inside the device as her rival struggled to hold it in place, using her left arm to stabilise her holding hand.

“Okay, Meowscarada, time to show off our hard work!” Nemona yelled, throwing the object with trained precision.

Meowscarada let out a mighty roar as she terastallized into a Dark type.

It’s okay, Juliana thought. Nemona had chosen a Tera Type that gave her an advantage over the Skeledirge’s Part-Ghost Type. Fortunately, the Crocodile Pokémon still had its Fire Tera Type. If she Terastallized as well, Nemona would lose her advantage - and Juliana would rather face her on neutral ground than at a disadvantage.

It only took a second for Juliana to pull out her own Tera Orb from her belt and prepare to press the activation button.

She blinked.

On top of the machine, the Professor looked at her with pleading eyes.

“I’m sorry, children. Run!”

Crystals began to form around the robot. Encasing her feet, enveloping her legs. Corrupting her form into a shell of her former self. Juliana was fixated on her eyes , so full of panic, of sorrow, of pain… and then nothingness. All emotions drained out of the robot as Terastal corruption took hold.

Juliana felt a chill down her spine as the Professor was turned into a weapon by her own programming.

Then the chill became real. The same crystals slowly formed around Juliana. She struggled against them, thrashed as she tried so hard to shake them off. She couldn’t move. She couldn’t breathe. She was alone, her Pokémon trapped. No one would help her. No one would save her. She…

“**DIIIIIRGE**!”

Skeledirge's roar brought her back to reality, the Pokémon giving her a worried look. Her hands were shaking.

She had spaced out. Her hands turned into fists as she willed herself to stay still. This- this shouldn't happen. She won't allow it. She fought her own body for control, taking a deep breath.

Fortunately, no one in the audience seemed to have noticed anything, all eyes still on the glittering form of Meowscarada. If anything, she knew from experience that it would only have looked like she froze in place for a second too long. No one would care, justifying it as her rethinking her strategy.

Though, she didn't miss the quizzical look Nemona held on the other side of the field.

Juliana shook her head, quickly put on her brave face again. She silently shoved her Tera Orb into her bag.

"Skeledirge, use *Torch Song*!"

The battle was over.

She had lost, unsurprisingly. Nemona had simply defeated her fair and square, having the advantage of type. Juliana didn't mind it, really.

The aftermath, as always, was a blur. Everyone had congratulated them both on a hard-fought battle as the crowd began to disperse. Juliana signed a few autographs before disappearing to the nearest Pokémon Center. She all but collapsed into a bench, waiting for her team to heal.

She rested there for a while, thinking back on the battle. What was happening to her? She never had this problem before. Yes, ever since Area Zero, she had never felt comfortable using Terastallization. And yes, somehow, it got even worse after the whole Underdepths situation a few weeks ago. But… she had never just frozen like that before. Stuck in a vision of her nightmares. Things didn't even happen this way, she knew it. So why…

Maybe she should try not using it for a while, she thought. She didn't need it anyway, she was sure she could function just fine while letting the Tera Orb collect dust in the back of her pack. She had to.

She was brought out of her thoughts as someone sat next to her. Opening her eyes, she saw Nemona stretching out her arms.

“Man, what a battle! I’m exhausted after all that action, what about you Juliana?”

“Yeah, I’m pooped.” She responded.

“But that was great!” Nemona turned to her, giving her a wide grin that made her heart beat just a little faster. “I’m so glad I’ve got you, Jules. It’s so fun being able to battle someone on your level y’know?”

Juliana nodded tiredly with a knowing smile.

They stayed silent for a few minutes, simply enjoying each other’s company. Eventually, Juliana felt sleepy and rested her head on Nemona’s shoulder. The girl didn’t mind. Minutes passed like this, but it could be hours for all they cared.

“Say, Juliana… I’m not sure how to ask this…” Nemona broke the silence.

“What is it ‘Mona?” She mumbled sleepily. “You know you can ask me anything.”

Her rival swallowed hesitantly. It was only then that Juliana realised how nervous the girl was. Forgetting her urge to sleep, she drew back slightly and looked her in the eyes with a patient gaze. She placed a hand on her rival's fidgety hand.

“Well… It’s… What happened back there, Jules? You know you could have won if you had used your Tera Orb, right?”

Juliana’s heart skipped a beat. Her mind was frantic. Nemona couldn’t know about her difficulties. She needed an excuse.

“I… I wanted to try something new! You were *obviously* waiting for me to terastallize, so I didn’t. I was hoping to throw you off, but, hey, it backfired!” She forced an unconvincing smile. Even as she said it, she knew how flimsy the excuse was.

Nemona stared at her for a moment, as if studying a wild Pokemon. Finally, she let out a sigh of relief, all tension leaving her body as she slumped back into the bench.

“Phew! And here I was worried that you didn’t want to battle me anymore and lost on purpose! I’m so relieved.”

This set off alarms in Juliana’s head. “What!? Nemona, I would never do that, you know that right? How- Why would you think that?”

Nemona suddenly looked embarrassed, her face flushed as she resumed her fidgeting. “I- I’m sorry! I just… This used to happen all the time when people didn’t really want me around, but didn’t want to say it. I’m just, you know, really bad with social things, so I’d never get the hint. So when we battled, they would throw the match over and over again until I lost interest.”

“Nemo…”

“I… I know I can be a little pushy sometimes, but I really do love battling, and you’ve brought so much into my life, it’s wonderful, and I love every moment of it, and, and-”

Juliana hugged her. “I’ll always be there for you okay? You mean just as much to me, I promise I’ll always love you too.”

Nemona didn’t say anything and hugged her back, crying silently into her shoulder.

A few minutes later, the nurse from the Pokémon Center found them both sleeping on the bench, still hugging each other. The woman chuckled softly and decided to keep holding their Pokémon a little longer, letting the two girls rest.

Ch3 - Study Time

The Ultra Ball shook gently on the ground where it had just engulfed the wild Pokémon. Juliana held her breath, and counted in her head.

One…

Two…

Three…

Bingo!

She let out a breath she didn't know she was holding. Finally! She had captured the Sandy Shocks that Professor Jacq warned her about last night.

To think that such a dangerous Pokemon was out in the wild… The League seriously needed to reassess the situation at the crater, before anyone else got hurt. How could a Paradox Pokémon find itself in broader Paldea? As Juliana picked the Ultra Ball back from the ground, she swore to herself she'd talk to Director Clavell or Geeta about it next time she'd get the chance.

She looked down at the Ultra Ball in her hands as she returned Ogerpon to her own Pokéball. She was wearing the League gloves gifted to her by Geeta. She still couldn't believe the opportunity La Primera had given her. Sure, she was Champion Rank, but to work for the League as part of the Elite 4? Her!? It didn't feel real. She wouldn't take the position until after she graduated, but still.

She always thought that Nemona would get there before her, but it seemed that the girl aspired more to replace Geeta one day, and she was on the right track to do so. And-

Her thoughts were interrupted by a buzzing sound from her bag. Slipping the Ultra Ball onto her belt, she clumsily fished out her mobile phone. Penny's profile picture appeared on the screen and she answered the call. The Rotom-powered device hovered in front of her, the camera being off. Knowing her friend, Juliana figured she had just woken up. She was always up at ungodly hours of the night, working on *something*.

"Hey Juliana!" Came her friend's enthusiastic voice. Penny was usually shy around people, but she seemed to be more herself around Juliana. And of course, long distance communication seemed to make her more comfortable. Juliana thought back to their early days, with all the chaos surrounding Team Star, and the hacker calling her on her mobile just like that, under the name 'Cassiopeia'.

“I was wondering”, Penny continued, “if, um, you wanted to watch the latest episode of Magical Veevee with me? It just came out this morning.”

Juliana winced. “Ah, I’m sorry Penny but I’m busy this afternoon. I had to run an errand for the League, and I still have to help Arven study for his exams when I get back. What about tonight?”

“Sounds good to me, I still need to binge-watch The Eevengers anyway. While you’re at it, can you do me a favor?”

“Sure, what is it?” It wasn’t often that Penny asked her for anything, so she was curious.

“Can you make sure that Arven doesn’t overwork himself? I know he wants to graduate at the same time as us, but I’ve been worried about him lately. He’s not responding to texts, or calls, or just anything in general. I don’t think he’s been taking many breaks, if any.”

Juliana nodded, then realized that Penny wouldn’t be able to tell on the phone.

“Okay, leave it to me! Thanks for letting me know Penny, I’ll be sure to check on that.”

“No problem. Now hurry, I’m already on episode 2.” She replied, bored.

Juliana giggled as she let Koraidon out and flew back to Mesagoza once more.

She arrived outside Arven’s room after dropping off the Sandy Shocks at Clavell’s office. The old man seemed to share her concerns about Area Zero’s security and assured Juliana that he’d talk to Geeta about it. Good.

She couldn’t shake the feeling that his gaze was different as she left his office. As if he was studying her.

She pushed the thought away and focused on the task at hand. On her way to Arven’s, she stopped by the library and picked up some books on mathematics and Pokémon battles. Those were the subjects she was best at, and the ones her friend needed most to prepare for his exams.

She knocked on Arven’s door and the boy was quick to open.

“Hey there, Little Buddy! You’re here early, how are you doing today?”

Arven looked like shit.

Penny wasn’t kidding when she said he was overworking himself. His hair and clothes were messy, and his room was even worse. The bags under his eyes reminded her of Kieran when she had battled him in-

She shook her head. She didn’t want to think about that.

“Arven, I’m *late*. It’s three pm, I was supposed to be here at two.”

Arven blinked slowly, his eyes lost somewhere.

“Ah, so it seems. I’m sorry bud’, I was so busy that I didn’t notice the time. Well, no time like the present! Let’s focus on my future, shall we? Come in, I’ll make you some coffee.”

She followed him in and took in the chaos of his room.

“Arven?” She asked.

“Yes?”

“When did you last eat?”

He paused in his tracks. “Well I! Uuuuh… Hmm, when was the last time I ate?”

Mabostiff barked once from his comfortable position on Arven’s bed.

“Ah yes! Thanks Mabostiff, it was this morning, I had breakfast.” He replied with his typical grin and thumbs up.

“...Arven.”

All tension suddenly left his body and he slumped forward.

“Yeah, I know, I know. It’s just been… hard, you know? Getting back to my studies after everything that happened, I didn’t realize how far behind I was. But I still want to graduate with all of you, so I’m working extra hard.”

“It’s okay Arven,” she said in what she hoped was a reassuring voice. “Believe me I understand what it’s like. Really, I…”

Her voice cracked as she failed to finish her sentence. She held back tears. Juliana raised a trembling hand to wipe her face but stopped short, clenching her fist instead. Not now. Not in front of him. Not again.

“But!”

Her confidence back as if it had never left, she stared down at Arven critically.

“You can’t let yourself go like that buddy. I’m so damn proud of you for hanging in there and trying to get back to your studies after everything, but you need to take better care of yourself. Not just for your own sake, but for the sake of the people who care about you, isn’t that right Mabostiff?”

“Woof!” The Pokemon agreed, stretching before hopping down the bed and making his way to Arven’s side.

“You need to take breaks, Arven. You won’t get anywhere by overworking yourself. More work doesn’t mean better work, I thought Saguaro would have told you that by now? Besides, you of all people should know how important a good diet is for a healthy lifestyle!” She grinned.

Arven took the time to take in her words, his gaze alternating between her and Mabostiff. He rubbed the back of his head with his hand, a conceding expression on his face. “...Yeah, you’re right. I’m sorry Juliana, you too Mabostiff. I’ll… I’ll try to take better care of myself.”

“Good! Because it starts now!” Juliana had a mischievous grin on her face.

“Now!? Wow, hold on there, Little Bud, the test is tomorrow, I still have to-”

“Nu-huh!” She interrupted his arguing. “Relax Arven, I’m still going to help you like I promised. But first, you need to take a break. Right now. Go take a shower, you stink buddy. I’ll clean up the place in the meantime, then we can go have a picnic and eat a sandwich!”

Arven frowned. “...Wait, was all that just because you wanted an excuse to have me make you a free sandwich?”

Juliana scoffed. “You wound me, Arven! Now hurry up, I’m hungry.”

“Fine, fine, fine! I’ll go along with your plan.” He smiled. “But only because it’s you Little Buddy! And Koraidon better not steal your food this time.”

While cleaning up the place, Juliana found a portable TV in Arven’s kitchen. He probably used it to watch cooking shows while preparing food, she thought. So, she decided to turn it on in order to have some background noise while she threw away expired cereal boxes.

She couldn’t find the remote, so the TV was stuck on one channel. Not that she minded, it was a news show that she’d watch at times. They were currently speculating about the mysterious Pokémon that she caught earlier, what it was and where it came from. Paradox Pokémon were still a secret kept from the general public while the League figured out what to do with them, so every sighting on TV shows, like this one, was the object of much speculation.

Some speculated that it was a hoax, and one guest insisted that it was an illusion caused by a Zoroark. Another suggested that it could be a known Pokémon in a rare form, such as a Mega Evolved Pokémon that happened to be separated from its trainer. Yet another suggested that it could be a new Pokémon, one that came from the crater in the center of the region. Fortunately, no one believed that theory.

For now.

Juliana shivered. She didn’t like the idea of people discovering what happened in the crater. Discovering the death of Arven’s mother, her failure to save what was left of her.

She suddenly didn’t like how alone she felt in Arven’s dorm room. She decided to let one of her Pokémon out for company.

“Paaaaa!”

Terapagos let out an adorable wail as he emerged from his shell, looking so happy to be here.

The cute baby melted Juliana's heart. She hadn't had the Pokemon for long, just a few months at this point. She still loved it. The Tera Pokemon was such a baby despite his probably high age, and it didn't help that he acted like she was his mother.

Still, she had a job to do. She continued to clean Arven’s room while enjoying the Pokémon’s company.

“Next, rumors about a strange group dressed in black suits are spreading throughout Paldea. Some people report seeing members of the group sneaking around important buildings in several cities. While nothing illegal has happened yet, concern

about the group is quickly growing. The president of the Paldean Pokémon League, Miss Geeta, had this to say about it-”

“Aaaaah! That felt good!”

Juliana jumped as Arven walked out of the bathroom and stretched. She had spaced out listening to the TV without realizing it.

“Oops, sorry Little Buddy, did I scare you?”

“Y-yeah a little! I was lost in thought, sorry.”

“All good!” He let out a hearty laugh. “And who’s the little guy?”

She followed his eyes back to Terapagos.

“Ah! Forgot you haven't met him yet. Arven, meet Terapagos!” She held him out in her palms to Arven.

“Paaaaa!”

“Awww he’s adorable. Say, where did you meet him? I don’t remember seeing him around back when we were chasing Titan Pokemon.”

“Oh! Well…” She wasn’t sure she was ready to talk about what had happened with Kieran in Area Zero. “I sort of met him at Blueberry Academy during the exchange program!”

“Okay…” It was clear that Arven didn’t believe her, but he decided not to push the subject.

“Well, let’s go then! I still have a sandwich to prepare.” He strolled confidently to the door, picking up his huge bag on the way.

Juliana forced back a smile. “Sure!”

Ch4 - Penny for Your Thoughts

“I just… I just wanted to say that… I LOVE YOU!”

“Veevee I… I love you too.”

“YES, FINALLY! I’VE WAITED NINE SEASONS FOR THIS!” Penny yelled.

Juliana watched with a grin as the shy girl sank back into her Eevee-themed doll, blushing in shame at her own outburst. The two of them were currently watching the latest episode of Magical Veevee in Penny’s room, with Terapagos asleep on her lap. After helping out Arven all afternoon, it was already dark outside when she arrived. Penny had been expecting her, and guessing that she wouldn’t have a chance to eat dinner, she had prepared lots of snacks.

“Can you believe it Juliana! My favorite ship just became canon!” Penny had stars in her eyes.

Juliana giggled, the girl was really into the show. Penny still had trouble truly expressing herself with words, but Juliana now knew that her love language stemmed in sharing things she was passionate about. She was happy for this opportunity to grow closer to her friend and she had to admit, she really was enjoying the show too, to her own surprise.

“That’s amazing Penny! Still, I wish Rubeon and Schneeon would get together too, I’ve been rooting for them since season three.” Juliana complained.

“Don’t worry Juliana, I’m sure they’ll get together eventually.”

Penny wasn’t the loud or outspoken type like Nemona or Arven. She showed her care in the little things: waiting all afternoon to watch the latest episode of her favorite show with a friend, preparing snacks for her, knowing she wouldn’t have had the time to eat anything but a sandwich today… It was really great to be surrounded by so many people who cared about her. It still felt a little surreal at times. It was so different from back when…

“Hey Juliana, are you okay?”

She hadn’t noticed that she spaced out yet again. Her eyes felt watery, and with the look of concern on Penny’s face it was clear that she noticed.

“Y- Yeah, I’m sorry. I’m just still a little moved by Veevee’s confession that’s all.” A white lie. Penny didn’t look convinced. “And I’m a little tired too, today was exhausting. Let’s go ahead and finish the episode, shall we?”

Penny bit her lip, but didn't say anything as she unpaused the TV.

"I'm sorry Rubeon but I have to do this. I have to get back to my roots and go back to where it all began."

'TUDUM

The screen faded to black and the credits scrolled down.

"Wow." Penny said. "That was amazing. Right Juliana?"

She nodded. "Yeah! I loved it, that was one of the best episodes of the show so far."

They both remained silent as the credits rolled, enjoying the moment, reflecting on the show. A question emerged in her head, so Juliana broke the silence.

"Say, Penny I never asked, how was your life in Galar?"

"Hmm? Oh right, I forgot that you were from there too." She paused, looking thoughtful. "Well, I grew up with my sister, my mom and my dad at Hammerlocke. Dad used to be a Gym Leader there before he retired. I heard something happened between him and his own brother, but I never really looked too much into it." She shrugged.

Juliana hummed in acknowledgement as Penny continued. "My mom was nice and my sister was always much more outspoken than I was, so she never really had any trouble at school. I was a bit more awkward, but my good grades got me a place at Naranja Academy, so I came here."

"Woah! I never would have guessed that your dad was a Gym Leader! Never let Nemona know, she'd stop at nothing for a chance to battle him." Juliana joked.

"What about you Juliana?

She paused. What about her?

"Th-There's not much to talk about, my life really isn't that interesting! Haha…"

"C'mon Juliana, you know all about my darkest secrets, surely you can share some of yours! I don't even know why you moved from Galar to Paldea…" Penny looked at her pleadingly.

Juliana sighed, defeated. Her eyes were on the ceiling in thought.

“W-well…” she winced, Juliana hoped the trembling in her voice wasn’t too noticeable.

“I lived a quiet life with my family in Paddoxton. You’ve met my mother by now, but my father was…” She gulped.

“A-anyway,” she continued, pushing past the stutter and nervousness, “I struggled a lot at school for many reasons. One was the bullying. Eventually, we heard about this school in Paldea that was known for its open mindedness and lack of bullying, so we moved here to, y’know, start over?”

When she dared to look back in front of her, she was surprised to see Penny dumbfounded. That was a new look on her face, she thought.

“I- Juliana I’m so sorry I never knew!”

She shrugged, forcing a smile. “It’s okay, I didn’t expect you to, I don’t like to talk about myself after all. It was a long time ago anyway, I’m over it now!”

“Still, I can’t believe I dragged you into Operation Starfall after that! All the stuff with Team Star, and me as Cassiopeia, and-”

“It’s okay,” Juliana interrupted. “Don’t worry you didn’t rope me into anything, I fully knew what I was signing myself up for. Besides, It was liberating to feel in control this time. And I wasn’t alone! I had Director Clavell by my side, he knew everything. He would have intervened if anything went wrong.”

Penny finally relaxed and chuckled. “You mean, your ‘good old pal Clive’?”

Juliana laughed. “Yeah, him. I still can’t believe you didn’t recognize him until the end.”

“H-hey! His disguise was expertly crafted!” Penny pouted. “Besides, I only saw him once or twice before the whole event, I didn’t stand a chance!”

Juliana stared at her before they both burst out laughing.

“Oh man, I needed that.” Juliana said, wiping away a tear.

“Awww, look like we woke up your little guy.” Penny said, looking at a yawning Terapagos.

Juliana yawned in return.

“Welp, thanks for tonight Penny, but I really should go to bed. I have a long day ahead of me tomorrow.”

“It’s okay, I have another show I wanted to…” She stopped herself at Juliana’s glare. “Okaaaaay geez, I’ll go to bed at a reasonable hour, I promise mom.”

Juliana clapped her hands, a smile on her face. “Well then, see you around Penny! Have a good night.”

Ch5 - Crystalline Distortions

Juliana was running.

She didn’t know why, but she was running. She was afraid, more afraid than ever in her life.

She had to make it. Where to? It didn’t matter. She had to run. To get away.

Her feet caught on something. She felt herself falling.

Falling.

For how long, she didn’t know.

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“Ouch!”

She finally hit the ground.

She was in a cave. She couldn’t see beyond her hands. But she could feel it: something, or someone was watching her. Studying her every move. Waiting for the chance to strike. What was she doing here anyway? How did she get here ? She was running. Why did she run? She was still walking. Where was she going?

She could hear a low growl that was getting louder by the second. It was hot here, the atmosphere was oppressive. Her legs felt heavier with every step.

She eventually stumbled and fell to the rocky ground. Red eyes pierced the darkness as the growl came closer. She didn’t have the strength to get back up when an angry

Houndoom stepped out of the shadows and prepared to attack her. She froze. She was powerless.

Wait. Was she?

Juliana slowly got to her feet and pulled a Pokeball from her belt. Yes, that was right! She was a Pokémon Trainer, and a damn good one at that. She didn't have to be afraid of the wild Pokémon, her own team could handle them. Juliana threw the Pokéball in front of her, expecting Skeledirge to come out.

The world shifted.

Her Pokéball landed on the metal floor with a loud thud. Strange chains locked it in place. She was in a shimmering red room with a huge machine in the middle. Alarms were blaring loudly. Her partner was locked up. She felt herself panicking. Why was the pokeball locked? Why was she alone? Wait- she knew this place. Not now, not again-

Professor Sada looked into her eyes from above. Her robotic voice was distorted by crystals.

"**What will you do now, child? I've tamed my own death! Koraidon, come out, and protect our dream!**"

She couldn't believe her eyes as another Koraidon, twice her size, stood menacingly before her. She tried to take a step back, but her feet were stuck. Large crystals quickly enveloped her legs, spreading around her body and trapping her.

She couldn't move. Couldn't breathe.

Everything went black.

…

"You have everything I ever wanted!"

Kieran's voice was all she could hear.

She was standing in the dark, a small light shining far off in the distance. Her limbs were free. She still had trouble breathing, but it didn't matter. She heard *his* voice. So, she started to run towards it.

"You have strong Pokemon! You can go anywhere you want! Be friends with anyone! Even Ogerpon chose you before me!"

She was getting closer. The small light in the distance shimmered, it was coming from an object that was about her size.

“You took everything from me! The Ogre, my title, even my own sister!”

Not long before she reached it.

“I worked so hard, and for what?! I STILL lost in the end!”

She stopped.

Before her stood Kieran, completely frozen in a crystal with an expression of deep hatred. Broken Masterball on the floor. He held a Tera Orb in his hand.

“This… This is all I have left!”

The voice did not stop, she fell back down to the ground, her legs weak.

“**I’m sorry, children.**”

She was back in the lab. Professor Sada was rising into the time machine. Juliana held out her hand, hopelessly trying to reach her. It was no use. She couldn’t get up. Crystals held her ankle firmly in place. She could see Kieran’s eyes in her reflection. She looked around, begging for help. Her friends were there.

Arven was broken. Penny typed on the machine’s keyboard, eyes wide.

Nemona wouldn’t look her in the eye.

She failed. She failed them.

The Professor flew through some kind of gate. Everything went black.

When she came back to reality, the first thing she felt was Koraidon licking her face.

“Ah! Ugh, gross! Stop it Koraidon!”

The Pokemon stopped as soon as it noticed that she was awake, sitting by her bed and looking at her with concern.

She took in her surroundings. She was still in her room, it was ungodly late at night and her pillow was soaked with tears. The rest of her team was thankfully still asleep, only Koraidon had noticed her distress.

“Wh- It’s okay, I’m fine, buddy. Thanks for waking me, I just had another nightmare, that’s all.” She tried reassuring him.

Koraidon didn’t look any less worried. She sighed.

“I wish I could say it was the worst one yet, but we both know I’d be lying then, huh?”

Koraidon said nothing, just laid his head on her lap. Her eyes were still watery.

“Thanks buddy.” She said in a small voice as she held back her tears and began to pet the lizard.

She stayed like that for a few minutes, grounding herself back into reality. Eventually, she got calmer, she stopped shaking in place. But she grew bored and didn’t want to go back to sleep just yet. Still petting Koraidon, she took out her Rotom phone and checked her notifications.

Huh.

Missed texts from Professor Jacq **and** the League. What was that all about?

“Dear Juliana… Hope this text finds you well.. yeah, yeah, why don’t they just get to the point? Ah, here it is.” She paused and frowned.

“Well, Geeta says that she understands my concerns about Area Zero and that they’ve increased security.” Koraidon tilted his head.

“But then, Jacq tells me about another sighting of what looks to be a Paradox Pokemon. Not much of an improvement in security, eh, buddy?” Koraidon let out a soft grumble in agreement.

“There’s been a lot more of these lately. I think… I think something suspicious might be going on at the crater to get all these Paradox Pokemon to leave. What do you think, Koraidon?”

Koraidon growled.

“Yeah, me too buddy. I agree.” She sighed as she absentmindedly patted the Winged King’s head.

Paradox Pokemon leaving the crater. Suspicious people seen around town... Was it related? Or was she just being paranoid? She felt so exhausted that she honestly couldn't tell at this point.

"We'll check it out tomorrow, okay? For now…" She yawned. "I think I'm ready to catch some Z's. Wake me up at dawn-"

She shivered at the look Koraidon gave her.

"Okay, okay! But I want to be up before 9, okay? I can't be late for Miss Tyme's class."

Satisfied, the Pokemon curled up next to her bed and went to sleep.

She sighed. "Thanks, g'night Koraidon."

Ch6 - Double Trouble

“So, what will it be, champ’?”

The vendor was waiting for Juliana to make her choice.

It was noon, she had just gotten out of class and decided to grab a quick bite at a local street food restaurant before heading out to catch the Paradox Pokémon Jacq had told her about.

She came to this place often, the guy was nice and the food was fast and cheap. Kofu would definitely disapprove of her eating at this place, but hey, she was a busy girl.

She was about to order when she heard someone scream.

“Help! Somebody, please help!”

Juliana sighed. Sometimes, it was hard to do the right thing. She looked back at the vendor.

“Sorry sir, I’ll be back.”

He nodded in understanding as she took off in the direction of the scream.

Heading into a dark alleyway, she found a girl about her age in a Naranja Academy uniform. She recognized her, it was the girl who tried to stop her from challenging Eri back in Operation Starfall.

“Hey Carmen! What’s going on?”

“Juliana ? Oh thank Arceus it’s you! I-” She gulped. She looked like she was about to cry, but hesitated to talk to her.

“Hey, if it’s about Operation Starfall it’s okay, you did the right thing trying to protect Eri by challenging me. Now, what’s the problem?”

“Th-thank you. It’s… There was this weird guy dressed in black that was looking at the Academy from this alley. I thought he might be a lost tourist, so I went to help him, but- but he attacked me and stole my Pokemon.”

“WHAT!?” Carmen flinched. Juliana winced, she didn’t mean to yell.

“Okay Carmen, tell me where he went and then go find Director Clavell. I’ll get your Pokemon back.”

“He- He went over the west railing and jumped into the river. But-”

Carmen never got a chance to finish her sentence. Juliana was already gone on Koraidon’s back.

Carmen sighed.

“Well, only one thing to do…” She headed in the direction of the Academy.

Juliana flew over the river west of Mesagoza, searching for the criminal.

“I still can’t believe it, stealing a Pokemon in plain sight, and in the middle of the day! Those guys were suspicious before, but they just got a lot more dangerous.”

Koraidon growled.

“Yeah, I’m worried too. He couldn’t have gotten far, he must have had a Pokemon swim him up the river. We should be able to - oh! There he is.”

The guy they were chasing had just landed on shore and called a Lapras back into a Pokeball.

“Here we go, buddy.”

Koraidon flew down to the ground with impressive speed, landing in front of the bad guy. It looked like he wasn't alone as he argued with a girl dressed in the same outfit as him. They wore black suits and caps, with a silver belt, gloves and boots as well as a large rainbow R on the torso.

“What the-!” They yelled in unison.

“Hey you! Give me back the Pokemon you stole!” At her side, Koraidon growled menacingly.

The girl punched the man in the shoulder. “Damn it, you were supposed to be discreet! Not steal a random girl’s Pokemon, now this brat is on our tail! The boss will kill us-”

“Shut up!” He interrupted his partner with an annoyed expression. “It’s just a random kid and an overgrown Cyclizar. The boss doesn’t need to know, we’ll just… get rid of her, and everything will be fine!”

The girl turned her head to Juliana with a menacing grin. “Now that’s an idea! Nothing personal, girly, but you should know better than to stick your nose in our business.”

Juliana stared back, unimpressed. “So, two against one is that right?”

She took out a Pokeball as Koraidon moved in front of her.

“Too bad for you, I had a little practice at Blueberry Academy!” She smiled as she sent out Ogerpon to stand by Koraidon’s side.

The guy was lost. “Blue-what-now? What is she talking about?”

The girl punched him once again. “Shut up idiot! Let’s beat her up!”

The battle was ridiculously easy. These guys wouldn’t even hold a candle to even the weakest trainer she’d faced at Blueberry Academy. Granted, she had never seen some of these Pokémon in-person before (a Pidgeot and a Raticate according to her Pokedex).

“Well, like I said.” She gave the two grunts a death glare.

“Give. Me. Back. The Pokémon.” Koraidon roared and Ogerpon readied her mace.

Needless to say, the two grunts were scared shitless.

“Wh-who is this kid!?” The girl shivered.

“Don’t know, don’t care! She can have that stupid Pokemon for all I care! RUN!”

“No you don’t! Stay-” Juliana tried to stop them, but the man threw a Pokéball at her that she barely caught.

The girl pulled out another Pokéball, releasing a medium-sized yellow Pokemon holding two spoons. They both held onto it as it teleported them away.

“Wha- HEY! COWARDS! COME BACK HERE!”

It was too late, they were already gone. They had slipped right through her fingers! She sighed. At least she got Carmen's Pokemon back.

She called Ogerpon back to her Pokeball before jumping onto Koraidon's back again. She'd take a quick look around the area, just in case they were still around, before heading back to-

There was something shimmering on the ground right where the two idiots had been standing, she noticed.

Shiny, crystalline dust. Dust she'd only seen once before.

Down in Area Zero.

She froze in place, confusion and horror flooding her mind. What- No, she didn't have the time to dwell on that. She shook her head and snapped a quick picture on her phone, before flying away on Koraidon's back.

Juliana knocked on the door leading to Clavell's office.

"Come in!"

She pushed open the heavy door and entered the office. Waiting for her were Clavell, obviously, sitting at his desk ; Carmen, who had just turned to her with watery eyes, and finally Eri, who was trying her best to comfort her.

"Ah, Miss Juliana. I take it that you were able to retrieve Carmen's Pokemon?"

"Yes, sir! Here it is, Carmen." She took out the Pokeball that the guy had thrown at her earlier and gave it to Carmen. She hoped that it **was** her Pokemon and not just some random Pokeball, she didn't have the time to check.

Carmen opened the ball and her Primeape came out.

"Th- thank you! Thank you so much! I'm so relieved to have him back!" She said, hugging the Pokemon. It looked very much annoyed by the sudden affection of its trainer, but kindly let her have her moment.

Eri stood up and walked menacingly towards Juliana. She gulped, she knew how nice the girl was, but she was still twice her size and very intimidating.

Eri placed a firm hand on Juliana's shoulder.

“Thank you. Thank you for all you have done. I am forever indebted to you. Please, if I can do anything for you in the future, don’t hesitate.”

Then she picked up Carmen **and** her Pokemon as if they were nothing, and walked confidently out of Clavell’s office.

With the two of them alone, Clavell sighed.

“Please Miss Juliana, have a seat.”

She raised an eyebrow but obliged, wondering what this was all about. Surely he wasn’t going to reprimand her for saving the day, was he?

“Juliana, let me start by saying that what you’ve done today is highly commendable. Your dedication to the welfare of others is admirable, and you prove again and again how brightly your courage shines.”

Empty words, her inner voice said. *He doesn’t know everything*. Still, she wasn’t going to interrupt just to refute him.

“How have you been?”

The question caught her off-guard.

“Huh?”

Clavell raised an eyebrow. “How have you been, Juliana? We haven’t had the chance for a chat since you left for Blueberry Academy.”

“W- Well I’m doing great!” She didn’t like how wavy her voice felt. “I’ve been battling Nemona and watching shows with Penny. Oh, and I managed to convince Arven to take more breaks! I- I worried he was going to burn himself out at this point, so…”

Clavell frowned. “I’m sorry Juliana, you still seem to misunderstand me. While I am happy for the well-being of your friends, I was only asking about you.”

“I…” Her voice cracked. Why did it do that? Why did she feel like she was going to cry again? She hated it.

“As I said, Director, I’m fine.” She said, avoiding his piercing gaze. “Now, if… if you will please excuse me, I still haven’t had a chance to eat lunch, and I’m quite hungry.”

She put on her brave face, the one she only wore for Pokemon battles, and met Clavell's gaze.

After a long minute of silence, the Director was the first to break eye contact.

"Very well then. Please, take care of yourself, Miss Juliana."

She stood up and began to make her way out of the office.

"Oh! And before I forget, please, would you please stop by my office tomorrow morning? I would like you to give a statement to La Primera about what you saw so that we can avoid more cases like this."

She looked back and gave him a thumbs up. "Sure thing, Clive! Stay fresh!"

She chuckled as she heard the old man spit out his coffee, pushed the door open, and walked out of Clavell's office.

Ch7 - What Shines Above / The Crater

“So? What do you think, Juliana?”

“Huh?”

Juliana was flying on top of Koraidon’s back, heading home after capturing a very distressed Brute Bonnet just outside of Medali. Nemona called her on the way back, but the conversation soon turned into a group call, with Arven and Penny joining the passionate girl. Now, Juliana had just spaced out while they argued, thinking about the whole Area Zero situation.

“S-Sorry I spaced out for a bit. What were we talking about?”

Penny gave Arven a dark look. “I was arguing with Arven about pineapple on pizza. I think it’s okay, but he seems to think it’s a crime! What do you think?”

“Oh, uh… Sorry I can’t help you there. I don’t really like pizza.”

“WHAT?!” Two shocked screams echoed from her phone.

“Sorry! Sorry! I’m just not a fan and-”

“Hey, Juliana?” Nemona interrupted her, her voice strangely serious.

“Yeah Nemona? What is it?”

“Are you, you know… okay? You’ve been spacing out a lot lately.”

She gulped. Had she? She hadn’t really noticed, but Nemona was right. And she was doing such a bad job of hiding it too. She sighed.

“Yeah, sorry I know, I’ve just been worried about Area Zero.” Arven and Penny tensed up, but she refused to look at the screen.

“All these Paradox Pokémon have been showing up for weeks, and I don’t know why, and just this noon, I stopped a suspicious guy from stealing Carmen’s Pokémon. Things have been weird, and I think that they might be related.”

“How so?” Nemona asked curiously.

“I don’t know. But when that guy teleported away, he left crystal dust behind. You know, the kind we saw when…”

She trailed off. They all knew what she was referring to.

She cleared her voice and focused, sending a determined look to her screen. “I’m not going to let things get bad if I can help it this time. I’ll investigate Area Zero tonight.”

None of them said anything for a while, thinking it over. Finally, Penny sighed. “If you wish to. I don’t think any of us will be able to come with you though, we don’t have clearance to go back there. Not to mention it would be suspicious to have two missing students connected to that place.”

“What! Oh man, I wanted to go with Juliana!” Nemona complained. “The Pokémon there are so strong, it would have been good practice!”

“Well if you want, I do have a battling exam tomorrow. I could use some help preparing my team." Arven suggested.

“Oh absolutely, yes! You’re so on!”

Penny shook her head, a fond smile on her face. “And I’ll keep an eye on them to make sure there’s still a yard to return to for the test.”

A bell rang in the back. “Oh shoot, that’s our next class! Bye Jules!” Nemona took off, running.

“H-Hey! Wait for me!” Penny ran after her.

Arven laughed. “And just like that, she forgot her phone. Welp, here I go! Stay safe little buddy, okay?”

Juliana replied with a grin. “Will do bud’, I promise.”

Arven nodded and ended the call.

She sighed. “What would I do without them, huh buddy?”

She tapped Koraidon lightly on the shoulder as he responded with a curious groan.

“Yeah, I know. Let’s speed up to the Academy okay?”

“Agias!”

“Let’s see… flashlight, snacks, an ample supply of hyper potions and max revives… Yup, looks like we’re all good buddy!” She said as she packed her bag.

She looked at the clock in her room. 1 AM. It should be easy to sneak out at this hour, most of the school staff was already asleep and no student would dream of ratting her out. She had taken the time to rest before going out. You can’t save the world by falling asleep while flying over the city.

Still, she felt tired.

It was exhausting, going on ever since the incident in Area Zero. Between the dreamless nights and the constant stream of Paradox Pokémon from the crater, she had never had a chance to rest. Not that she would if she had the occasion anyway - she had a region to save. A role to play.

She snickered. She had admonished Arven for burning himself out, yet here she was sneaking out at night to investigate a suspicious group in the most dangerous area of the entire region. She was such a hypocrite.

Still, her responsibilities weighed heavy on her shoulders. She wasn’t going to let anyone else get hurt because she didn’t do the right thing in time. Never again.

She took a deep breath and marched towards the door… but she didn’t get far before she felt like she had forgotten something.

She turned around and scanned the room once more… Ah. There it was.

The Scarlet Book.

She didn’t want to touch it. She didn’t even want to acknowledge its existence. But… She was investigating the Crater, and the book was still the key to the late Professor’s lab.

She didn’t *think* that she would need it. She didn’t want to consider even entering the lab again.

But her instincts screamed at her to take the damn book. What to do…

Her hesitation was interrupted by a ping from her phone. Who could be sending her a message at this hour? She pulled out the device and turned on the screen.

It was Ms. Briar, of all people. The teacher had just sent her a revised version of her book, citing exciting additions and reviews from close contacts of hers. Juliana

hummed with curiosity as she tapped the download link and put her phone back in her back pocket. She'd read it later.

Looking back to the Scarlet Book still gathering dust on her desk, she groaned in defeat against her own instincts and shoved it into the bag. With that out of the way, she turned back to the door and headed out of the room.

"It's go time." She whispered.

She was flying on top of Koraidon, high above the clouds of the crater.

Juliana always wondered. What had caused it in the first place? What could have crashed into the earth so hard, leaving such a gaping, cloud-covered hole in the center of the region?

She had her theories, but none of them explained everything.

Maybe she should pay more attention in history class.

"Okay Koraidon let's do this! Go down slowly, we don't want to alert them."

She observed the crater as Koraidon began to spiral down. Thankfully, the crystals illuminated the area enough for her to see.

The first thing she noticed was how much more accommodations there were for the descent into the crater than there had been on her last visit. Elevators, metal stairs, railways, and even a tunnel had been dug to allow wheeled vehicles to enter the crater.

Second, the Pokemon were strangely agitated.

There usually wasn't anything special about the upper layer of Area Zero. Sure, the Crater was home to many kinds of rare and exotic Pokémon, but things on the surface were usually relatively peaceful, with most of the aggressive species preferring the deeper caverns.

That wasn't the case here.

In the distance, a herd of Great Tusks patrolled the plains surrounding the oasis, while smaller creatures such as Pawmis and Swablus hid in fear. A Flutter Mane fed on a defeated Medicham in the shade of a tree. A pack of Slither Wings challenged a Roaring Moon to battle, defending their territory.

“What-”

Koraidon tilted himself just in time to avoid a flying Roaring Moon that was diving headlong at them. The Pokémon looked frenzied, more aggressive than usual for its species, with a bright green replacing its usually tan-blue scales. A strange aura surrounded it.

She frowned. “Okay Koraidon, let’s get down. Time to get serious.”

Koraidon dove to the ground, now being chased by the wild Roaring Moon. The Paradox Pokémon was faster - but just as it was about to catch them, Juliana threw a Pokeball behind her.

Tinkaton emerged, using the momentum to swing her giant hammer at the frenzied Dragon.

The Roaring Moon didn’t stand a chance, taking the heavy blow to its jaw and landing hard on the ground. Tinkaton then used it to soften her own fall and, following Juliana’s orders, used a four time effective Fairy Type move.

The Roaring Moon didn’t get up after that, and Juliana captured it in an Ultra Ball while Koraidon landed softly next to it.

“Huh, weird.” She thought out loud.

Pondering how to proceed, she thanked and called back Tinkaton before mounting Koraidon once again.

“Things are definitely wrong here. C’mon buddy, let’s snap a few pictures for good measure and then we’ll go down into the caves.”

Ch8 - What Lies Below / The Crater

Juliana was hiding behind a rock. Granted, it was a small rock, but she wasn't much bigger to begin with. She was standing in the upper pathways of the cave system of Area Zero. Huge crystals stood just about everywhere. The ceiling, the walls, the ground, illuminating up the caves.

She shivered. She *really* didn't like these things anymore.

She was exploring the area after taking pictures of the chaos on the surface when she heard voices approaching, echoing off the walls. Not wanting to be seen by whoever was responsible for all of this, she hid.

Eventually, some men showed up. Just as she suspected, they were all dressed in a black uniform with a big rainbow R on the chest.

It looked like she was right.

The problem was, there were a lot of them. Like, a **lot** of them. She didn't think Area Zero had ever seen so many people at once. They all marched on like an army, thankfully ignoring her hiding place. She could hear a few snippets of conversation as they passed.

"Ugh, cleaning mission again?"

"I hope the Boss gets what he wants soon, I want out of here."

"Look sharp boys, we're on a serious mission here!"

"Couldn't we just stay at base? It was more comfy. And safe."

"Do you even know what they are researching down there?"

"Don't know, don't care. All that I know is that that big building gives me the creeps, I hope they don't find a way to open it."

She let out a sigh of relief. At least they hadn't found their way into Sada's lab yet, she still had time. Still, it looked like their base of operations was situated deeper in the caves. She hoped that most of their manpower was up here and not down there.

Juliana armed herself with patience as she waited for an opportunity to leave her hiding place.

It took much longer than expected to get to the bottom of Area Zero, due to the amount of patrols that she had to sneak around, but she finally got there. Somehow, where there had been nothing but a large empty space next to a crystal, there was now some kind of black and red building that gave her a strange “evil lair” vibe.

Were these guys even trying to be subtle!?

She noticed two guards standing there, watching the entrance. If she didn’t want to cause a ruckus, she’d have to… Hey, wait a minute, she knew them!

“Why are we even here?” The man complained. “This place is even more messed up than the Ultra Dimension! I almost got an arm chewed off by a funny-looking Salamence!”

“Shut up, idiot!” The girl replied, annoyed. “It’s your fault we’re stuck down here guarding this place! We could be chilling in town right now, gathering intel, but nooooo! You just had to steal some kid’s Pokémon!”

“Sorry, okay! She just came right at me, and I got scared, so I panicked and…” He looked like he was about to cry. The girl just sighed.

New plan, Juliana decided. She marched confidently to the pair, Koraidon trailing her in his battle form.

“Oh, hey! If it isn’t my two favorite criminals! Fancy meeting you down here, fellas!” She gave them an innocent smile.

“What- Oh no- OH GODS PLEASE NOT AGAIN-” The guy fainted here and there.

“Y- You! What are you doing here!” The girl looked just about ready to run for her life. Juliana wouldn’t have it. Koraidon roared, paralyzing the criminal under his glare.

“So. I’m not sure anyone’s bothered to fill me in on what exactly is going on here. Last I checked, Area Zero was devoid of human life, and yet here you are!” She asked, feigning a child-like wonder. “So, would you mind bringing me up to speed?” She wore a sweet smile, Koraidon standing menacingly behind her.

“Y- you’re insane! Who are you anyway!?”

“Oh, how rude! Can you believe it, Koraidon? I haven't even introduced myself!” Koraidon just rolled his eyes, obviously waiting for his partner to get to the point.

“Well, let’s start over. Hi there! I’m Juliana, Champion Rank in the Paldea Region and soon-to-be member of the Elite 4. I work for the League, though I can’t say they know I’m here, so let’s keep things between us, okay?” She winked at the grunt.

“You know what that means right?” She added.

“Huh?”

“Since I’m not here on official business, the League won’t care if I end up breaking a bone or two.”

The girl swallowed, her eyes wide.

“Now, where were we… Ah yes! You see, I’m used to Area Zero. It’s a good place for a picnic! So imagine my surprise when I get attacked on the surface by rabid Pokémon that are only supposed to live down here.”

The girl cursed under her breath. “Okay, okay, I’ll talk.”

Juliana clapped her hands. “Good girl! Now, tell me everything.”

The stressed grunt looked around to make sure that they were alone. “We are Team Rainbow Rocket. We’re known for using Ultra Dimension research to commit our crimes. Remember the Aether Paradise incident a few years ago? That was us. Our boss was interested in Area Zero after being contacted about it a few weeks ago, so we moved here. That’s all I know, I swear!”

She stared down at the girl critically. It looked as if she was telling the truth. “Then what are you doing in Area Zero? And what is going on in this building?”

“I don’t know, Boss orders! He sent a few of us to infiltrate cities for intel gathering, and the rest of us have to stand here and protect this stupid place. We even had to weed out some of the more dangerous wild Pokemon to make it safer, but they just keep congregating on the surface! For some reason, the Boss wants us to either capture or drive the most dangerous ones out of the crater. I don’t know what’s going on inside this building though, I swear.”

This was even worse than she thought.

Disrupting the ecosystem by driving out the more dangerous Pokemon? It would be a disaster if more of them got out of the crater. Besides, this Team Rainbow Rocket sounded dangerous. Who was their boss? What was their goal? Why the sudden interest in Area Zero? Who might have contacted them? Area Zero was supposed to be kept secret, even Briar's current published book didn’t mention it explicitly.

“The original Professor had a dream… of a world in which ancient Pokémon might live alongside present-day Pokémon in harmony.”

She stood in an elevator, talking to Professor Sada. Or at least, the robot that replaced her. No words would come out of her mouth.

“But these Pokémon’s powers seem to stem from a primal energy of the ancient past… and this energy has proved too terrible. Their very existence brings destruction to the ecological balance of this modern age.”

Professor Sada looked her in the eyes, her synthetic gaze devoid of emotion. In it, Juliana saw only her own reflection, eyes wide with shock and despair.

“I need you to stop me, Juliana.”

She suddenly felt pain in her stomach.

She slouched over, surprised. The grunt had punched her and used her time to run away into the cave as fast as she could. Juliana guessed that she had spaced out again. Cursing under her breath, she called out to a bewildered Koraidon. No doubt, the Pokémon was still wondering what had just happened.

Alarms suddenly blared out through the cave. She needed to get out quickly.

“Let’s go Koraidon. We’ve done all we could here, let’s head back home.”

She snapped one last picture of the building before jumping onto the Pokémon’s back. They zoomed through the cave in a blur, passing startled Rocket Grunts and Paradox Pokémon alike. Finally, Koraidon took off from the upper layers of Area Zero, and they were flying out of the crater.

She was blinded by the sudden light that surrounded them. What? It was daytime already? She checked the time on her phone.

Oh. She was already late for her meeting with Clavell and Geeta.

“Let’s hurry up, buddy, okay?”

“Agias!”

Ch9 - Behind Closed Doors

Juliana was pacing outside of Clavell's office, waiting for the old man to call her in as he finished debriefing Geeta. She was nervous, her mind racing.

She had her reasons for her nerves. Nevermind the thugs in Mesagoza, the mess in the crater - she had swung by her room to change clothes before the meeting, but was met with chaos.

The place had been a mess. Her mattress had been torn apart, her papers overturned, her desk thrown to the ground. Small souvenirs and gifts from her friends had been scattered everywhere, most were broken. And yet, nothing of value had been taken.

Someone had searched her room while she was out.

She couldn't stand the sight. Everything she loved, her safe place, broken. She couldn't stand her trophies and medals, still proudly displayed by the door. In their reflection, a shattered champion stared back at her with wide eyes

She had run, barely containing a whimper, until she reached Clavell's office. Pacing. Thinking. Someone searched her room. They were searching for something. Something they hadn't found.

A shiver ran down her spine, could it have been the Scarlet Book?

If they were, were they after the Professor's lab? Her research? The time machine? The lower depths of Paldea? If so, how did they know about it being the key? Or that she was the one holding on to it?

She shook her head. She didn't want to think about that now. Her mind was already a mess, she didn't need to go into that Bunnelby hole right now.

Someone had broken into a safe place. What if she had been in there? If this wasn't safe anymore, was her house at Cabo Poco?

At least, Mom wasn't there now. Juliana felt incredibly relieved that she was visiting some family back in Galar this month. This way, she didn't have to worry about her. Still, that meant that nowhere was safe anymore. If these people knew who she was and where she lived, what could they know too?

Her head felt dizzy. Juliana stopped her pacing and sat down in one of the chairs lined up against the wall.

At least, she didn't involve anyone else this time. Nemona, Arven, Penny - they should stay safe from all of this if she kept things to herself. And thank Arceus she had taken the book with her in Area Zero. Even now, her instincts didn't betray her.

Her phone pinged once. It was Clavell, telling her to come in.

She sighed. It was time for her to report what she saw. Hopefully this meeting would go well.

Juliana stood back up, took a moment to recompose herself, turned to the door and pushed it open. Standing in the doorway, she was greeted with an inquisitive look from Clavell. Sitting in front of his desk were Rika - laid back but professional as ever, with her feet on the desk and a pen tapping rhythmically against a clipboard - and Geeta, sitting as straight as an arrow with her gloved hands resting neatly on her lap. Juliana always had a hard time reading her.

"Juliana!" Clavell called out. "Please, take a seat. It is good to-"

"You look like shit, kid." Bluntly stated Rika.

Juliana blinked, caught off guard. Clavell sent the secretary a shocked look while Geeta chuckled lightly.

The director sighed. "...As I was saying: please, take a seat. It is good to see you, Juliana."

Juliana sat in a chair between Rika and Geeta, nodding politely to Clavell.

"So, Juliana. Please tell us what you saw yesterday."

She nodded. "Yes, sir."

She closed her eyes, recollecting the events of yesterday, taking a big breath before giving her report.

"I was having lunch in Mesagoza yesterday when a man wearing a black uniform with a rainbow R on it stole a student's Pokémon. I gave chase and defeated him and his partner in battle, retrieving the Pokémon. To my shame, the criminals were able to escape using another Pokémon to teleport away. After looking into it, I believe it was a Kadabra."

Clavell nodded. "Right. So you see Geeta, it is just as I told you. I-"

"If I may, sir," Juliana interrupted him, all eyes on her. "I wasn't finished."

“Oh! I apologize Juliana. Please, continue.” He gestured to her. She took a breath. *Here goes nothing*.

“...Thank you, sir. So, after they both left, I found some crystal dust on the floor where they were standing. To add to that, as you know, I have been spending the last few weeks capturing wild Paradox Pokémon that escaped the crater despite the League’s increased security. I even caught a very panicked Brute Bonnet a few hours after the events.”

Rika gulped guiltily as she was taking notes, while Geeta didn’t look even slightly fazed.

“So,” Juliana continued, “taking all that into account, I decided to investigate Area Zero for myself-”

“WHAT?!” Yelled Rika and Clavell in unison.

Juliana winced, she should have expected it. People didn’t like it when she was going alone in the most dangerous area of the region for some reason, even though she proved again and again that she could handle it.

“I know, I know, I’m sorry! But my clearance still hasn’t been revoked ever since the Terapagos incident, so I thought I might as well…”

“It’s okay.” Geeta said in a soothing voice. “It was to be expected.”

Rika raised an eyebrow. “Ma’am, are you saying that you knew this would happen?”

Geeta smiled at her. “Of course. It was obvious that our top-rated Champion rank trainer wouldn’t stand on the side considering the recent events. I thought it would be more productive to allow her access rather than get in her way.”

Rika huffed as she clicked her pen in frustration. “I understand. Though I can’t say that I approve.”

Geeta turned back to Juliana with a smile. “Please, continue.”

“Thanks, Boss. So, as I was saying, I decided to investigate Area Zero. I soon found out that I was right, the whole place is in chaos. Paradox Pokémon are restless, competing over territory and appearing where they shouldn’t.”

“Descending into the caves, I found a lot more of these criminals down there. They are the ones driving out the Paradox Pokémon out of the crater, for some unknown

reasons. They even have their headquarters set up in some new building, not too far from the Professor's lab."

"Anyway, I found out that they call themselves Team Rainbow Rocket. They are doing *something* down there, but I'm not sure what. I…"

She bit her lip, torn between honesty and protecting her only key to Sada's lab. Should she tell them about her room? She would then have to explain the fact that people were looking for the Scarlet Book… and admitting that she didn't report about it before. Maybe… maybe she wouldn't mention anything about it, just to be safe.

"I… I have my own reasons to believe that they're interested in using Terastallization as well as the late Professor's research for nefarious purposes. Unfortunately… I couldn't learn more before I had to come back here."

Rika whistled, impressed, some concern in her eyes. "Looks like you've been having a rough night, kid. Still, I'm glad you got out okay."

"Me too, Miss Juliana." Clavell re-adjusted his glasses. "Though, I am surprised that you would so openly admit to breaking at least three Academy rules in your statement."

Juliana reddened. She hadn't thought about that. "I- I'm sorry sir. But I couldn't just stay behind with what I knew."

Geeta put a firm hand on her shoulder. "It's okay, Clavell. No harm was done. Please, excuse her. I am going to explain everything anyway."

Clavell sighed, pinching his nose bridge in exasperation.

"Geeta please, you've heard Miss Juliana's testimony. You know you cannot trust-"

Geeta held up a hand, silencing him. "Please, Juliana. Allow me to introduce you to someone."

Juliana had a bad feeling about this. She watched as Geeta got up and opened the door.

Outside stood a tall man, wearing a black and red suit. The man had a taunting smirk on his face, and a small, embroidered Rainbow R on his jacket's pocket.

"Juliana," Geeta presented with a smile, "this is Giovanni, the leader of Team Rainbow Rocket."

Ch10 - The Room Where it Happens

“Juliana, this is Giovanni, the leader of Team Rainbow Rocket.”

Juliana watched, stunned as the man entered the office and closed the door behind him. She wanted to scream. WHAT?!

The old man sighed, exasperated. “Please Madam, do not call us that. I already told you, our name is the Rainbow Rocket Exploration Team.”

Geeta chuckled. “As I was saying, I believe there has been a misunderstanding. Mister Giovanni here is the leader of an archeological exploration team related to Miss Briar’s research. I have been granting them permission to study the Crater and its Pokémon after an official request a few weeks ago.”

“I sincerely apologize for my men’s bad behavior. The individual that stole that poor girl’s Pokemon has been expelled from the project.” The man bowed before her, though she could swear the most menacing look had just flashed on his face for a second. “I beg you not to judge our entire group by the bad actions of only one foolish man.”

Juliana couldn’t believe it. “B-but the Pokemon!”

“I assure you that everything we do is going towards research for containment of the Paradox Pokemon in a more appropriate environment.” He turned to Geeta. “So far, the data shows that our approach is working. Miss Juliana rare sightings might be due to her intrusion into the crater, disturbing the fragile ecosystem.”

Geeta turned to hear with a smile. “It is true, I have seen this data for myself. You see Juliana? Everything was just a huge misunderstanding. I can promise that Paradox Pokémon won’t be an issue in the future. The criminal you stopped is no longer part of the organization.”

She couldn’t believe it.

Giovanni brought back his piercing gaze to her.

“Say, I’ve heard that you helped Miss Briar with her studies on Area Zero. What a fantastic young girl! Have you read her latest book? About the depths of Area Zero?”

She was stunned. How- that part wasn’t even available to the public yet!

“Of course she had to anonymize the students that went with her. Still, I found them to be the most fascinating part of her book.”

“What do you think about the young girl from the Paldean League that went down with her? The one that was responsible for her safety? How do you think she felt when that boy foolishly decided to terastallize Terapagos?”

“I… I-I”

“Yes, I’m sure you’re right. She only cared about her own safety. Else, she would have never allowed the expedition to go as far as it did. But you know what they say, you can’t make an omelet without cracking a few eggs. Or, you know, discover unfathomable power without endangering a few lives. I’m glad she was selfish.”

Her breathing accelerated. Was… was he right? Had she been selfish? After all, she never saw how bad Kieran felt until she was too late. If- if she had been paying more attention to others back then, then…

No! Stop! He was trying to get into her head! She still had the pictures!

“Geeta, ma’am! I have proof that things are worse than you think in Area Zero!”

She could have sworn, Giovanni had just a plain evil smirk now. Geeta didn’t notice it and just frowned.

“Oh? What is it?”

“I- I took pictures on my phone while I was down there! I recorded it all,” Juliana took out her phone, frantically navigating to the album app. “I-It’s right the-”

It was all gone.

Every single photo that she took in Area Zero had been wiped out. Completely erased. Her fingers trembled over the empty gallery - the proof of every risk she’d taken, wiped clean by unseen hands.

How-

“Well, one thing is clear to me Geeta.” Giovanni said. Juliana could swear she could hear malice in his voice. “Based on what I’ve heard, I believe the poor girl might be overworking herself to a dangerous point.”

Geeta didn’t say a thing, giving her a disappointed look.

“N-No! I know what I saw you don’t understand! My room, the book-”

“Juliana.” Geeta interrupted, her tone sounding final. “You are hereby relieved of all of your Champion Rank duties, effective immediately. Please, do take time to rest and heal.”

She froze. Her world shattered around her in an instant.

“Now.” Giovanni said. “I believe we needed to talk about the next step in our studies.” Geeta nodded and led him out of the office. Rika got up and put a hand on her shoulder.

“Sorry kid. If that makes you feel any better, I don’t trust the guy either. Still, Geeta’s right. You need to take it easy, let us adults handle the situation for now.” She had a calm smile on her face. “Please, come back to us even stronger. Poppy misses you.”

She followed Geeta out of the door, leaving only her and Clavell in the office.

She didn’t say a word, looking at the door, shell shocked.

“...I apologize Miss Juliana. I have been harboring the same concerns as you about that man for a while now, and believed a testimony from you would sway La Primera’s mind. I… I am saddened to admit that I was wrong. Please, do rest. Your classes for the day are canceled.”

She couldn’t believe it. Shock gave way to anger while her mind wrapped up on what had just happened.

“You…” Her voice cracked. She turned and looked at Clavell with watery eyes. “You don’t believe me either, huh?!”

“I… I am sorry Miss Juliana. Though I admire your tenacity, I cannot reasonably believe claims of a shadow organization aiming to seize control of the region without evidence. Professor Sada’s research is safe, I’ve made sure of it.”

It’s at this moment that Juliana’s heart broke. He didn’t believe her either.

Geeta, she could understand. The woman was both hard to read and really naive, she didn’t mind. It hurt her so much, but it was okay.

Rika hurt even more, but she could handle it.

But Clavell? Clavell had been on her side from the start. The old man was with her as she grew, as she raided Star Bases. He gave her a Pokemon and a purpose. He always had her back.

And now?

Now she was alone.

Why did she even bother? She was so, so tired of it all. Area Zero, the Professor, all weighed so heavily on her shoulder for so long now.

She turned around and walked out of the office, ignoring Clavell as he called out her name multiple times.

She ignored Penny, Nemona and Arven as they found her around a corridor, asking why there were tears in her eyes.

She ignored everyone and everything, and released Koraidon right in front of the Academy Gate. She got on his back and flew away.

As far as possible.

Ch11 - Leap of Faith

Juliana felt lost.

She sighed, lying in the grass. What was she to do?

She felt bad. Really bad for walking out on Clavell and her friends. Now that she was calmer, she deeply regretted her reaction.

Still, the sting of betrayal was deep.

After flying away with Koraidon, aimless, she had somehow ended up in Alfornada. Maybe an automatism, the city of the psychic gym had to be one of her favorites in the region. She adored the mosaics on the walls of the gym.

She had stopped in the city for a while, waiting for her Pokémon to get a check-up at the local Center, all the while sitting on a bench and trying to contain the storm inside of her. Self-blame, guilt, failure and shock still clouding her mind.

She didn't meet the nurse's eyes when she was handed back her team. Though, she could feel the concern and scrutiny. She hated it.

She was Juliana, Paldea's latest star and treasure! She couldn't afford to show weakness. Not even now.

So, she had forced herself to calm down. She left the town on foot as soon as possible, heading to a waterfall nearby, and set up camp. There, she let out her team to feed them, prepared herself a sandwich - her first meal of the day - and lied down in the grass, staring at the noon sun.

Even now, she could feel them all around her. Her team, her family. She knew what everyone was doing even without looking.

Koraidon was resting by the waterfall, likely still tired after a long night and morning of non-stop flying. Ogerpon and Tinkaton were running around, their steps loud on the grass, playing a game of catch with a ball.

Lying next to her, she could feel the warmth of Skeledirge, humming with a comforting low purr. Her first partner always was able to sense her distress and ease her easily. She could guess he had a lazy eye open, watching over Terapagos who was marvelling loudly over every blade of grass with awe.

Clodsire, finally, was sleeping soundly in her arms. While a powerful Pokémon in his own right - she often bonded with Rika over how strong and cute their respective

Clodsire were - hers was mostly content serving as an oversized plushie. Juliana kept that a secret though, that would ruin her ‘tough girl’ image that she tried so hard to build over the years.

Juliana closed her eyes. With how tired she felt, sleep would come easily to her. With the proximity and comfort of her team, she tried to relax and empty her thoughts.

Maybe Geeta, Rika and Clavell had a point. Maybe she did need to take it easy.

This felt good. This felt right. It was just her, and her team.

…

…

…

She knew what she saw down there.

She still remembered vividly the look of disappointment on Geeta’s face. Clavell and her friends’ concern.

She felt so guilty. So weak, powerless. She was so mad at herself for worrying them, for disappointing La Primera. Did she really mess up and forgot to take these damn pictures?

That was not who she was. She was supposed to be strong! Fearless! Her friends didn’t need yet another burden in their lives- her role was to be their support!

But- but she failed even that. Where was she now? Sulking, alone, in a city as far away from them as possible. Ignoring their concerns, their calls.

Arceus, Giovanni was right. She **was** selfish. Even now, even with the whole region in danger, she could only feel sorry for herself while lying on the ground.

But she was so tired. As time went on, her drifting mind began to be overshadowed by the nothingness. The exhaustion of the past days and nights caught up to Juliana.

And, without even realizing it, she cried herself to sleep.

Juliana was brought out of a dreamless rest by a distant crash.

She jolted awake, feeling disoriented by the surrounding darkness. Looking up at the night sky, a full moon illuminated the windy plains with a pale light.

Sleeping Pokémon surrounded Juliana. All her team sans Ogerpon had amassed around her, their slumbering form topping each other in a mess of legs, tails and an oversized metallic hammer. The Ogre stood on a nearby rock, the crystals of her mask shining brightly under the light of the moon. She stood attentive towards the town, a guard protecting the group in the dark of the night.

Juliana carefully maneuvered to join her without waking anyone. She was still hearing strange distant noises, but couldn't tell where it all came from. Ogerpon stood motionless, worried over something.

"What is it girl?" Juliana murmured gently.

The Pokemon pointed at Alfornada in the distance. Wha- oh.

That was a Roaring Moon perched on top of the League Building.

She sighed. That wasn't good.

The Pokémon was agitated, roaring loudly and clawing at the air like it was fending off ghosts. Wild Pokémon cleared out in panic, in turn causing chaos in the city. A crowd had gathered near the towering edifice, curious about the situation but still fearful of the uncontrollable Pokémon. Local League officials and trainers were trying their best to handle the situation, but no one would move too close towards the Paradox Pokémon.

Another roar drew a cry of fear from a child in the crowd. The Roaring Moon looked frenetic, panicked. Dangerous. In this state, it was only a matter of time before he would attack someone.

Juliana didn't think, she had to take care of the situation.

She woke up her team with the help of Ogerpon, recalled everyone but Koraidon to their Pokéballs and rushed towards the crowd, not bothering to clean up camp.

"Everyone!" She called as she reached the people. "Please, back away from the Pokémon! I work for the League, please let me handle this!" She raised both her hands, making sure that anyone could see that she was wearing the League's gloves. Thankfully, Geeta didn't take that from her either.

The people listened to her, and thankfully the League staff did too. Either Geeta didn't inform them of her time-out, or they were too scared to care. As they parted

ways, she walked to the foot of the building and climbed on Koraidon's back, directing him to fly gently to the Pokémon's level.

What she didn't expect was the Paradox Pokémon to fly away at max speed as soon as she came into view.

"Wha- Koraidon! Don't let it get away!"

"Agias!"

Koraidon chased after the Pokémon, matching its speed.

The way the Roaring Moon was behaving was weird, she pondered as howling wind filled her ears. The ever aggressive dragon was just, what, running away from a challenge? On top of that the way it flew, in a straight line, without any attempt at throwing them off, it was as if it had a specific destination in mind. Like it wanted to be followed.

If she didn't know any better, she'd say the Roaring Moon belonged to a trainer.

Wait-

"Now, *Moonblast*!"

Multiple voices rang at once in the dark. Suddenly, about thirty light orbs were flying from the ground, all directed directly at them.

"Koraidon!" She cried.

The Winged King did his best to avoid the incoming barrage, but there wasn't much that he could do at this speed without harming his passenger. A few orbs missed them, but most of them hit.

"Agiaaaaaaaaaaaaa!"

Koraidon faltered and lost consciousness, and together with Juliana, they fell from the night sky.

You would think the worst part about falling is hitting the ground.

In Juliana's opinion, you would be wrong.

Sure, physical pain isn't particularly pleasant. But there is something even worse in *knowing* that it is coming. And that there is nothing you can do.

When she and Koraidon fell from the sky, they were already travelling at high speed. Thus, all that momentum launched her towards the treeline like a bullet.

And for a few seconds, the only thing she could think was *I can't do anything about this*.

For a few seconds she saw the ground grow ever closer as she felt weightlessness. Not in control. Powerless.

It was terrifying.

The first branch she hit was like coming back to a harsh reality. It was light but the pain was sharp. She got the sense to try and protect her head with her arms after that.

She hit a second, then a third, the fourth was the only one thick enough to stop her momentum. She hit it hard and started to fall vertically as opposed to horizontal.

She hit another branch on the way down with her sides, then her back, then her left arm. She tried to hold on to something - anything - but the motion made her body go off course and her head bashed into a tree trunk.

So, in comparison, hitting the ground was a relief.

She landed on the soft grass with a loud thump, followed soon by another. Heavier.

Everything hurt.

She laid there for an unknown time, at first overwhelmed by the pain.

As soon as the shock passed however, she opened her eyes.

She was lying next to a tree, alone under the night moon in the wilderness near Alfornada. She tried pushing herself up- but stopped immediately when pain spiked in her left arm. She collapsed back to the ground instantly.

Her head hurt like hell, pounded like Gorythmic at a rock concert. The world wouldn't stay still before her eyes. She lifted a hand to her forehead and felt something sticky. Blood.

That couldn't be good.

She tried to get up a second time, this time helping herself up with the nearby tree. Her vision slowly stopped swimming, she could finally get a better sense of her surroundings.

She had landed in a clearing, somewhere in the wilds. Shadows and bushes obscured the treeline, leaving her with only the view of the wild grass brushing under the wind in the moonlight. An eerie silence hung in the air. There wasn't a sound. None from her attacker, but none from the wild Pokémon of the area either.

Something of a bright red laid at the center of the clearing.

Koraidon.

He was lying there, fainted.

"Koraidon!" Juliana exclaimed. She took off her bag and put it in front of her, rummaging through it.

She paused.

Only now did she realize the fall had damaged her clothing.

Nothing too bad, sure, mainly some tear in her sleeves that left angry red marks on her skin. But her gloves. Her *League issued* gloves- the last claim she had to her previous Champion status.

One had fallen off during her fall. The other had a wide tear all across the League logo.

She forgot to breathe for a moment. Then shook her head. Now was not the time. After searching some more, she finally found it. Koraidon's Pokéball.

"So, what have we here?" A voice suddenly rang through the dark.

She froze as multiple Rainbow Rocket Grunts stepped out from the dark, surrounding her and Koraidon. Juliana cursed under her breath. She didn't hear them coming.

Still, she painfully got up, her knees shaking as she used the tree trunk as support. Juliana recalled Koraidon, stuffing the Pokéball into her bag on the ground. Her downed partner in safety, she allowed herself to ease up the tension a little.

She stepped between the grunts and her back, shooting them with a defiant look.

Juliana wasn't going down without a fight.

The men merely stood there, motionless, watching her without a hint of aggressiveness. They were here just to prevent her from leaving, she realized. Then, in front of her, two of them moved aside to let a tall figure into the circle. Hands in his pockets, a haunting mocking grin on his face.

It was Giovanni.

"Hello again, Juliana." He said, his voice dripping with venom. "I hope you've fared well since our last encounter."

"Fuck you." She responded. Her voice felt raw.

Giovanni smirked in amusement, raising his chin.

"Now, that's not a proper way to speak to a kind man such as myself. I'm sure Miss Geeta would be disappointed in you right now."

She shot him a dark look. His expression became serious.

"Look, I get it kid. You're full of rage. You yearn for power. The power to stand up for yourself. The power to protect the innocent, to punish the wicked. I know the type. And that," he crossed his hands behind his back. "That is why I have an offer for you."

Juliana put a hand to her belt, hovering in front of her Pokéballs.

"Why not join Team Rocket? I see great potential in you Juliana. I can give you everything you want, and more. So?"

She spat blood at his feet.

He glared at her ominously for a beat. Then, the same mocking smile from earlier went back to his face.

"Ha! A fine answer! Such a shame, none of these fools would hold a candle to you. But you still have something I want." He snapped his fingers.

Two grunts approached her from the left. She sent out Ogerpon.

"Stay back!" She warned.

The both of them froze, unsure of what to do as the Ogre Pokémon stood with a club in hand and protective bloodlust visible beneath her mask. Yet, Giovanni ignored her and continued on.

“You see, I really want to get my hands on the famous Professor’s research.” He explained. “Paradox Pokemon, like your precious Koraidon, are an invaluable asset.” He snapped again and two more grunts marched toward her, stopped this time by Tinkaton.

“But more than anything, I want what lies beneath it all. What I want is the heart of Area Zero, said capable of granting any wish.”

He snapped his fingers once more, and every grunt now came marching at her. The whole team emerged from their Pokéballs at once to protect their trainer. Including…

“And what I want, I take.” He said, an ominous smile on his face. Behind him, a pale human-sized Pokemon with a long wagging tail came out of the dark. It hovered ominously over the ground, an eerie intelligence in its piercing gaze.

“Mewtwo, give me Terapagos.”

The Pokémon’s eyes glowed and a powerful psychic wave sent her flying back into the tree.

Juliana recovered as quickly as she could, still reeling over the Pokémon’s tremendous power. Her whole team was at her side in an instant, the grunts having jumped back to the shadows to avoid the attack. She could *feel* its eyes piercing through her. Intelligent. With a plan.

It sent chills down her spine. This thing wasn’t natural, at all.

Skeledirge launched a *Shadow Ball*. The Pokémon diverted the attack, sending it hurling into Clodsire. Tinkaton and Ogerpon jumped, weapons in hand, one going high and the other low. A psychic blast sent them both crashing to the ground.

Terapagos stood in front of her, unsure what to do.

A plan, the only plan, quickly formed within Juliana’s mind. The Pokémon was Psychic type, but its raw power meant nothing on her team could match it, even with a type advantage.

She had to match power with power.

She called back Skeledirge, Clodsire, Tinkaton and Ogerpon. Terapagos was on the same page as her, readying himself for his transformation.

Juliana crouched to her bag, fishing out the Tera Orb she had put to the side a couple days earlier.

Now was its time.

She held it tight, readying a throw.

The crystals reflected the blinding light of Teragos' final form as the cave shook.

No- she wouldn't be distracted by old memories now. She strengthened her grip on the Orb.

Oddly enough, the psychic Pokemon wasn't looking at her Pokemon. It was looking at her.

Crystals fell from the ceiling, threatening to crush her.

"THIS is the hidden treasure of Area Zero!" yelled a deranged woman behind her.

Her hand was shaking. Her whole body was trembling. Power coursed into the orb, crystal dust absorbed by it. She had to hold on to it. She didn't notice a grunt reaching for her bag behind her.

An explosion of raw power shook the cave further. Energy was pulsing everywhere. The boy was going to be hurt by a blast, she wasn't fast enough to reach him in time.

She threw a Pokéball in desperation.

She threw the Tera Orb in desperation.

She aimed true. Koraidon came out in his fighting form just in time, thankfully saving the boy.

The Orb stopped in the air, seized by an invisible force.

"Huh!?"

Across the field, the strange Pokemon held out a hand in the air as her Tera Orb slowly made its way to Giovanni, surrounded by a purple glow.

Juliana quickly realized what was happening. She needed to stop it.

“Terapagos, use-”

“*Focus Blast*!” Commanded Giovanni.

Terapagos never had time to react before a ball of fighting type energy hit him, easily fainting him in one go.

The man threw a Masterball at her Pokemon before she could process any of it. The ball didn’t even shake before making a clicking noise.

She- she couldn’t believe it. Terapagos was…?

Something in her, something she didn’t even realize could break, broke. Juliana felt herself lose focus. She had lost a piece of herself.

The man laughed.

“I thank you for your contribution to Team Rainbow Rocket, ex-Champion. This has been entertaining.” A grunt approached him and gave him a bag- **her** bag! Did- did they swipe it during the battle!?

“Your Pokémon will be a great addition to our cause.” He taunted. “We are going to bring great change to the Paldea region thanks to you!”

No! He- he had Koraidon and Terapagos! The Scarlet Book, the key to Sada’s lab! She couldn’t-

Another psychic attack sent her back against the tree. Giovanni turned his back on her while she was still reeling in pain. He called back Mewtwo to a Masterball.

“Now then, I must take my leave. This region will kneel, and you won’t be there to see it. Goodbye, Juliana. It has not been a pleasure.”

And as he marched into the dark, she heard him say one last thing.

“... Get rid of the body.”

“Sure thing boss!”

Giovanni disappeared into the night.

“So, how do we go about it?” A man spoke.

“I dunno, never killed a child before y’know.” Another answered.

“Yeah, me neither.” A third commented.

The grunts argued among themselves over how best to end her life. None of them paid attention to her. After all, they had already won. She was battered and bruised, broken in body and spirit, holding herself up against a tree.

That was it. This was the end. She was going to die here.

Juliana felt pathetic. Weak. All of this, just to end up here. Koraidon. Terapagos. She had failed them. She couldn’t keep her silent promise to Sada.

At least, she thought, they had a good run.

She closed her eyes. Let herself fall back to the ground.

Memories of past adventures came to her.

Her first battle with Nemona on the beach behind her house. Defending Penny against bullies at the Academy and bonding over shared pop-culture references afterwards. Eating a sandwich with Arven after defeating a Titan Pokémon.

Raiding Team Star Bases and meeting the bosses. Witnessing Mabostiff’s recovery with every new spice discovered. Beating Geeta at the League, and then battling Nemona again in the center of Mesaledo under the encouragement of a wide crowd.

If it all ended here. If this was all she could do, her legacy. Would she be content?

Her eyes watered. She couldn’t stop the flood of memories from coming.

Lying in the grass next to Nemona during a break from training, her exhaustion melting away at the sight of her smile.

Playing a fighting game with Penny, losing badly, then throwing the pop-corn bowl at her in retaliation.

Sitting with Arven under the moon, late into the night after a picnic, hearing him talk about memories of his mother with a bittersweet tightness in her throat.

… No.

She… she wanted more.

It felt selfish, but she wanted **more** of this life.

She wanted to laugh and cry with them each step of the way. To live for them. To live with them.

She felt stupid for ever considering giving that up. The roar of life pulsed ever stronger within her heart, galvanized by the pain and agony that still left a tear through it.

It couldn't end here. I won't, she decided.

She still had friends waiting for her. She wouldn't let Ogerpon lose her trainer yet again. She would come back and apologize to Clavell. They would live, and laugh, and cry together all over again. She would meet Kieran again, make amends- truly this time. She would travel with them all, to her family in Galar, to other regions.

She would survive this.

She opened her eyes and was surprised to find tears flooding her cheeks. Fortunately, all the grunts were discussing among themselves. No one was paying attention to her. She dried her face with her sleeve as she slowly got back up, using the tree as a support. Her legs screamed in protest, she ignored them.

Juliana looked a final time to the grunts.

And then, she bolted.

"Hey, where is- HEY GET BACK HERE!"

And the grunts ran after her.

"This way!" A voice called from behind her.

Juliana ignored it, jumping over a rock as she ran through the trees.

The grunts were chasing her. Closely. Even with a head-start, her aching legs and sore arm were slowing her down.

She evaded a branch. Thankfully, the movement made it so a *Moonblast* moved over her shoulder, crashing harmlessly into a tree.

This was bad. She was beginning to feel tired, with too many attackers to fend them all off with just her Pokémon team. Her only hope was to break through the forest and head to town. Alfornada shouldn't be too far now.

A bigger rock came into view. She ran on top of it and jumped down, rolling under another *Moonblast*. Getting back up in a flash she saw an opening through the trees. She rushed into it-

And stopped as soon as she crossed past the woods.

Just in time to not fall off a cliff.

That- it- it shouldn't- it-

She cursed loudly. She had run the wrong way in the confusion and ended up at the opposite of her destination.

She looked down. Waves were crashing hard against the rocky shore. The jump was high. Very high.

"Hey!" A voice rang out.

Multiple grunts burst through the forest, surrounding her against the cliffside.

"You've got nowhere to run, kid!" A man called with a mischievous grin.

Juliana considered her options.

The grunts were creeping closer, slower now, their faces betraying their ill intent.

She sighed. She could only see one way out.

She had to risk it.

The first guy was still watching her. His eyes widened as she turned her back on them. As he realized what she was about to do.

"Hey- WAIT!" He shouted.

Juliana ignored him. Ignored everything.

She took a few steps back.

Then she ran,

and jumped.

Juliana woke up underwater.

Sinking. Drowning.

She panicked, thrashed uselessly against the tide. She couldn't see anything beyond precious air bubbles and overwhelming darkness. She didn't know what way was up or down.

She couldn't breathe. She was losing conscience. Water filled her lungs.

Everything was a blur. She remembered falling from the cliff, then hitting the water. She had passed out briefly.

A noise rang muffled from her belt, accompanied by a bright flash. Her vision was fading as a familiar brown figure pulled on her left arm.

The sudden pain was enough to bring back full consciousness. Her eyes focused on the figure. Clodsire. The Pokémon was dragging her to the surface.

Hope filled her heart. She held onto him with her other arm and pedaled with her feet, letting the Pokémon take her back to safety.

She gasped for air as they emerged on a rocky shore, coughing water. Clodsire laid at her side with a concerned expression while other flashes illuminated the night. Tinkaton, Skeledirge and Ogerpon.

"I- I'm fine, everyone," She said as soon as her lungs were finally full of air. She petted Clodsire with a tired hand, reassuring him. "Th-thanks, b-buddy. You saved my life."

Juliana then tried to get back up - but her arms buckled under her. She breathed heavily. Too tired and injured to even think straight. The cold was overwhelming. She was shivering with her feet still underwater.

The world swam around her. Everything that happened was a blur. Skeledirge grumbled, taking command over the team as their trainer was unresponsive. He headed to a nearby cave as Ogerpon and Tinkaton picked her up together, carrying the girl, with Clodsire following close behind. A powerful roar echoed from the mouth of the cave as a wild Tera-Bug type Hawlucha flew out in terror.

She was brought inside the now emptied cavity and propped up against a wall by her Pokémon, curling up instinctively in the cold as Skeledirge intensified his flames to try and warm her. Her clothes were soaked. She could feel her consciousness slipping again.

Juliana was tempted to give in here and there. To surrender control to the nothingness. Until something vibrated in her pocket.

Surprised, she fished out her cell phone. She had completely forgotten about the device, now the only thing she had left besides her Team's Pokéballs. She frantically tried to turn it on. Thankfully, it had survived the water.

Breathing heavily and trying - failing - to still her shaking hands, she opened her phone app and clicked her last contact. She put the phone to her ear, praying and waiting for an answer.

"Hello?" A voice asked on the other end.

Finally! Her heart pounded in her chest.

"P-Penny! It's… It's Juliana." She answered.

"JULIANA!" Penny shouted back. "Where have you been! We were so worried we looked for you all day and-"

"Penny." She interrupted her. "Penny I- I messed up. Bad." Juliana tried, and failed to contain a sob. She was shivering, so cold, so much hurt. "Can- can you track my location from my phone?"

"Shit- Jules, are you okay? I- I can do that but-"

"I need help. Medical help. Only… Only tell people you absolutely trust."

"What!? Juliana! What is happening!" She couldn't make sense out of Penny's words anymore as she lost her grip on reality, her consciousness finally overshadowed by the darkness.

"'m sorry Sada." She mumbled. "couldn't… keep 'em safe."

Everything faded to black.

Ch12 - Awakening

Juliana woke up.

Her eyes shot open as the dreamspace and the real world blended together for a moment, heart pounding as her reality set back into place.

It was just a dream, she reassured herself.

She winced immediately. Her head throbbed, the sudden light was painful to her eyes, her body ached.

She rose up slowly. Her mind was still groggy, she wasn't sure what had happened last night. And now she was…

Actually, she wasn't sure where she was.

For one thing, she was in bed. She was sure that she hadn't fallen asleep in one. Then, there was the fact that she was in a bedroom. Not hers, and certainly not one from the Academy. It was something nice, cozy. Early morning light filtered through the window, with the sound of chittering Fletchlings outside.

She gave herself a quick once over. Unrecognizable clothing. She was wearing a white and blue striped pajama obviously too big for her size, with no pockets.

She tensed up. Her Pokemon weren't with her. She didn't have her phone either.

Her breath quickened. The events of last night came to her in a painful flash- the ambush, Mewtwo, the cliff. Koraidon. Terapagos. And now, her other Pokemon were…

Stop.

She didn't have the luxury of having yet another panic attack.

Think girl, you were attacked and passed out in a cave, and now you woke up in an unknown place. What can you do?

She scanned the room and found a baseball bat.

That will do.

She got out of bed and slowly made her way to the bat. Her movements were slow, sloppy. She almost tripped and fell a few times, her legs felt weak somehow.

Still, she had to get out of here. Wherever it was.

Juliana grabbed the bat and held on to the wall, recovering her breath after what felt like a tremendous effort.

She heard footsteps approaching.

Using the rest of her strength, she slid against the wall to hide by the door, forcing herself to slow her breathing.

Someone was coming.

The handle moved.

The door opened, revealing a man.

She didn't even wait to see who it was before she hit him in the back of the head with all her strength, knocking him out-

"OW! What the hell Juliana?" He exclaimed.

"Huh?"

The man turned to her and-

"Arven?! What- How-"

In front of her, Arven sighed, rubbing his head.

"Hey, buddy, please drop the plastic bat before you hit me again." He complained. "That hurts, you know?"

"I- I don't-" The plastic bat hit the ground with a squeaky noise.

Juliana was hyperventilating. Her legs felt weak, she could barely stand. Arven caught her before she felt herself collapsing.

"Wow- hey shhh, calm down buddy! I'm fine! See? Now let's get you back to bed, okay? Then I'm going to get everyone."

"E- everyone?" She wondered in confusion.

“Yup!” He gave her a bright smile. “You know, Penny, Nemona, Director Clavell… Oh, and Nurse Miriam from the Academy! Penny’s the one who called us all last night and guided us to that cave you were in.”

His expression grew somber as he helped her back to the bed. “We- we’re really worried about you bud’, you know? Miss Miriam patched you up, but you, the state you were in, I…”

Juliana let him guide her without resistance. Her neutral expression hid the storm of shame and guilt brewing inside.

“... And where are we?” She asked as she properly sat on the mattress, fidgeting.

“Nemona’s mansion.” He answered easily. “Her parents aren’t home and all the staff are on paid leave, it’s just us.” That explained the pajamas, she thought.

Arven’s expression turned sorrowful. “Your mom couldn’t be here either, Clavell told us she was on a trip back to Galar, sorry.”

She forced a smile, hiding the emptiness inside her. “It’s okay, I don’t want to worry her anyway.”

He gave her a worried look.

“Yeah, we’ll talk about that later, okay little buddy?”

She wasn’t sure what he meant by that, so she shrugged. Arven sighed loudly.

“Okay, now I’m going to get everybody. Stay here okay? And please, don’t hit them with a bat?”

She chuckled. “No promises!”

He patted her gently on the back with a smile and began making his way out of the room.

He was at the door when she called out.

“Wait! What about my Pokemon?”

He tensed up, his hand on the doorknob. Arven turned to her.

“Skeledirge, Tinkaton and Ogerpon are resting. They spent most of the night guarding you and keeping you warm. Clodsire is fine though, he’s waiting for you in the living room.”

He didn’t mention Koraidon nor Terapagos. The way he stood, it was obvious that he didn’t want to break the subject just yet.

“Can…” Her voice cracked, barely audible. “Can you please bring Clodsire back, too?”

He smiled brightly and gave her a thumbs up.

“Sure thing buddy!”

With that, he left the room.

So.

The room felt empty now that she was alone, left with her thoughts and memories.

She felt like shit. Her hands clenched her clothes as she stopped herself from breaking down.

She attacked her friend now, with a plastic bat of all things. Her team had saved her, and it had taken a toll on them. Her friends had seen her injured, they were worried, they were going to see through the mask. They were going to see the true her. They would leave. And worse yet, she had gotten them involved anyway.

How pathetic was she?

Koraidon. Terapagos. They were truly gone.

Her breath hitched, her mind overwhelmed with a spiral of guilt, shame, anxiety and pure despair.

Her hands turned into fists as she wiped her eyes. She wouldn’t allow it, she decided.

She’d get back up. She’d get them back on her own. She would make sure everyone would be safe. No matter the cost. Her Pokémon, her friends… Everyone.

Juliana forced herself to take a deep breath. She had to calm down before they got here.

She looked around for a distraction. So, this was Nemona's bedroom, huh? And from the clothes, she guessed Nemona's pajamas.

Now that she took it all in without the panic and confusion clouding her mind, it was obvious. Posters on the wall showcased famous trainers and depictions of Pokémon battles. Bags of premium Pokémon food and pro expensive stuff were neatly arranged around the room. Various plushes contrasted with the veritable wall of trophies and medals. A shelf contained a whole library of complicated looking books, all with various signs of use and old age, lined up against a desk littered with opened notebooks.

Juliana shook her head with a smile, thinking about her friend. The action reminded her of her headache. She still felt a little dizzy, but it was much better than when she first woke up.

She then noticed a Pawmot plush at the end of the bed. She smiled, it was so much like Nemona to have that. The girl didn't play favorites with her Pokémon, but it was obvious to anyone how close she felt to her ace.

Her expression soured, her heart caught in her throat.

She… She hoped Koraidon and Terapagos were okay.

The sound of approaching footsteps brought her out of her thoughts. She quickly put on her best smile as the door opened.

Her friends were there.

She waved. "Hi-"

She didn't have the time to say more than that before she was suddenly tackled by a fast object.

"JULIANA!" The bullet shouted into her ear. "I'm- I'm so glad you're okay…"

Nemona held her into a Bewear hug, the both of them now lying on the bed. Behind them, Clavell hid a smile as Penny snapped a picture on her phone.

"Nemona, don't rush her, she's still recovering you know." Arven admonished, Clodsire in his arms.

Nemona blinked for a few seconds, processing.

"Oh! Sorry!"

She stood up with a sheepish smile and rejoined the others.

Clavell cleared his throat. “Well, with that said, we are all glad to see you well Miss Juliana.”

She forced a serene expression. “Thank you Director! A-and thank you everyone. I'm sorry to have worried you so much.”

Clavell frowned. “Miss Juliana, I-”

He was interrupted as the door slammed open, revealing Nurse Miriam, carrying a huge case.

“Sorry, I’m late! Now that you’re awake, let's get you checked out!”

Clavell turned to her. “Miriam please, we were discussing…”

He trailed off under the nurse's threatening glare. Miriam clapped her hands happily and walked over to Juliana with a smile.

“So! About the checkup.” She turned to the crowd. “Everybody out. Leave the Clodsire here.”

“...And that’s that! You’re good to go, Juliana.” Miriam said as she put back tools inside her case.

“R-really?” Juliana couldn’t believe it. That felt too easy.

“Of course you’ll have to take it easy.” The nurse answered without stopping. “You only suffered minor physical injuries, but it **will** get worse if you put too much strain on your body! You’ll be having headaches for a while and you’ll have to rest your arm to let it heal. You’ll also feel dizzy for the next few days, but that can be remedied with medication.”

Juliana looked away, hugging Clodsire.

“...Oh. Okay, that’s fine.”

Miriam turned to look at her with a knowing glint in her eyes but went to knock on the door, letting everyone know to come back in. She repeated to them what she had told her.

Clavell bowed. “Thank you for everything, Miriam. I know that all of this isn’t exactly in your job description, but…”

She smiled. “It’s my pleasure! After all I owe a lot to Juliana, I couldn’t exactly look away even if I wanted to.” She started to leave the room but stopped at the door.

“Say, Juliana if I may, where did these injuries even come from? I’ve never seen anything this bad at the Academy…”

“Oh! Um, well, I **did** crash into a tree and jumped off a cliff.”

“WHAT!?” Several voices shouted in unison. She winced, yeah she should have expected it this time too.

Miriam just giggled and waved as she left the room, having accomplished what she wanted to.

“Okay.” Penny took a deep breath. “I know we planned to ease you into it but I just need to know for my sanity. Juliana, what the fuck happened to you?”

“Langage!” complained Arven.

Clavell cleared his throat, his professional posture betrayed by the concern in his eyes. “Despite Miss Penny's frankness, I do believe we all agree. Please, Juliana, tell us what happened.”

Juliana collected her thoughts and concentrated on stroking Clodsire. She owed them part of the truth, at least. Pushing past the lump in her throat, she slid back into ‘Champion mode’ as Penny would call it. Her entire world was reduced to petting Clodsire. Looking at them, or even acknowledging their presence, would be too much right now. She recounted the facts in a detached but professional manner, hiding the storm inside of her and wincing at every stutter. From her expedition into Area Zero, up until…

“... Team Rainbow Rocket ambushed us. I- I fell right into their trap, I couldn’t do a thing. Giovanni just unleashed this powerful Pokémon, stole my bag with the key to Sada’s Lab, kidnapped Koraidon and Terapagos, and left me for dead. So- so I was forced to escape by jumping off a cliff and… here I am.”

An eerie silence filled the room as she ended her report. Eventually, Juliana raised her head to her friends, cautionally curious of their lack of reaction. She was met with a mix of stunned, worried and pained expressions. Somehow feeling even more guilty than before, she turned away.

“I-I’m sorry for worrying you all,” she confessed. “You’ve done so, so much for me and I don’t know if I can ever repay you.”

“... Bud’ what are you talking about?” Arven asked, frowning. “You don’t have to repay us for anything.”

She shook her head. Not a good idea, it made her dizzy.

“But I’ve worried you all so much, you even had to bring me here from that cave and…”

“Juliana come on, you’ve saved our asses more than once.” Penny tilted her head. “The least we can do is watch your back.”

You were only ever in danger because of me, she thought. *And I still couldn’t save Sada*.

“...I guess you’re right.” She lied and nodded, holding one arm with the other. It was clear she didn’t convince anyone. “Now, I still have a job to do.”

She started to get up weakly, her knees shaking. Her head was spinning, she didn’t even notice Nemona rushing to her side to make sure she didn’t hurt herself.

“Wow wow wow! Hold on Jules, where do you think you’re going?!”

Juliana gritted her teeth, and stabilized herself. “You’ve heard what I said, Koraidon and Terapagos are in danger. I have to get them back.” She left Nemona’s side and began making her way towards the door.

“Hey, didn’t you hear Miriam?” Arven exclaimed, standing between her and the exit. “No straining yourself, you need to rest”

“I’m fine, I need to go! I can’t just sit here while they do who-knows-what to them!” She tried to push past him, but he only moved with her, refusing to let her go.

Clavell placed a reassuring hand on her shoulder from behind. “I’m sorry, Miss Juliana, but pushing yourself now will only make things worse.”

She pushed his hand away. Their concern was too much, and her contained emotions boiled over.

“I know that, I KNOW THAT! But you don’t get it!” She shouted back. “It’s **my fault** they’re gone, and now, I have to fix it! If I don’t, someone else is going to get hurt! Or

they'll get hurt! I can't- I can't let it happen. **Again**." She challenged Clavell's determined gaze with her own.

"Then battle me!" Another voice, thus far quiet, called.

"Huh?"

She turned to Nemona. The girl wore the most serious expression she had ever seen.

She held out her Pokeball, inviting a challenge.

"You heard me Jules! I challenge you to a Pokémon Battle!" She insisted. "If you win we'll let you go, no questions asked. But if I win, you have to let us help you."

Clavell frowned. "Miss Nemona, I apologize but I do not think that battling in such a state would be a good idea for Juliana's health."

Nemona threw him a silent look that communated… something, that Juliana didn't quite understand. Eventually, the Director sighed.

"Fine, I'll allow it." He caved.

Nemona looked back at Juliana with a grin on her face.

"So, what do you say, Juliana?"

"You're on."

Ch13 - The Battle Within

Juliana stood on dry sand.

She was pacing up and down the battlefield at Nemona's private beach, right by her house, waiting for the other girl to finish preparations.

The place held good memories: it was where she truly met her rival for the first time, as well as where her journey had begun. And now, she hoped, where it wouldn't end.

She was beyond stressed out about this incoming battle. The stakes were just so high, she'd never felt that way since dethroning Kieran at Blueberry Academy.

The boy commanded his Pokémon with wrath and hatred on the other end of the battlefield.

"AM I GOOD ENOUGH FOR YOU NOW, JULIANA!?" He shouted as he landed a critical hit on Ogerpon, fainting the Pokémon. She winced - just like that, she had to rethink her entire strategy.

A sudden pain in her left palm drew her back to reality. Confused, she looked to realize her hand was clenched so tight that her nails bit into her own skin.

The confusion gave her pause. Did she actually do that by accident? It felt like a new low, even for her.

The ball at her belt rattled. She sighed, forcing herself to have composure. The Pokémon she had chosen for this battle was already restless. He didn't need her fear to exacerbate that.

While preparing for the battle, Juliana had been left with a tough choice: which Pokémon to pick? With most of her team recovering, Nemona had agreed to a one on one in a single round. She'd most likely expect her to bring Clodsire, the Pokémon being her only viable option, and Nemona had done a great deal of training against him.

So, Juliana had decided on an odd choice the girl wouldn't be able to anticipate.

The Roaring Moon she caught back at the crater.

Using her prep time, she had taken him out of her PC boxes and trained with him for a bit. The Pokémon was a 'Dragon' through and through, as Drayton would call it. Even without his frenzied state from Area Zero, he was full of energy. Still, he

responded well to orders, and enjoyed letting out some steam. It had been relatively easy winning his favor with food.

The Pokémon was unlike what she saw at the crater. Though, she had her theory as to why. She had read online that Team Rocket once used radio waves to frenzy wild Pokémon years ago in Johto. So, she figured a similar system should be in place in Area Zero. It might even be the reason for his unusually colored scales, who knows?

Juliana sighed, stopping in place to look at the waves washing on the shore. It felt… bad, pulling such a dirty trick on Nemona. Her rival always was a beacon of hope and honesty, she only gave her truly fair battle with clear set parameters beforehand. Juliana had this one advantage: Nemona wasn't used to battling Paradox Pokémon.

Ever since the crater, Juliana had been the only one with clearance from the League to go back down there, or even handle Paradox Pokémon in broader Paldea for that matter. As a result, her rival didn't have much experience with these beasts.

It felt bad.

She closed her eyes. She never wanted to resort to this, but she **had** to. Nemona trained with her so much, both girls knew the other more than themselves. She needed an advantage. **Any** advantage.

She had to win.

She had to prove herself well enough to be allowed to move on. To leave them behind, in safety. To protect them.

She gulped. She couldn't afford to lose. Koraidon and Terapagos were at stake.

Juliana shivered. Why was it so cold outside? Her head was still spinning too. She was still wearing pajamas, now with a stuffy jacket thrown over them. Her health problems were annoying, but still, she would have to power through it.

Her mind lost in a spiral of self-blame and stress, she didn't hear people stepping into the beach behind her as she gazed at the sea.

"Ready Juliana?" Nemona called from the battlefield, startling her. She was staring at her as if analyzing a wild Pokémon.

Juliana looked to the left. Her other friends were watching from the side, no doubt ready to intervene if anything went wrong. Clavell in particular looked focused, watching over her.

She nodded to Nemona, marching to her side of the battlefield.

“Ready.” She answered briefly.

The girl had a signature grin on her face. One that cut through the noise in her mind.

“Great!” Her rival yelled excitedly. “Let’s make this a good battle.”

They both threw their Pokémon at the same time, Roaring Moon facing Pawmot.

The battle was going better than she had imagined.

Juliana’s plan worked. Nemona, to her credit, had adapted surprisingly quickly to the Paradox Pokémon. But still, the difference in raw power was astounding.

Pawmot was no pushover to be sure, it was one of the most powerful Pokémon on her team, often impressing renowned trainers from outside the region. But Roaring Moon was an absolute monster.

His sheer power and aggressiveness forced Nemona to fight on the defensive, something the girl wasn’t used to, coming from Juliana. Still, Pawmot was fast and agile. Using his superior speed in combination with *Quick Attack*s, the Pokémon was able to dodge all of the dragon’s most threatening moves.

Thus, despite her advantage, Juliana was unable to do any real damage to the electric rodent. But all she needed was one good hit to win the battle.

All she needed was an opportunity.

Pawmot ducked under a blow from Roaring Moon’s paw and took the chance to hit it with a weak *Double Shock*.

Juliana smiled.

Her Pokémon didn’t even flinch as Pawmot stumbled back from his own attack - he wouldn’t be able to act fast enough to dodge. This was her chance. Time to make it count.

“Roaring Moon!” She called. “Use *Dragon Rush*!”

Dragon energy enveloped the Pokémon as it barreled towards Pawmot, flying low with a trail of sand behind him.

Juliana’s heart pounded. There was no chance it wouldn’t hit now, the battle was hers-

Nemona had the biggest grin on her face, she realized. Pawmot looked serene in the face of the incoming dragon, not even **trying** to run away. Why-

She widened her eyes. “Wait, no stop!” She called.

Too late.

The dragon’s energy faded as electric arcs stunned the Roaring Moon’s muscles, causing it to crash hard into the sand right in front of Pawmot.

How could she be so stupid! Of course. Of course Nemona wouldn’t leave her Pokémon open to an attack against such an opponent. She must have had Pawmot disguise *Nuzzle* as *Double Shock*-

“Now’s our chance Pawmot! Use *Close Combat*!”

She felt her knees weaken, her mind screaming. She knew the power of that Pokémon. Roaring Moon couldn’t withstand a super effective move.

Koraidon took a heavy hit, panting. She knew he couldn’t hold on for long. Across the room, the other Koraidon was preparing to deal another blow.

“Oh man, can we really not pull off a win here?” She heard Nemona's desperate voice. “This doesn’t look good…”

She was panicking. What could she do?! The rest of her team was trapped inside their Pokéballs. At this rate Koraidon would…

She heard a sudden gasp behind her. Penny looked at her, eyes wide.

“H-hey, Juliana! Your Tera Orb is glowing!”

Or could it?

That was the answer, she thought, Terastallization! She- she hated the thing but it didn’t matter at the moment. She didn’t know Roaring Moon’s Tera Type, but as long as he lost his Fighting weakness, the battle could go on.

She reached for her Tera Orb.

She reached for her Tera Orb.

She could feel it pulsing with energy.

She could only grab the air.

Her breathing quickened, she was trembling.

Why- where was her Tera Orb? Her head was hurting.

She watched, powerless, as the orb surrounded by purple energy slowly floated into the man's hand.

"Thank you for your contribution." He said with a malicious voice.

Oh,

she forgot.

Juliana collapsed to her knees, watching, powerless, as Pawmot hit Roaring Moon. The dragon fell to the sand and didn't get up.

Her head throbbed with pain.

She couldn't breathe.

She couldn't breathe.

Crystals formed around her. Sada's machine looked into her eyes, an expression of hatred and pity at the same time.

She sank her hands into the sand, trying to grasp something that wasn't there. It was wet with someone's tears. That someone was screaming in agony, using her own voice.

She couldn't breathe. Crystals were crashing all around. Kieran looked at her with despair. His scream echoed through the room. "You- you took EVERYTHING from me!".

People were rushing to her side. She couldn't hear them. The world was impossibly loud. She put her hands to her ears, unbothered by the sand splashing on her temples.

She couldn't breathe. *Geeta stood across the room, disappointed. Giovanni watched her with a wicked grin. She fell from the sky. She sank endlessly under water.*

Everything was blurry. She was lost in a void. Darkness consumed her like a maw. Yet, crystals reflected her own broken face. Impossibly bright.

She couldn't breathe.

Static filled her ears. She couldn't hear anything except-

"Hey…"

A calm, soothing voice reached out from the void. An open hand reached out to her.

"Juliana, do you hear me?"

She nodded her head.

"Good!" The voice sounded relieved. "Can I take your hands? Just so you can hear me better…"

There was the gentlest brush against her fingers. A moment later, warmth wrapped around her hands, guiding them slowly away from her ear.

"Stay with me, we're going to do this together okay?" The voice continued. Familiar, comforting. "Breathe in through your nose with me, then breathe out through your mouth."

She did so shakily. It felt impossibly hard, but she immediately started to feel just a bit better.

"You're doing great!" The voice sounded pleased. "Now, we're going to do this and count from 1 to 5 between each breath. Ready? Breathe in…"

She repeated this exercise with the voice for a few minutes as she slowly felt the static disappear. The world started to make sense again, but the darkness didn't subside.

"Well done Juliana! Now, slowly open your eyes."

Oh. That was why. She did so tentatively and was met face to face with Penny. The girl had a patient smile on her face, a fierce focus in her eyes - one she hadn't seen

since Operation Starfall. She had her hands in hers. Next to her was Clodsire, the Spiny Fish Pokémon looking at her with a happy expression.

They were still outside, sitting on the beach. Penny seemed unbothered by the wet sand clinging to her clothes and bag. The rest of the group was nowhere to be seen.

They left her behind, her inner voice whispered. Her heart missed a beat, her breathing suddenly quickening.

“Hey! Stay with me!” Penny called, unaware of the cause of her panic. Juliana gripped her hands tight, trying and failing to calm herself. The world was slipping again.

“Juliana,” Penny said gently. “Please, do something for me, okay? We’re going to play a game.”

This seemed to reach her. Still shaking, Juliana tried to speak but found her throat uncooperative. Instead, she nodded in agreement.

“Great!” Penny smiled, her glasses slipping a little. She didn’t bother to push them back. “Let’s start, tell me five things you can see.”

Juliana took a shaky breath, forcing her voice to work. “Y-y-you.” She started, finally pushing past the lump in her throat. “Clodsire. Sand.” She searched around for a beat, not seeing anything else. “... A Wingull.” Perched on top of the nearby tree. Looking at her. Was it judging her? Did it perceive her mistakes? Her failures? Did it-

“Hey,” Penny called her back gently to reality. “Come on, another one. You’re doing great.”

Juliana gulped, forgetting the Wingull to find something else. She had to win the game, her competitive mind decided. Looking up, past the cliff, was Nemona’s mansion. Shapes were moving through the window, though one in particular stood next to the entrance, watching her with concern. Nemona.

“... Nemona’s house.” She answered.

Penny smiled and complimented her as she would a stumbling Eevee. Juliana didn’t mind, it… It actually felt good for once. The ‘game’ continued, each round becoming more challenging with other senses. She persisted, growing more calm and comfortable with each one. Four things she could touch, three she could hear, two she could smell - wow, Clodsire needed a bath - and one thing she could taste.

Juliana blinked in confusion at the last one.

“Um…” She pondered. “... Air?”

Penny chuckled. “Yes, that’s okay. Air is good. Well done, Juliana.”

She pulled back her hands, pushing back her sliding glasses into place with a fond smile.

“Welcome back to the realm of the living.” She mumbled, not unkindly. Juliana couldn’t help but squeeze the girl in a quick hug, silently thanking her for grounding her back to reality. Her panic and visions now a distant memory. She heard footsteps in the sand.

“That was amazing Penny! How did you do that?” Nemona exclaimed, making Juliana jump back, letting go. She hadn’t seen the girl approaching them.

Penny on her part blushed, all semblance of calm and confidence gone.

“U-um, I used to have panic attacks too, when I was younger. Dad used these tricks to help a-and it always worked, so…”

Nemona gasped. “Your dad sounds amazing! I should meet him sometime.”

Her dad. The ex-gym leader.

“No!” Penny and Juliana shouted in unison.

Ch14 - No More Masks

Juliana was ushered back inside the house by Nemona, hugging tightly a content Clodsire while her rival pulled her by the elbow, with an exasperated but amused Penny in tow.

She was directed to an old looking study. There were two couches facing each other by a fireplace, an armchair on the side. The walls were all lined up with bookshelves filled to the brim with old, expensive books. A desk sat unused in the corner, two Pokémon sleeping comfortably under it in some sort of pillow fortress, Ogerpon and Tinkaton. A live fireplace crackled, its sound overshadowed by the low continuous snore of Skeledirge resting by it.

Juliana was sat on a couch, Clodsire slipping to her lap as Penny and Nemona kept the conversation going, light and uneventful. Juliana had tuned them out by now, enjoying the comforting background noise as her mind took a break.

It felt good. Her head still throbbed, but it felt good. Surrounded by her friends, she allowed herself to relax.

As soon as she did, a quiet anguish came creeping back. Terapagos and Koraidon should be with her. She missed them.

She shook her head. Brooding wouldn’t get her anywhere. She didn’t want to worry them any further. Grounding herself, she took a deep breath.

It smelled nice, she realized.

The smell of baked goods came from the door, likely from the kitchen. Her mouth watered, she hadn’t eaten in a while. It must have been where Arven was, she realized.

As if on cue, Clavell emerged into the door, followed by Arven and his Mabostiff, the boy carrying a tray. The Director was holding a cup of water and a pill in his hand.

"Ah, Miss Juliana, good to have you back.” The Director said, giving her a pleased look. “You gave us quite a scare-"

Penny elbowed him. Juliana felt bad about what happened- she shouldn’t have panicked in front of them like that, she thought. It wasn’t right. They were never supposed to see this.

“I-I’m sorry.” She answered, looking away with a sad look, hands resting on top of Clodsire. She forced an easy smile, the Champion mask sliding back on in habit. “But I feel better now! Sorry you had to see that. Head still kinda hurts, but I’m good.”

“I may be able to help with that.” He handed her the pill. “Here, take this medicine. Miriam prescribed you to take two a day.”

She nodded and swallowed the pill. Hopefully it would stop the throbbing. Clavell handed her the cup of water, which she also drank quickly.

She had to admit, she was starting to feel a little tired. She must not have looked good, because soon Penny was sitting next to her and patting her back. She was cold too, the pajamas weren't really helping to keep her warm despite the nearby fireplace. She shivered.

Before she knew it, Nemona had thrown a blanket over her. Arven handed her a cup of hot chocolate from the tray.

“Shhh, it’s okay honey.” Mom said, patting her back. “It’s okay, drink this, you’ll feel better.”

She handed her a cup of hot chocolate.

The last dam broke.

She had tried her best, damn it.

Ever since she woke up this morning, she had tried to hold it in.

Repress it, she thought.

They can’t see you like this. But this was it. She had finally reached her limit.

It started quietly at first, just a few tears spilling loudly into the cup.

“Juliana, are you okay?” “What’s wrong?”

Her friends were at her side immediately. They were worried.

“I-I just” Her voice was weak, so weak, barely audible between hiccups and sobs.

“I love you guys.”

She was startled when she soon felt someone hug her. Then another, and another.

She began to sob even harder into someone's shoulder, fully embracing the group hug.

An unknown amount of time passed like that. Minutes, hours- she didn't know. But finally dry of tears, Juliana was the first to reluctantly break away from the group hug.

Everyone returned to a seat of their own, Clavell sitting in the armchair while Nemona, Arven and Penny all took the opposing couch. Not that they didn't want to sit by Juliana, but the place was taken by her own Pokémon. At some point, Skeledirge had climbed on the couch - Juliana hoped it wouldn't ruin it - and was resting his head on her lap. Meanwhile, Ogerpon and Tinkaton had woken up and decided to move their pillow fortress to the other side of the couch. Incorporating Clodsire as a building foundation, the Pokémon being happy to be included.

She watched them with a smile as a comfortable silence filled the room, broken solely by the crackles of the dying fire. She was unaware of the subtle looks and whispers her friends gave each other, of Clavell watching her with a pensive expression.

"... So." Arven was eventually first to break the quiet. "How do you feel, Juliana?"

She now realized they were all watching her. Carefully.

She sighed. Considering what they had just seen - the panic attack **and** the group hug, pretending to be fine wouldn't be an option anymore now, would it?

But she didn't want to talk about it.

"Better, thanks." She answered.

Penny looked at her suspiciously. "... That's not what he meant and you know it."

"Penny!" Arven exclaimed.

"What!?" She turned to the boy. "I'm just saying what we're all thinking, that's all!"

Juliana chuckled at their bickering. Those two never really changed, did they?

But something inside her… caved in. She felt tired, hopeless. She had lost that battle. She didn't want to talk about it, but she knew they wouldn't let it go.

“Yeah, I know, I’m sorry. I…” She trailed off, looking away while stroking Skeledirge’s head. “Well, it might not come as a big surprise, but I-I’ve not been doing well lately.”

Nemona frowned, leaning forward with intensity in her eyes. “... How long?”

Juliana blinked, confused. “Huh?”

“How long has this all been going on, Jules?” Nemona insisted.

Juliana paled. She had hoped her friends would think her troubles started and stopped at Team Rainbow Rocket. And yet, it was clear that Nemona had figured her out. They both remembered what happened at the Tournament.

And by the look in her eyes, Nemona *knew* she was right.

Juliana smiled sadly, looking away. She had tried so hard to keep things to herself, to bury it all. But in the end, she never stood a chance, huh?

“... Area Zero.” She answered, her voice more shaken than she expected.

She gulped, took a breath and continued. “I-I-I’m worse now than I was then, don’t get me wrong. Terapagos, Koraidon,” just saying these names out loud felt like it tore her whole essence apart. She kept going. “I-I-I’m so **scared**. Of- of what could be happening to them. And-and I want nothing more than to get up and get them back, no matter the cost. But…”

She paused. It was hard to talk about this- but at this point, she wanted to.

“After… After Area Zero. After the Professor.” She glanced quickly at Arven. His expression was… patient. “I-I messed up. I felt powerless. And then came Kitakami, Blueberry Academy, and a whole lot more mess. And I tried so, **so hard** to do the right thing. But I messed up. Again and again. And- and ended up hurting people.”

There was a solemn look on Clavell’s face. No doubt the man regretted sending her to Kitakami in the first place and blamed himself. She hated that.

She saw it in her friends’ eyes. They had trouble reconciling her words with their vision of her. Trying to recontextualise past interactions. She looked away.

She owed them the truth.

“E-Ever since Area Zero, I’ve been having trouble.” She confessed. “I can’t sleep at night. I space out at crucial moments, get trapped in visions, or have these… panic attacks. It-it only got worse with time.”

She laughed, humorlessly. Unaware of the stray tears falling to her lap, where they evaporated on top Skeledirge's head.

"I-I wasn't always like this, you know? Scared. Of everyone, of everything. I used to rush headfirst into things, uncaring of the consequences. I used to ***feel*** like a hero, while now I'm merely playing the part for everyone to see. I'm deathly afraid of Terastallization. Can you imagine? The very power that makes this region special? The scandals that would arise if people figure me out? I'm a joke of a champion. A broken mess they like to call 'special'. They don't know about my failures."

Her sob tore itself from her throat. She wanted to stop now. She should. But she couldn't.

"I thought- I thought I could power through it. Just, y'know, repress the worst of it and keep moving forward. 'Cause, if I can't be what I'm pretending to be, then at least I can work to earn it? Earn all of this: friendship, companionship, family? Maybe, with enough effort, I could be worthy of it all. But- but now I can't. I've lost it all, I can't move on anymore. So- what good am I if I don't have what it takes to do the right thing? If I can't even continue to put on this farce of a Champion, disgraced by the League, left for dead under a tree. If I can't even protect those I care about, what use am I? I- I- I- I…"

She sighed. She suddenly felt deathly tired. "I don't know what to do anymore…"

A heavy silence filled the room. The fire had died down, the only sound Juliana could hear was her own heavy breathing and Skeledirge's sad low rumble.

She had said too much.

She had said too much, and now they would hate her. They would finally see her for who she truly was. They would leave.

She couldn't look up from her lap. She wouldn't dare. She couldn't see their reactions.

"Welp." Penny's voice broke the silence. "That's a lot."

She looked up in fear - only to be met by a vast array of stunned and sad expressions. Before she could process it, Nemona jumped from her seat and pulled her in a Bewear hug.

"I-I had no idea Jules, that's- it all makes sense now!" She exclaimed. "How could I not see it!"

They didn’t hate her, she realized.

She felt dumb at the idea. Of course they didn’t.

Juliana gave her a sad smile as Nemona pulled back, and sat back in her seat. “That’s okay ‘Mona, you couldn’t have known. I really don’t talk much about myself, a-and I didn’t really want anyone to know so…”

“That’s what I don’t get, actually.” Arven had his eyes closed and his arms crossed, deep in thought. “I mean, we’re your friends right? You could have reached out at any moment for help, but you didn’t. You know all about us, but I’m starting to realize how little we knew about you, buddy. You always seemed so strong, like you could carry the world on your shoulders you know? But we’ve never seen you so… vulnerable.”

She lowered her gaze, ashamed. Arven was right. Of course he was.

“I- I’m sorry. I know, I always knew I could count on you all. The truth is, I-I really didn’t want to be a burden.”

Nemona frowned. “A burden? Juliana, you’ve helped us so much!”

“Y-Yeah!” Penny added. “You even saved us back then at Area Zero!”

This was too much. She clenched her fists and closed her eyes.

“You don’t understand- you only ever were all in danger because of me! I should have been better! I should have been stronger! We almost got killed because of my incompetence-”

“But, bud’, you-” Arven tried to intervene.

Her temper rose, she was yelling before she knew it. “I WASN’T EVEN GOOD ENOUGH TO SAVE SADA!”

The room fell silent once again.

Juliana’s eyes widened as she realized what she had just said. That just came out by itself. Her breathing accelerated, she panicked at her own outburst.

“I- I’m sorry! I didn’t mean to snap, I- I’m sorry. I’m so sorry! I- I- I…”

She jumped when a hand touched her shoulder.

She looked up to see that Arven had approached her. He kneeled down to be at her level and looked her in the eyes.

“Juliana.” He said, talking as if he was soothing a troubled Pokémon. “My mother died a long time ago. Long, long before you ever came to Paldea. It was hard to admit it, but that AI wasn’t her. It could have never truly been her.”

He bit his lower lip. “I won’t lie, it was still hard to see her go, but she made her own choice.”

“And so did we!” Nemona exclaimed with a grin. “We came to the crater of our own free will! It was our choice to put ourselves in danger, not yours! You’re the one who got us out of there.”

“Y-Yeah!” Penny regained some confidence. “Plus, you really helped us a lot besides that Juliana. You saved Team Star and helped us reconnect even though you barely knew any of us. I’m sure you’ve changed everyone’s lives for the better.”

Arven’s Mabostiff barked from beside her as if proving her point.

“It was not your fault, little buddy.” Arven said, a sad smile on his face. “We don’t care about your titles and whatnot. We don’t care if you messed up. You’re our friend. That’s all that matters. And you’re not getting rid of us that easily.”

“S-s-stop it,” Juliana said with a shaky breath. “You- You’re going to make me cry again!”

A few tears spilled out. She pouted.

“This- this sucks. I don’t like to cry.”

Penny couldn’t help but giggle at that, then Nemona followed her. Then the whole room erupted in laughter.

Juliana smiled, and joined in.

A few minutes passed before everyone calmed down.

Clavell cleared his throat. Juliana jumped. She had forgotten the old man was still here.

“Now, if I may? I believe we need to discuss our next course of action.”

Nemona tilted her head. “What do you mean, Director?”

“I know very well that Miss Juliana would rather not stay here forever. It is, of course, evident that she wishes nothing more than to be reunited with her Pokémon. Rather than becoming yet another obstacle to her… unwavering bravery, I believe it would be more constructive to try to act together.”

“Really?!” Juliana was stunned. She had figured they would try to force her to stay cooped up in here and rest. She didn’t expect to be wrong.

Clavell smiled and adjusted his glasses. “Of course. Though, I think we need to talk more later about your tendency to put yourself in danger regardless of your own well-being later.”

Juliana gulped. She was not looking forward to that conversation.

Nemona startled her by clapping her hands. “And we’ll help too!”

“Wha- wait no you can’t!” Juliana protested. “It’s too dangerous!”

Arven deflated. “Juliana, buddy, what were we **just** talking about? It’s because it’s dangerous that we want to get involved. We won’t let you face this alone.”

“Plus!” Penny had a menacing expression on her face. “We can’t let those bastards get away with this. They are going to pay.”

Yup. She was going to commit murder.

“So!” Nemona had a mischievous grin on her face. “Where do we start, Boss?”

“Well…” She thought out loud. “First of all, we need a way to get into the crater. We won’t be able to fly down like we did last time without Koraidon, and even then, Team Rainbow Rocket will probably be on high alert. There are elevators and stairs now, but they are most likely guarded, meaning that we would have to fight our way through. Alternatively, I did see a tunnel down there last time…”

“Oh! I know about it!” Penny exclaimed. “The League just finished building it recently, Miss Geeta asked me to check its security.”

She frowned. “It’s locked down tight, I made sure of that. No one gets in without clearance and we don’t have it.”

A plan began to form in Juliana's mind. This- this might actually work.

"Say, Penny." She grinned. "Let's say that we do get clearance. Do you know if Team Star still has any of these Starmobiles lying around?"

Penny thought about it for a second. "I think so, why?"

Then, it hit her.

"Wait- no, you're not thinking about-" she said with wide eyes.

"I like where you're going!" Nemona had the wildest grin on her face.

"What's a Starmobile?" Arven asked, confused.

Penny buried her face in her hands with a groan. "Oh Arceus. We're really doing this, aren't we…"

Nemona leaned closer to Arven, eyes alight with a mischievous glint. "Basically, picture a car. Now, strap a Revavroom in the engine, make it bigger, faster, and way more illegal."

Arven blinked. "...That sounds stupid."

"It is stupid," Penny muttered, glaring at Juliana. "And dangerous. And impossible."

Juliana's grin widened. "So that's a yes?"

Penny let out a sigh. "You're all going to be the death of me."

Nemona punched the air excitedly. "Operation Starmobile is a go!!"

Arven just shook his head, but Mabostiff barked happily in approval. Clavell adjusted his glasses again, mumbling something about "youthful recklessness," though a smile tugged at his lips.

Juliana felt hope, for the first time in a long time.

She was useless alone. But maybe, together, they could do this.

Ch15 - What's Left Unsaid / League Business

"How are you feeling, Miss Juliana?"

Dread. Despair. Anguish.

"Anxious." She said.

Clavell chuckled. "That's good. I'd be worried if you weren't."

She looked back at him and stifled a chuckle. She couldn't believe he was wearing that wig once again.

She was wearing her usual Academy uniform, having borrowed a change at her own house on the way here. But Clavell- the man had disappeared for an *hour*, doing who-knows-what, and came back wearing his old 'Clive' disguise.

She had to admit, it felt good seeing it again.

Focus. You have a mission here. She thought, shaking her head.

Back to the task at hand, the plan was simple. They needed clearance from the League to enter the Area Zero tunnel. So, they would have to "borrow it".

Penny wouldn't be able to hack her own system from the outside (the girl had cursed her younger self for securing it so thoroughly during her 'internship'). Thus, she would need someone to plug a USB stick into the IT room for her.

Of course, the main issue would be the Elite 4 present in the building. They needed a distraction.

Arven had asked Hassel's tutoring to prepare for a test, which the teacher had enthusiastically accepted. Nemona kept Geeta busy by challenging her for an exhibition match in Mesagoza. Rika was usually checking in on some Gym Leader's work at this time of day, and Larry rarely if ever left his office before lunch hour. That left Poppy to distract on her own. Fortunately, the child was fond of her and it wouldn't be hard for her good old pal Clive to disappear unnoticed.

Mindlessly, she patted her back pocket as she walked towards the League. It was strange not to feel her phone there. Penny had asked her to give it to her when she'd mentioned how it had malfunctioned when she'd tried to show Geeta evidence. A strange glint had passed through the young girl's eyes and Juliana knew better than to ask about it.

She shook her head. No use thinking about that now, she needed to focus on the present. They all had a mission to accomplish, everything would go according to plan.

Right?

Juliana and Clavell stopped at the front door of the League building. Right, now she needed Poppy to come and open the door for her. She pressed the doorbell button as the intercom came to life.

“Who is iiiiit?” A child’s voice asked.

“Hey Poppy! It’s Juliana, can you come open the door for me?”

She heard a gasp at the other end of the line. “Yes! ‘Coming!”

Juliana chuckled at the child’s enthusiasm. Now, all she could do was wait anxiously for Poppy to open up the door.

She desperately needed this to go well. The sooner they had access to the crater, the sooner they could rescue Koraidon and Terapagos. She- She couldn’t imagine what the two Pokemon were going through right now.

She jumped when a comforting hand touched her shoulder. She looked to see Clavell staring at her with a worried look.

“Are you okay, Juliana?”

She unclenched her fist and put on a fake smile.

“Yeah, thanks Clive. Just thinking about… stuff.”

He sighed. “Well, don’t forget. Whatever happens, I’m here with you. You’re not alone in this, Juliana.”

She was about to answer when the door suddenly opened, revealing an excited Poppy who was practically running toward her. Juliana froze as she realized that a second person was standing at the door.

Rika waved at her nonchalantly.

“Hey Juliana! Fancy meeting you here. What brings you to the League?”

“H-Hi Rika!” Juliana waved back, trying her best to hide the surprise and panic in her voice. “I just wanted to check on Poppy. I haven’t been able to come here for a long time because of, y’know, work and stuff.”

Poppy had reached her by now and she gave the girl a quick hug.

“I’m sorry I didn’t tell you Rika,” she continued, patting Poppy’s head. “I didn’t expect you to be here so I didn’t bother. I thought you were supposed to check on Grusha’s progress today?”

Rika put her hand behind her head and smiled apologetically. “Yeah you’d be right, but Grusha called in sick today. Said he had a cold, so suddenly I have the day off.”

Juliana felt her eye twitch. All of this, all this planning could be for nothing just because Grusha caught a cold?!

“Say Juliana, who’s the stylish guy with you? I’m not sure we’ve met.”

Clavell cleared his throat and introduced himself, in typical ‘Clive’ fashion, by showing off his hair.

“Yo! The name’s Clive, you’d better not forget it. I’m an old pal of Juliana’s, here for emotional support.”

Juliana died a little inside. Clavell’s act had been funny back in Operation Starfall, but here?! Rika would never fall for it! Sure, he would have convinced Poppy, but Rika?! It was over. The whole plan would fall apart. Rika was going to figure them out and-

“Oh! Well then, come in! I’ll make you some coffee.” Rika said with a smile.

Huh?

Rika winked at her mischievously before shoving Poppy and Clive inside.

Juliana sighed and followed them in.

One surprising fact Juliana had quickly learned after joining the League was just how big the building actually was. Sure, there was the battlefield where she challenged the Elite 4, but the entire tower was filled to the brim with offices and private headquarters for League staff.

The living room was one of them. Here, Clive and Rika were discussing something over a cup of coffee. Juliana drank hers while Poppy enthusiastically showed off her latest drawings.

Sitting on the teal blue sofa, she let out a sigh as Poppy was frantically searching for a pencil.

She was worried for her friends.

She couldn't help it. After all that happened, it felt wrong to let them go do their own thing. She had to, for the plan, but still. She didn't even have her phone to contact them if needed. What if something happened? What if Giovanni targeted them next? What if-

"Are you okay there, kid?"

The voice cut through her brain fog, she looked up from Poppy - the child having begun a new drawing - to meet Rika's cautious but inquisitive look. The woman had paused her discussion with 'Clive' to talk to her.

Juliana gave her a quick smile. Easy, fake. "Y-yeah, sorry. I-I just miss my friends, that's all."

Rika smiled. "Ah, I get it kiddo, no worries. It can get lonely here sometimes, especially when the other League members are busy doing whatever they do."

Juliana nodded mindlessly, patting her belt and feeling five Pokéballs under her hand. It was comforting, knowing she still had most of her team at her side. She allowed herself to relax for a beat.

Poppy abandoned her drawing for a second, tugging on her sleeve to catch her attention.

"Don't worry, Poppy will keep you company!" She said sweetly with a wide smile, showing her missing teeth.

Juliana's heart *didn't* melt right here and there. Her throat tightened. She loved that kid.

Then, Poppy had a pensive expression. "Hey, that's funny. If Mr. Grusha hadn't been sick, you and Mr. Clive would have been all alone with Poppy!" She exclaimed.

Juliana and Clavell shared a panicked look.

They scrambled to talk atop one another, trying to explain themselves. Luckily, Rika saved them from the embarrassment, ruffling the child's hair with a chuckle.

"Well, good thing I'm here to keep company too, huh kid?" She said lightly. Poppy gave her a nod and a wide smile, returning to her drawing.

Clive took the opportunity to tap her shoulder. Right. Even with the incident and Rika's presence, the plan was still on. Juliana nodded discreetly at him, secretly hoping he wouldn't say anything stupid.

He cleared his throat. "Well, if you'll excuse me, I think I need to use your bathroom." He said.

Rika turned to him with an eyebrow raised and amused smile. "Sure, but why?"

Clive ran his hand through his wig, then winked and shot finger guns at her. "My belly is *'ratioing*' me, if you know what I mean. It's pretty much not '*poggers*'."

Juliana felt like she could die of embarrassment. She could see Rika's eyes watering as she tried desperately not to laugh. And with that, Clive left the room.

Poppy tugged at her sleeve, again.

"Juliana? What's a poggers?"

Clavell quietly hummed, satisfied, while walking through the corridors of the League. He still had it! He had to admit, he was quite worried his Clive persona might be outdated, but he was still 'hip' and 'cool'!

Now all he had to do was find the IT room. He used to visit the League often in the good old days, so he hoped he still knew where it was.

He turned left and came to a glass door that revealed a room full of electronic equipment.

"So, what do you think?" A male voice asked.

"'Dunno, what do **you** think?" Replied a female voice.

Clavell quickly hid by the door. Two people were in the room, dressed in black uniforms.

Rainbow Rocket Grunts.

“I think this is bullshit.” Said the man. “Suddenly we’re not good enough to guard the base, so the boss sends us to hack computers? Why?! I can’t even use a Pokégear properly!”

“It’s because of that girl!” The woman complained. “Damn brat beat our asses twice, the Boss was really not happy that we couldn’t stop her.”

“She was a champion! How did he expect us to do anything! This is so unfair… And why does he still care! Wasn’t she taken care of?”

“Yeah, that’s what the guys told me. Two Pokémon stolen and she jumps off a cliff. Man, I didn’t like her, but talk about a sad way to go.”

“So…” The man turned to a computer. “What exactly are we supposed to do here now?”

“Oh, right!” She pulled out a flash drive. “That crazy woman said all we had to do was plug this thing in and the whole League network would be down for months at least!”

Well, Clavell couldn’t really let that happen, could he? Time to step in.

He entered the room and cleared his throat.

“What- who the hell are you!” The man shouted.

“Yo! The name’s Clive, you’d better not forget it.” He taunted, still in character. “I won’t let you carry out your evil plan, miscreant!”

The woman laughed. “Ha! It’s just a random student! Let’s thrash him!”

The man looked at her disbelievingly. “A random- do you really not recognize the guy?!”

“Shut up!” She said, preparing to throw a ball. “We have new Pokémon, and I want to try them out on this lost kid!”

She and Clavell threw their Pokéballs at the same time, revealing a Machamp versus Clive’s Houndoom.

He winced. This did not start well.

“Machamp! Giga-Impact!”

Giga-what-now?

Larry was a simple man.

He wasn’t special. He didn’t like to think of himself as unique. He liked to be just a man, another nameless cog in the machine.

Most people would find him boring. Maybe. He didn’t care. When he had a job to do, he would still get it done.

He didn’t know what compelled La Primera to appoint a man like him as a Gym Leader, let alone an Elite 4 member. But it wasn’t his place to question.

If he had a job, he would get it done. Simple as that.

Still, when the clock in his office struck noon, he knew the task at hand would have to wait. The paperwork could be done later, now was time for his lunch break.

He got up from his desk and grabbed his jacket. He liked lunch break. Mesagezo was a few steps away from the League and there were many restaurants in town.

He left his office and made his way through the corridors. The Pokéballs on his belt rattled softly. He could feel his Pokémon growing restless.

It had been some time since his last challenger, he thought. Perhaps he should hold a training session for both of his teams this afternoon, to blow off some steam, after he’d taken care of the documents regarding the crater-

CRASH

A loud noise startled him. He calmly made his way to the source of the commotion.

“Houndoom, use Fire Blast!”

At the end of the hallway stood the headmaster of Naranja Academy, wearing a student uniform and the most ridiculous wig he had ever seen. The man was directing his Pokémon in battle against a Machamp that had just crashed through several walls.

He felt a headache coming.

Nope. That was not what he was dealing with. Whatever *that* was, it was above his pay grade.

Larry was a simple man. When he had a job to do, he would get it done.

There was nothing in his contract about a principal fighting a Machamp in the hallways. So that was not his job, plain and simple.

Besides, it was time for his lunch break.

Larry turned and left in the opposite direction.

Ch16 - What's Left Unseen / League Business

Juliana sat quietly on the League sofa, finishing her now cold coffee. She was trying to relax as she watched Poppy hard at work, drawing… something on a piece of paper. The child was happily humming a familiar song, though Juliana couldn't remember what it was.

"So, Juliana." Rika sat down beside her and smiled. "How have you been?"

Juliana sighed inwardly. Why did everyone ask her that lately?! She didn't look *that* bad, did she?

Who was she kidding, of course she looked bad. Even Poppy had noticed the dark circles under her eyes by now.

"I've been fine, thank you." She put on a strained smile.

Rika rolled her eyes.

"Don't lie to me kiddo, I'm used to playing that game."

Juliana dropped the act, her composure melting on the couch. "Sorry, force of habit. There's just been a lot on my plate for a while and it's just now catching up to me, that's all."

"... Sorry about that." Rika said, looking frustrated. "It shouldn't have been your job to deal with all that in the first place. Hey, at least you can rest now, right? No need to overwork yourself for the League and I'm sure that good old Clavell has you covered at the Academy." She winked at her.

Juliana sighed. "Y-yeah, you're right, but I'm still really concerned about Team Rainbow Rocket. For… reasons."

She couldn't really bring up the whole *they tried to kill me and kidnapped two of my Pokémon* thing without any proof. Not after last time.

To her surprise, Rika sighed as well. "Yeah, I get it kiddo. I don't like 'em either, and I have no idea what the heck is going on in the crater. And somehow, the Boss does trusts them despite our protests. Something fishy is going on."

Juliana was taken aback by that. "Wait- how come you don't know? Aren't you, like, her second in command?"

“Beats me kiddo- all I know is that in the last few months there have been some efforts to make the crater more accessible, to clean up the mess down there. Figure out what to do with the Paradox Pokémon and Sada’s research, y’know?” She shrugged.

Juliana placed her empty mug on the table, giving Rika her full attention as the woman started an exasperated rant. “It shouldn’t have been left to you kids to handle that on your own, ‘least we can do is clean it up. Then, a few weeks ago, these guys showed up out of nowhere claiming to be an archaeological exploration team. Their Boss meets with Geeta in private to discuss some sensitive documents, and suddenly our fearless commander gives them complete control over the crater while we’re left in the dark. I don’t know what happened, but Geeta has been off since then.”

Juliana was about to question it further when she felt a tug on her sleeve. She looked back at Poppy, and saw that the child had finished whatever she was drawing and was waiting patiently to show her.

“What have you got there, Poppy?” She asked.

“Tadaaa!” She said with a happy smile, pushing her drawing into Juliana’s hands. “It’s us! I drew Miss Rika with Clodsire, there’s me with ‘Rajah! And here it is you, with Koraidon! And-”

Whatever she was about to say next was cut short by a single teardrop hitting the paper.

They were falling. There was nothing she could do. They- they were taken. Alone again. Her fault. Always her fault. They would suffer because of her. They would have been happier without her. She shouldn’t have met them. She shouldn’t have been a burden. She shouldn’t have been born. She-

She was brought back to reality when a gentle hand touched her shoulder.

“You okay Juliana?” Rika asked, sounding worried.

She had spaced out again. Juliana realized how tightly she was holding the paper, crumbling it. Poppy looked at her, unsure of what was happening.

“Y-yeah, I am now, thanks.” She said, her voice wavering, wiping her eyes. She gave Poppy a shy smile. “I’m really sorry I ruined your drawing, Poppy, it was really great.”

To her relief, Poppy just smiled. “It’s okay! I can make another one!”

They're gone. You've lost your greatest treasure, and it's your fault. The voice said.

Juliana shivered. "I'm sorry but… can we go outside, for a bit? I-I could use some fresh air, right now."

Rika smiled, giving her a knowing look. "Sure thing, kid. Come on Poppy, show her the way, okay? I'll be right with you."

Poppy gasped, stars in her eyes. Juliana didn't have time to say anything before the child took her by the hand with surprising strength and led her through the halls of the League.

Rika snorted as she watched the children run away.

"Kids will be kids, huh?" She reflected.

She sighed, wrote down a note to let poor old Clive know that they were outside, and went after them.

Clive was not having a good time.

Fighting these two grunts should have been child play- afterall, they **had** been beaten by a child before. But the Pokemon they were carrying with them were strong. Stronger than he had expected them to be.

"Houdoom!" He called. "Dodge it, then Sucker Punch!"

His mind was racing. The battle had started out normal enough. Sure, the Machamp was a powerhouse, and he had to be very careful in order to defeat it without alerting the whole building, but he had not expected Paradox Pokémon to join in the fray afterwards. Worse than that, the other Grunt had reluctantly sent out his own Pokémon into the battle.

Still, he was the headmaster of the Naranja Academy for a reason. His old days of training still served him well.

As expected, Houndoom easily dodged Brute Bonnet's Solar Beam, and retaliated by rushing an unprepared Scream Tail, knocking it out. One down.

"Damn it!" The man yelled. "I'm out of Pokémon! This is bad, I told you this was a bad idea!"

“Shut up, idiot! You’re useless!” She replied.

Were… were they arguing in the middle of a fight? Well, no time like the present. The Brute Bonnet looked confused, not sure what to do.

“Houndoom, finish it off with one last Fire Blast!” He shouted.

The attack hit the Pokémon with full force, knocking it out.

“Huh?”

The female Grunt blinked, just now realizing what had happened.

“What- What the hell is going on with children in this Arceus-forsaken region! I can’t take it anymore, I’m quitting!”

“Shut up!” The other grunt interjected. “Let’s bail!”

“Now hold on-”

As he moved to intercept the criminals he was interrupted by one of the grunts throwing something at his head while the other opened a Pokéball.

“Ouch- Houndoom! Sucker Punch!”

Houndoom lunged at the pair as a Kadabra widened its eyes. The Dark Pokémon was about to reach them when a bright light teleported them away, and it snapped its jaws at an empty space.

Clavell sighed, thanked his Pokémon, and returned it to its Pokéball. His foot kicked into the object the grunts threw at him.

“Is that…”

He picked up a flash drive with the letter R on it and hid it in his pocket. He’d keep it as evidence for now. Shaking his head, the Director made his way back to the IT room, taking out his Rotom Phone and calling Penny on the way.

“Clive,” She answered at the first ring. “Are you in position?”

“Almost, Cassiopea.” He whispered back. “There was an unforeseen delay.”

Penny paused on the other end of the line.

“A delay? What caused it?”

“Two Rocket Grunts were in the IT room. They were planning to insert a suspicious flash drive into the League’s systems for nefarious purposes. I managed to stop them and have the device in my pocket.”

He heard the girl nod. “Good work, Clive. I’ll examine it when you get back. for now we need to act fast. Are you in position?”

Clive stepped into the now empty IT room as she said this.

“I am. What do I need to do?”

“Turn on the big computer in front of you and log in. Then, plug in the USB stick I gave you. All you have to do is stay to make sure the download completes itself, and that’s it, I’ll be able to hack into the system.”

“Roger that.”

Clavell quickly completed the steps according to Penny's instructions, and soon he was standing in front of a slowly advancing progress bar.

“... By the way Clive,” She said with an anxious tone. “I finished my analysis of Juliana’s phone.”

He raised an eyebrow. “Oh? Well, I’m sure Miss Juliana will be happy to hear what you’ve learned once we can call you from a safer place.”

“Y-Yeah about that… Actually, Clive, if you wouldn’t mind, I think she should hear it from you in person, and as soon as possible.”

Clavell frowned.

“Very well then. What have you learned, Cassiopeia?”

Things were surprisingly quiet.

Juliana sat against a wall in the League backyard. Poppy played with Ogerpon and Tinkaton in the distance as she tried to relax and ground herself.

Things were okay. She was somewhere safe, with people who did not want to kill her.

She closed her eyes. She could hear Mausholds scurrying through the green grass. A Magnezone and a Garchomp raced around the crater. Her Pokémon laughed excitedly as they played with the child.

She was safe. She had to ignore the barrage of visions that clouded her mind. They weren't real. She was safe.

She jumped when she felt a hand touch her shoulders. She opened her eyes again to see Rika, kneeling beside her.

"You okay there, kid?"

She nodded silently. Juliana didn't trust her voice right now.

To her surprise, Rika sat down next to her.

"Soryy, I won't pry kiddo. But it doesn't take a genius to guess that something's wrong."

Juliana looked at her. Rika smiled and held a piece of paper between her fingers.

"Take this, it's my personal phone number. You can call me anytime, whatever the reason."

Juliana took the piece of paper, stunned. "Wh-Why…?"

"'Cause we care about you, kiddo. Me, Poppy, Hassan, even Larry has a soft spot for you, I know it. You're family to us."

She ruffled her hair despite Juliana's protests.

"Anyway, how about letting out your Clodsire? I hear it's a good Pokémon to hug when you're feeling down," she winked at her.

Juliana's cheeks flushed. H-how did she know?! Thankfully, she was spared the embarrassment when the door next to them opened, revealing a worn-out-looking Clive.

The man's wig was a mess and his eyes were all over the place. Something was wrong, but he made sure to put on a relaxed front in front of Rika.

"Ah, Juliana? Sorry to interrupt but the Director called, you're needed at the academy."

She looked at him for a moment. His whole demeanor seemed to scream '*We need to get out of here as soon as possible, play along.'*

Juliana let out a heavy sigh and slowly got to her feet. She got the attention of her Pokémon, calling Tinkaton and Ogerpon back to their Pokéballs.

"I'm sorry Poppy, Rika, but duty calls. I'll keep in touch, okay? Thanks for everything!"

Poppy gave her a quick hug and said goodbye. Not to be outdone, Rika decided to give her one as well.

"Take care of yourself kiddo- don't push yourself too hard, okay?"

"I-I won't! Promise." Juliana replied.

With two fingers crossed behind her back.

Clavell and Juliana were walking at a safe distance from the League. Her mind was racing since the man came back, she couldn't contain her worry anymore.

"So, out with it Clive. What's wrong?" She asked, repressing the urge to bite her nail.

Clavell cleared his throat.

"Well, first things first, I wanted to offer an apology."

Juliana was surprised. That's not what she had expected.

"An apology? Clavell, my guy, you have nothing to apologize for-"

"Please, let me explain." Clavell interrupted her.

She blinked. That was odd, the director was usually far too polite for that.

"I want to apologize for my clear lack of foresight." He explained, looking serious even with the disguise. "You have suffered a great deal in silence under my tutelage, going through things a child your age should never have to face. More than that, I want to apologize as a friend. I didn't believe your claims when I should have. New evidence has come to light, proving without a shadow of a doubt your claims about Team Rainbow Rocket."

He pulled a flash drive from his pocket, emblazoned with a rainbow R.

It wasn't hard for Juliana to guess what might have happened in the IT room, given Clavell's condition.

She clenched her fists. Team Rainbow Rocket was already on the move, they could not afford any more delays.

"Also, I have news to share about your phone."

That was odd too. She knew Penny, the girl would have wanted nothing more than to share her progress herself. If she didn't, it meant she was worried about her reaction.

"What is it?" She asked, caution in her voice.

"Simply put, your phone was bugged. A spyware program was feeding all of your data directly to someone in the crater. Photo history, geolocation, calls, everything was being monitored and controlled by someone remotely."

O-oh. That, that would explain a lot. How her evidence disappeared, how they were able to ambush her.

Clavell cleared his throat, not done. "What's worse, the spyware could not have gotten on your phone on its own. The Rotom inside would have detected it. It was planted there by receiving infected files from a trusted contact. Penny is still trying to figure out who exactly."

W-wait, that meant-

"I'm sorry Juliana, but it seems that someone close to you has betrayed you."

Ch17 - Calm Before the Storm

“Roaring Moon!” Juliana called. “*Pursuit*!”

The Paradox Pokémon was surrounded by Dark energy, speeding through the air like a bullet towards his fleeting target. He hit it with a thick noise that resonated hard in the room.

The mannequin was smashed to pieces under the might of the attack.

Juliana blinked in shock and exasperation as Roaring Moon flew back to her, catching the treat she threw mid-air in his mouth, happy and proud of his own performance.

She sighed. This was the fourth training prop she broke this afternoon.

The equipment in this Pokémon Gym was really… out of date. It was actually pretty concerning. At this rate, she was scared that Skeledirge would burn down the place just by sneezing.

She moved to replace the mannequin - but the world suddenly started to spin around in a blurry mess of colors. She had to hold herself to a nearby equipment just to stop herself from falling.

Right. Doctor’s orders, don’t strain yourself. That was what she got for ignoring those, huh. Roaring Moon yelped in concern, gaining the attention of Ogerpon who was unleashing hell upon her own training dummy. The Ogre quickly let go of her mace and mask, rushing to her trainer’s side and guiding her gently to a couch.

The world just *wouldn’t stay still* around her. It was actually infuriating.

Roaring Moon kept close in concern as Ogerpon vanished, rushing to the locker room. Juliana was still recovering when the Pokémon came back with her gourd and medication.

Right. She thanked the Pokémon with a pat on the hand as she took the medicine and laid back on the couch, waiting for it to take effect.

She closed her eyes, sighing. She pushed herself too hard, unsurprisingly. Why did she do that?

“I’m sorry Juliana, but it seems that someone close to you has betrayed you.”

Yeah, that was why.

She… She hadn't taken the news well. Clavell had explained everything of course. It, it just…

She always spiraled so easily. Who did it? How? Why? She had very few contacts on her phone: her mother, friends and some teachers. That was it. And if Penny was right, it **had** to be one of them.

So who? Who spied on her, protected criminals and fed information to them?

The who didn't bother her as much as the why. Why? Why would someone close to her want to hurt her? Had she done them wrong? Did one of them secretly hate her and only pretended to be her friend? What was their goal?

Could she trust her friends?

At that point, she had known she spiraled too far. She couldn't accept the doubt, couldn't allow herself to. She could never doubt Nemona, Arven and Penny. Never. She had felt ashamed for even considering it.

So, to avoid any further unpleasant thoughts, she had done what she usually did.

Kept herself occupied.

The problem was, there was nothing to do. After meeting up with everyone in Zapapico, North of the crater, everyone had a task.

Everyone but her.

Penny and Clavell had opted to go and rally Team Star. Gather the Bosses and bring the ex-rebel students to the mining city along with the five Starmobiles. Meanwhile, Nemona had a secret expedition planned with Arven, much to the boy's chagrin. And Juliana?

She had been told, very sternly, to stay and **rest**.

She couldn't rest.

So, she did the only thing she could. She found a rickety abandoned Pokémon Gym in the city thanks to her phone - Penny had finally handed the device back to her after getting rid of the spyware - and threw herself into training.

She knew it wasn't healthy.

She didn’t care.

Juliana had a lot of work to do. She knew the kind of fights and people she needed to face down there, and she needed to be ready. If her battle with Nemona was any indication, she still had a long way to go.

Plus, she had thought of a new strategy to handle Giovanni’s Mewtwo, if it came down to it.

She opened her eyes again. The world was still again, and she could think more clearly. Ogerpon was sitting next to her, humming a tune with a smile on her face. As always, Juliana felt incredibly thankful to the Pokémon.

Roaring Moon sat on the ground in front of her, wide eyes waiting for her to move. She chuckled. Behind his gruff exterior, the Pokémon was actually as sweet as a juvenile Rockruff. And just as full of energy too, if the swing of his tail and the quiet shaking of his body was anything to go by. She threw him another treat, shooing him away as he took off with his tongue swaying in the wind and started flying circles around the room.

In the distance, she could see Tinkaton practicing hammer swings, using Clodsire as a projectile while trying to aim at a Corviknight doll. Clodsire himself came back after each swing, determined. Somehow, it was good training for him too.

Meanwhile, Skeledirge was lazily resting on some piece of furniture. The Pokémon snored in peace, keeping an eye open, surveying the other members of the team. He eventually barked an order from time to time, but otherwise didn’t move.

Good. Juliana didn’t think the Pokémon *could* throw any attack in here without causing more property damage. And he seemed to enjoy his coach role, Juliana thought.

She looked outside the window and frowned. The sun was starting to set, and still no news from Arven and Nemona. She didn’t fret. She knew the two of them could hold their own against anything, but still.

Juliana looked at her phone. Still nothing since the last text from Penny either. The girl had last informed her most of Team Star had arrived and made camp South of the city, preparing for the main event, and nothing after that.

She sighed. Even though it **was** her idea to involve Team Star in the first place, she had quickly grown to regret it. Because that meant the truth of Area Zero would get out.

Also, that she would indirectly involve so, **so** many innocent people into this whole mess.

She had shared her doubts with Clavell and Penny when they first reunited.

“I wouldn’t worry about that,” the ex-leader of Team Star had said, looking up from her computer screen. *“If- nah, **when** they know the truth, they’ll want to get involved no matter what. You have nothing to worry about.”*

She had asked Clavell his own thoughts. *“Truly, I do strongly believe in the youth of Paldea. Only you can bring true change.*” He had answered, fidgeting with the Rocket flashdrive he had gotten at the League. *“Plus, now that I do have physical evidence, there may be some hope with more… official, albeit slower channels.”*

She had found the man calling someone on his phone in secret afterwards, still fiddling with the flashdrive. She barely caught the name on the other end before the Director ended the conversation with a sigh. Something like… Watcher? Peeker? Or was it Loo-

She was brought out of her reminiscing when the door to the gym opened loudly.

“Yo, Juliana!” A male voice shouted.

Giacomo stood at the entrance, in full Team Star costume, with a hand raised and a shit-eating grin on his face. Eri ducked under the doorway behind him, giving her a silent wave.

She stood up from the couch as they approached her.

“Penny sent us,” he explained, “to get you back to base. We’re having a picnic, wanna come?”

Juliana suddenly felt very anxious. She-she wasn’t ready to socialize just yet.

“N-no thanks!” She answered with a shaky smile. “My Pokémon already ate. But thanks for inviting me though!”

Giacomo frowned. “Have **you** eaten, Juliana?”

She gulped.

“I… I had coffee this morning?”

Eri and Giacomo shared a look.

“Welp, just like Penny said. C’mon, do your thing Eri.”

“With pleasure.”

Juliana didn’t have time to react when Eri scooped her up and threw her over her shoulder despite her protests. Her team merely looked at her with amused expressions. The traitors.

“Wha-HEY! Let me down! What are you doing!?” She complained.

“We’re going to the picnic.” Eri answered in a tone that left no room for argument.

The tall girl didn’t react as Juliana tried to wiggle out of grasp, to no avail. They headed out, followed by a chattering Giacomo and the rest of her Pokémon.

She had to admit, the picnic was surprisingly… nice.

Now, Juliana was by no means antisocial. Normally, she’d love this kind of activity. The only reason she was really reluctant at first was because of… everything.

She sighed, leaning on a tree. It was late into the evening now, the sun had set a while ago and the mood was still high among Team Star. They had set up camp in the wilderness, making a giant picnic for all branches and the Team to gather and celebrate. The various Bosses were scattered all around, handling various tasks *that she wasn’t allowed to help with, no Juliana go eat something nice and rest for a bit for the love of Arceus you look like you are about to pass out*.

Harsh, but true.

Still, despite her… reservations, everyone in Team Star was really nice. Though there was a large number of people present she never felt overwhelmed, and no one asked her uncomfortable questions.

Maybe that was because her Pokémon team would stare menacingly at anyone she didn’t know who got too close.

For now though, she stood apart from the party, along with Penny. They discussed their favorite shows next to the line of Starmobiles while Meloco and Ortega meticulously checked every car under the expert eye of Clavell.

Then, the earth began to shake.

At first, it was small, imperceptible. A light tremor that shook only the surface of her drink.

Then, it became more intense. The ground trembled as if a locomotive was thrashing against the ground, loud thumps growing louder and louder in a rhythmic pattern. Juliana had to hold herself to a Starmobile to not fall over.

It was as if something was coming towards them. Something huge.

And then she saw it.

The… beast was charging through the dense forest, knocking down trees on its way. It was a stupendously large Pokémon, armed with two intimidating tusks. She- she had never seen anything like it ever since her Treasure Hunt with Arven.

Wait.

“YOOOHOOOO! JULIANAAAA!” A familiar voice yelled from the back of the towering beast.

She watched in shock as Nemona effortlessly leapt down the Titan-sized Great Tusk.

“Whaaa- Nemona what did you- What is that!?”

Nemona gave her an excited grin and started rambling with passionate energy, making wide gestures all the while.

“Weeeeell, earlier today Arven was telling me about your adventures with Titan Pokémon, and I thought to myself ‘wow that is so cool! I wish I could have battled them, they sound really strong!’ And I'll admit, I was a bit jealous, but then I thought about the Starmobiles, and I thought ‘oh wouldn't it be cool if we had one too just like the Star Bosses!’ but then I realized it was probably not possible because we wouldn’t have time to make another one. So I put two and two together and came up with the best idea: what if we rode like a HUGE Pokémon! Like, like that one Great Tusk Arven told me about! So I asked Arven about it and he said something like ‘you’re crazy Nemona, these are super strong Pokémon that would be super cool to battle and you’re not getting anywhere near them’ and I said ‘that’s stupid!’ and-”

She was interrupted as something crashed next to her. Arven got up with a groan of pain, having just fallen off the Titan Pokémon's back.

“Hey! Quit spreading lies you hyperactive Scorbunny!” He complained, getting back up. “I never said that!”

“Did so!”

“Did not!”

“DID SO!”

“DID NO-”

“Ahem.”

Their bickering was interrupted by Clavell, clearing his throat to get their attention. They both reddened as they noticed a curious crowd was forming around the Titan Pokémon.

“So, let me get this straight.” Juliana said, bracing herself for the coming headache. “You two **captured** and tamed a Titan Great Tusk, a known hyper-aggressive and territorial Pokémon that can easily smash through a building, just so we could ride it into the crater?”

“H-hey, to be fair I wasn’t fully on board with the idea!” Arven protested.

“You’re the one who insisted on coming along!” Nemona interjected.

“Because you would have been mauled by a Titan-sized Paradox Pokémon if I wasn’t there to hold you back!”

Juliana sighed.

“Arceus, I love you both. But please, next time you're going to do something like this, tell me first, so I don't have a heart attack when you come marching in on the back of the Greatest Tusk I've ever seen.”

They both gave her a sheepish grin.

“Sorry, we won’t do it again little buddy.”

“I promise Jules, I’ll let you come along next time!”

Juliana began to notice the crowd growing. Penny turned to her.

“We’re all ready on our end Juliana. Now might be a good time for you to make a speech before we storm the crater.”

She froze. Her? A speech?

“Wha- me? Why?! Aren’t you supposed to be their leader?!”

Penny shook her head.

“Nah, only the bosses know about my involvement with Team Star, the members don’t know me. But you, they’ve all seen you in battle. And they know that you’re close to the bosses, so they respect you.”

Juliana anxiously looked once more at the crowd, gathered around the Paradox Pokémon.

These people came here of their own free will. They had no idea what was happening. None of them knew anything about the crater, Paradox Pokémon or about Team Rainbow Rocket. Yet, they still chose to follow their leaders into the unknown, unaware of the risks and consequences.

She turned back to Penny, deeply conflicted. Her choice was made when she saw the unflinching determination in her eyes.

“Okay,” she sighed. “Help me get up there.”

Juliana never had stage fright. She wasn’t usually shy or nervous in front of an audience. In fact, she was usually in her element. She quite enjoyed the spotlight when it meant putting on a show for the entertainment of others.

But **this**? This was different.

She stood atop the Titan Pokémon, a microphone in her trembling hand, connected to the Starmobiles’ speakers. A large crowd was gathered below her, waiting for her to speak.

She closed her eyes and took a deep breath, willing for her heart to slow down. She needed to be calm for this. She had to put up a solid front. She couldn’t let fear and doubt take over - not in front of so many people.

A thousand eyes rested on her.

She was going to tell the truth about Area Zero.

Sada died because of her.

Get it together, she thought.

A hand touched her shoulder, warm and comforting.

She turned to see Clavell. The man had helped her up the Titan Pokémon and was planning to stand beside her during her… speech.

“You’ll do fine,” Clavell said with a warm smile, looking directly in her eyes. “I’ll be by your side. Do what you must.”

Her breath caught. She couldn’t help but hug the man with teary eyes here and there, unbothered by the number of people watching. Pulling back, she didn’t even find herself embarrassed - she had found the courage she needed.

She turned towards the crowd with a grin and waved.

“Hey everyone! Thanks for coming! How are you doing tonight?” She said into the mic.

The roar of the crowd answered her, easily overpowering the speakers. Yeah, they were doing well.

“So!” She called, gaining back the attention of the crowd. “Let’s get down to business. You’re probably all wondering why you’re here, and what the big deal is. I’ll do my best to answer all your questions.”

She sighed inwardly. *Here we go*.

“First things first: let’s address the Donphan in the room, so to speak. The Pokémon I am standing on is called a Great Tusk, although this individual’s size is more… drastic than other members of its species.”

She took a Pokéball and let out Roaring Moon, who cheerfully flew around under the awes of the crowd.

“And this is the Roaring Moon.” She continued. “These two Pokémon are part of a larger group, called ‘Paradox Pokémon’. Species that are long-lost ancestors of Pokémon you know today, coming from a distant past when they had to be much stronger to survive. Though most of them have evolved or disappeared over time, some still inhabit the crater of Paldea.”

Her voice took a more serious tone as Roaring Moon landed next to her.

“I must insist on this, but these Pokémon are, on their own, immensely powerful and dangerous. That’s why we tried to keep their existence a secret until now, until we figure out what to do with them. If they escape from the crater, they could spell ecological disaster for all of Paldea.”

She took out her phone and opened the Pokédex app.

“I will now share with you the Pokédex entries of all known Paradox Pokémon. Please everyone, have your phone ready.”

Her finger hovered over the share button for a few seconds. Unsure about what she was about to do.

The information she had tried so hard to keep private. To hide from the whole region. Out in the open for the first time. The thought was overwhelming. Would they figure out the rest from there?

She shook her head. It was too late to back down. She pressed the button and heard a good number of **dings** from the crowd.

That was it.

She took a deep breath, closing her eyes. Now was the hard part.

“A few months ago, during the Treasure Hunt,” she began, “I had to go into the crater along with my friends to ensure the safety of the region. And if I’m standing here now in front of you now, it’s because we have to do it again.”

She looked over the crowd, everyone was watching her in silence. Her fist was tight around the mic. So tight it hurt.

“I’ll be blunt: we are in need of your help. The first time we went into the crater, things were bad. But we made it out. Things… have changed since then. I-I am ashamed to say that a criminal organization, Team Rainbow Rocket, has taken control of the crater right under our noses. They’re wreaking havoc down there, threatening the region once again. They’re responsible for a lot of bad things, you may know them as Pokémon thieves. They…”

She gulped, voice wavering.

“They stole Pokémon from me, too.”

Ignoring the sudden roar of the crowd, she continued.

“I was stupid to think I could handle these people alone, and my partners paid the price. They are dangerous, there is no denying that. But, there is strength in numbers. The League is compromised, but you, you have always stood for freedom and justice. That's why I know I can trust you all. I- I would not blame anyone for backing down now. But I need your help. Paldea needs your help. If any of you have doubts, please, now is your chance to walk away.”

She closed her eyes and waited for the silence to pass. People should start leaving now.

She didn’t blame them.

They had no reason to help her. What happened was her responsibility after all. She did everything she could to make them understand the risks. If she had to do it alone, so be it. At least others would not throw their lives away for her.

“RAID THE CRATER!” A man shouted.

Huh?

“YEAH, RAID THE CRATER!” Another yelled.

She opened up her eyes to see the crowd chanting those words again and again, growing in intensity.

No one had left.

They were all here, hyping up this dangerous expedition. Even the Pokémon were joining in the excitement, the Great Tusk itself letting out a determined roar. Some were already discussing strategies, pointing at their Pokédex.

She felt her eyes water. They- they stayed?

She turned to Clavell, who smiled at her stunned expression. Someone climbed up the Titan beside her. Nemona put an arm around her neck, careful not to startle her.

“They’re here for you Jules, we all are.” She said. “We’re all following you down there, whether you like it or not.”

Penny was glad that things were going so well. To be honest, while she knew Team Star would be nothing but supportive and excited about her plan, Juliana’s nervousness was infectious.

At the very least, things were going smoothly for now. She could hear the roar of the crowd and the chant as Juliana finished talking.

She looked up at the night sky, pausing her work on her laptop. She had been occupied during the big speech with Clavell's odd request of transferring the files from the Rocket flash drive to an encrypted address. It was easy enough for her, but time consuming.

There was a full moon tonight. She couldn't see the stars because of Team Star's artificial lights.

Ha, ironic.

Maybe she could still see them if she tried hard enough. Penny used to love to look at the stars with her father. If she squeezed her eyes hard enough...

Wait, what was that?

In the distance, a shadowy figure hovered over the crater. Two eyes flashed through the darkness.

It was watching them.

Suddenly, the eyes turned to her. She felt an immense panic, like a Weedle spotted by a Pidgeot. She closed her eyes and used her arms to shield herself from the coming attack…

…That never came.

Cautiously, she opened her eyes again. The figure was gone, as if it had never existed.

Penny sighed. Maybe… maybe she was a little tired. Maybe she just imagined it. It must have been nothing. She went back to working on her laptop, not noticing the dark figure in the distance, slowly sinking back into the clouds above the crater.

Ch18 - Meeting Old Friends

“Clodsire, use *Poison Tail*! Skeledirge, *Torch Song*!”

Juliana’s Clodsire hit the Rocket Grunt’s Clefable with full force, knocking it out in one clean hit. A flaming bird flew past her head from behind and landed on the Slither Wing as it crept up on the side, scorching the beast.

The Rocket Grunt cursed at her and ran off, while the Paradox Pokémon retreated to heal its wounds. She used the second of silence to collect her thoughts.

They were in the crater. She, along with her friends and Team Star, had gone through the tunnel that led to Area Zero. Thankfully, Penny’s trick with the League clearance had worked and they were allowed in- though they hadn’t expected so much resistance right off the bat.

From the moment they entered the crater of Paldea, they were forced to fight on two fronts against an organized Team Rainbow Rocket and frenzied Paradox Pokémon.

Though they did well enough, with the Starmobiles doing much of the heavy lifting to keep the most dangerous ancient beasts occupied, it was a struggle. They weren’t making much progress, and her own team was getting tired. So much was happening at the same time, it was just like the Star Raids all over again.

“Tinkaton!”

Juliana directed her Pokémon as Tinkaton kicked a heavy boulder with her giant hammer, smashing it into a flying horde of Golbats that were surrounding the Fairy type Starmobile. Ortuga gave her a grateful nod as he rammed the vehicle into a line of Brute Bonnets.

Juliana breathed heavily, stopping by a rock. She had been running around all over the battlefield now, she just needed to catch her breath. The world was spinning - why was it spinning?

She didn’t have time to rest as she had to duck to avoid the overhead attack of a wild Roaring Moon.

She shook her head, repressing a headache as the world slowly came back into place. She was getting sick of these guys.

The Dragon Pokémon seemed to have decided to target her as it swung again, forcing her to roll away to avoid having her shoulder torn off. With the onslaught, she didn’t even notice the Paradox Pokémon separating her from the rest of the group.

Soon enough, Juliana found herself alone on a bridge, surrounded by Rocket Grunts. Her own Pokémon were holding off the criminals and the battle was at a standstill.

“Rhydon, use Earthquake!”

Until one of the grunts had a bright idea.

The whole area shook violently, causing Juliana to fall to her knees.

Beside her, a huge crystal broke from the wall and crashed heavily to the ground.

It was too much.

The weakened floor gave way beneath her, Juliana barely held onto the edge of the bridge with one hand to keep from falling.

She made the mistake of looking down.

Her feet were dangling uselessly several miles from the hard ground. The wind howled in her ears, promising a world of pain if she ever let go. Rubbles teared from the crumbling platform, falling far, far down into the abyss without ever touching the ground.

Her fingers were slowly slipping.

That- that was a really bad position. She could hear the distressed cries of her Pokémon from atop the platform.

Juliana tried to pull herself up.

It was useless, she didn’t have the strength with only one hand. What… what was she going to do?

Another tremor shook the bridge. The ledge she was hanging from was weakened as well. Juliana watched in horror as cracks appeared all along the rocky formation. She felt the ledge slowly loosen under her own weight.

Until, finally, it gave away.

She was falling.

“I’ve got you!”

Or not.

Someone caught her wrist at the last moment. She looked up to see the very panicked face of Nemona. The girl herself was hanging only from the ribbons of Penny's Sylveon wrapped around her leg. The Pokémon, her trainer and Arven were struggling to pull them both up onto the platform.

Finally, after what seemed like hours, they were hoisted up to the bridge. Juliana took a moment to recover from her near-death experience.

"Are you okay?" Nemona asked.

"M'okay thanks… not the first time I jump off a cliff." She tried a joke, unable to conceal the waviness in her voice nor the loud pounding of her heart.

She got worried looks. She winced - it landed flat. Her joke didn't lighten the mood as she intended.

"C'mon," she complained, "I've had worse than that before! Besides, I'm fine now, no use dwelling on it." She stood up, trying her best to steady her still shaky knees.

"That doesn't make me feel any better, bud', but if you say so." Arven shrugged. "So, what do we do now?"

"Well, first we'd better get off this bridge. Then, now that the way is clear, I should be able to brute force my way to their HQ while you guys help out Team Star-"

"Nuh huh! No way!" Penny interjected. "You're not doing this alone Juliana, we've been over this."

Juliana raised her hands apologetically. "I know, I know! It's just that I… I don't know if I'll have another chance to sneak away, and we can't just all leave Team Star behind to fend for themselves!"

"Tell you what," Arven argued. "We can split up. Penny and I will stay here and deal with the mess, while you go with Nemona and get your Pokémon back."

To Juliana's relief they all reluctantly agreed to Arven's plan, but not before Penny made her promise not to run off on her own. Before she knew it, Juliana and Nemona were riding the Titan Great Tusk, crashing through Team Rainbow Rocket's lines of defenses.

Koraidon, Terapagos, hold on. I'm coming for you.

The halls of Team Rainbow Rocket HQ were a pain, Juliana thought to herself.

After separating from the group, she and Nemona had finally entered the suspicious building by taking out the guards in battle. Since then, they had been running through this endless *maze* of teleporters and security cameras disguised as Persian statues. And now?

They were lost.

Juliana had to admit that she was exhausted. They had fought endless waves of grunts and shady scientists throughout the whole ordeal, with no end in sight.

To be honest, she was glad that Nemona was with her. The girl's passion for combat was contagious. Juliana looked at her. She had a wild grin on her face, clearly enjoying herself as she battled a single grunt guarding the corridor.

Still, her posture was a bit less energetic than usual. Even she must have gotten tired of this.

Nemona won the battle easily and sent the grunt running, all the while Juliana was busy trying to decipher a map of the building propped on the wall. It made no sense.

"Whoo! Another one done! Let's go Julia- AH!" Her rival yelped.

"Nemona? Are you okay?" Juliana called after her, unable to see what happened.

She rushed to her partner and found her sitting on the floor, confused. Juliana helped her back to her feet.

"I-I'm fine! Something just caught me off guard when I opened the door, that's all!"

"What do you mean?" Juliana asked, curious.

"I think it might have been a Pokémon? I opened the door and a small figure rushed past me and into the hallway."

Juliana frowned. "Speaking of which: What's wrong with **this** hallway?"

The whole corridor in front of them was unlike any other they had seen before, mechanical doors lining the walls. Juliana made her way to one of them and tried to open it, to no avail. She tried to look through the thick glass, but saw only darkness in the room.

“H-hey Jules? Check this out.” Nemona said in a nervous voice.

Juliana turned to Nemona and saw the girl looking through another door. She went over and looked into the room.

A larger than usual Scream Tail was sleeping in a vat filled with a glowing blue liquid. The vat was mounted on top of a crystal, with remnants of Herba Mystica scattered around the room.

It was disturbing to see.

“See the Herba Mystica? Do you think they’re trying to recreate Titan Pokémon?” Nemona asked.

Juliana frowned. “I honestly don’t know, but-”

She was interrupted when something soft rammed into her legs, almost causing her to fall to the ground if it weren’t for Nemona catching her. Was that a-

“Is that a Furret?” Nemona echoed her thoughts. She crouched down to the Pokémon’s level. “What are you doing here little guy?”

The Furret looked at her curiously and clung to Juliana’s leg. Did… Did she know this Pokémon?

A whistle rang through the halls. The Furret perked up and took off, chirping excitedly at the end of the corridor while looking expectantly at her and Nemona.

“Well,” the girl giggled. “Looks like he wants us to follow him. What do you think, Jules?”

Juliana nodded. “Let’s follow him.”

They followed the Furret together until Juliana heard voices coming from down the hall. She stopped and hid behind Persian statues, silently motioning for Nemona to do the same.

Furret looked at them in confusion before deciding to hide alongside Juliana. The Pokémon jumped into her arms, content with its position.

From what she could hear, a boy and a girl were walking in their direction. They seemed to be arguing about something.

“...’m telling you! These guys are super weird! I’m worried sis…” Said a very familiar voice.

“Don’t you think I don’t know! I don’t even know why we’re still here Kiki!” The girl replied, also familiar to her.

“Yeah…” The boy replied, sounding defeated. “...Maybe I should call Furret again, I hope he’s not lost...”

Juliana knew those voices. She knew who they belonged to. But it couldn’t be them, could it? Not down here! Not after everything!

Crystals shattered all around her. The boy looked at her with hate and envy.

After some more arguing, she heard the boy whistle loudly. The Furret in her arms chirped excitedly despite her attempts to calm it.

"There!" Someone called and started to run.

They were coming. She- she wasn’t ready yet. The footsteps came closer and closer as she held the Pokémon, praying that somehow they wouldn’t see her. She closed her eyes.

The Terastallized Hydrapple fell to the ground. The boy stood stunned and motionless for a few moments under the gaze of the crowd, before cupping his head in his hands and falling to his knees.

He mumbled “no” over and over.

She heard someone stop in front of her.

“Wha- Juliana?!” Kieran exclaimed, stunned.

She opened her eyes to see the boy, still wearing the same Blueberry Academy uniform and red shirt as ever. Carmine soon reached him, panting, and had a similar reaction.

“...Hey, guys?” Juliana waved awkwardly. The Furret jumped out of her arms and climbed onto Kieran’s shoulder. She came out of her hiding place together with Nemona, the girl greeting them as well.

“What are you doing here?” Kieran asked, confused. “N-not that I’m not glad to see you! It’s been a while! I-I-I’m just surprised, that’s all!”

Carmine chuckled and muttered something about her brother being “adorably obvious” as the boy’s cheeks reddened.

“That’s… That’s a really long story, and we don’t have time for it right now.”

Kieran smiled. “That’s okay! I’m just glad-”

“You look terrible.” Carmine interjected, looking at Juliana with a critical eye.

“Sis!” Kieran huffed while Nemona burst out laughing.

“What! That’s true! You’re seeing her, right! Sure, she has always looked ragged since we first met her, but never this bad! She’s even worse than you were, back at the BB League!”

Kieran gasped. “C’mon, I wasn’t that bad! I just didn’t really rest. Or sleep, in general. But…” He sighed. “Okay, I get it. But that’s still not a nice thing to say!”

Carmine rolled her eyes playfully, a smile on her face. “Okay, okay! Geez… Sorry Juliana.”

Juliana chuckled despite herself at the brotherly benter. These two hadn’t changed, that was nice to know. Thankfully she felt more at ease now, trying not to think too hard about her and Kieran’s history. They had both agreed it was over afterall.

“So… What are you doing here? I thought that the two of you were supposed to be at Blueberry Academy right now?” She asked, trying to stop her heart from pounding.

“Well…” Carmine’s smile faded. “On paper, we’re here to accompany Miss Briar and help her with her research. Normally it would just be me, but she asked Kiki to come along, since this is Area Zero. But I dunno, things have been weird since we got here? She won’t tell us what exactly she’s researching here, she’s working with these weird guys, and we kinda haven’t seen her for days?”

“Last we’ve heard of her, she told us to ‘get ready for action’, whatever that means. Supposedly she’s working on some confidential stuff that we’re not allowed to see yet.” Kieran filled them in.

Juliana was taken aback. Briar? Briar was here? Now that she thought about it, it made sense. Giovanni did mention her research before. But still, was she here of her

own free will? Had the teacher been tricked by Team Rainbow Rocket? With what she knew about her, it was a possibility.

She sighed. “Okay. That’s- that’s bad.”

She shared a worried look with Nemona.

“Could you please take us to where she works? We need to talk to her.” The girl asked.

Carmen looked unsure but Kieran nodded, a smile on his face.

“Sure! The thing is, we don’t really know where she is. But I know someone who does! Come with me.”

The group followed Kieran through the corridors. Fortunately they didn’t run into any grunts. Her team was finally able to rest, for once.

Juliana was glad for the chance to catch up with him and Carmine, she hadn’t seen them since the whole ‘Pecharunt’ fiasco in Kitakami. Looking back, she had only ever really interacted with both of them in times of emergency.

Someday, when she would be able to look Kieran in the face without feeling overwhelming guilt, she’d take them with her other friends to relax and go on vacation together, she decided.

For now, it looked like Kieran got Furret back on his team. That was good. The Pokémon was never really interested in fighting when she met him and his trainer in Kitakami.

So when Kieran hungered for power and revenge, like all things ‘childish’ in his life, he simply replaced it.

Now though, it looked like the two of them had reconnected. She was glad to see them so close to each other once again, just like when she first met them.

She sighed inwardly. She… She had really screwed back then, hadn’t she? It was because of her that they fell apart after all, because Kieran had no other way to beat her.

“...you listening, Jules?” Nemona asked, pulling her out of her reverie with a shake.

“Yes?” She answered without thinking, then reconsidered. “No. Sorry, I spaced out.” ***again***, she thought.

Nemona chuckled. “Kieran was telling us about that one forest in Kitakami! We have to visit it next time we go there Juliana, there are rumors of a super strong Ursaring-like Pokémon!”

“Oh-oh… I think I know the one ‘Mona, sorry, I already battled it. I’ll show you its Pokédex entry after this, I promise!”

Nemona deflated. “Aw shucks! Oh well… By the way you two, who’s the guy we’re going to meet?”

“An old man who works with Briar on her research.” Kieran said. “He’s really nice, don’t worry about it! I think they met when he visited Blueberry Academy? He’s the one who offered her to come here, though I think she called him first. You’ll see him at the end of this hallway, once we’re past the battle arena and the labs. His name is Gio-”

“Ah, there you are!” Another familiar voice interrupted the boy from around the corner.

Wait.

Before she could process what was happening, a tall woman appeared from behind Kieran and Carmine.

“Greetings, Juliana.” Geeta said, watching her with an unreadable expression and a cold tone. “I must say, I am very disappointed in you.”

Juliana froze in shock. La Primera’s eyes burned into hers, piercing her soul.

“Not only do you continue to disregard your own well-being, but you have directly disobeyed orders from the League. You are once again trespassing into the crater, interfering with invaluable research and causing great distress to the local wildlife. This time, you've even gotten your friends into trouble. I expected better from you.”

“Wait, La Primera, please!” Nemona interjected. “You don’t understand! Team-”

Geeta held up a hand, silencing the girl. “Champion Nemona. It would have been your responsibility to keep your dear friend out of harm’s way. Yet, here you stand beside her, at the bottom of Area Zero.”

“I…” Her words caught in her throat.

“Follow me, you two.” La Primera said in a tone that left no room for arguments. “We will discuss this matter further at the League, after you have ordered your friends up there to retreat from Area Zero.”

“No!” Juliana exclaimed. She winced- she didn’t mean to shout. “I-I… I’m not leaving without Koraidon and Terapagos!”

Nemona nodded beside her, holding out a Pokéball in challenge. Juliana held the woman’s burning gaze for what seemed like hours. Finally, Geeta turned to Kieran.

“Very well. Kieran, was it? I have heard you were once a Champion rank trainer in the BB League, correct?”

“Y-yes?” The boy answered, surprised.

Geeta clapped her hands, a satisfied look on her face.

“Good! Well then, I may require your assistance in this matter. You see, your friend Juliana, as you may have noticed, has been overworking herself to the point of exhaustion. She has hardly had any rest or sleep for the past few months, and I am quite concerned about her physical and mental health. You would agree that it would be harmful for her to continue down this path, would you not?”

Kieran’s fist clenched, the boy looking deep in thought.

“I wish nothing more than for her safety, but I am afraid Miss Juliana is unfortunately not in a mental state where she can make rational decisions. She has been delusional for some time about a conspiracy involving people who care about the welfare of this region. Will you help me stop her?”

Kieran avoided her gaze. “I… I don’t…”

“Do you want her to get hurt?”

His eyes snapped back to hers, wide with shock.

“You know full well the dangers of exhaustion in a place like this, don’t you?”

Carmine touched the boy’s shoulder, making him jump. His hands were shaking. They exchanged a look before Kieran clenched his teeth, and turned back to La Primera.

“...Okay. I’ll do it.” He looked at Juliana, avoiding her eyes. “I-I’m sorry Juliana. I’m not sure I understand what’s going on, but it’s for your own good.” He put a hand to his belt and took a Pokéball, trying to stop his hands from shaking. His gaze kept fleeting to Carmine who watched from the side, arms crossed with an unsure look on her face.

“You…” He continued. “You stopped me when I needed you to, back then. You saved me from myself. It’s time for me to help you, too.”

Two Pokéballs were sent out onto the field, Poliwrath and Glimmora facing them.

Nemona turned to her with a smile.

“Alright! Let’s do this, Juliana!” She said as she threw a Pokéball onto the field, revealing a very pumped up Pawmot.

Juliana silently nodded, gripping a Pokéball at her belt.

Ch19 - Wrong Turn

Juliana had to admit, this was going better than she had expected.

She was stressed, going into a Pokémon Battle against Kieran and Geeta. The former was an incredible trainer in the BB League and a Double Battle prodigy, and the latter wasn't her boss for nothing. She always had a hard time facing her when the woman actually got serious.

Suffice it to say, the Top Champion was not messing around this time.

Even so, she and Nemona made for a perfect Multi Battle combination. Battling against each other so much, the rivals covered each other's weaknesses perfectly, even commanding the other's Pokémon. Despite their combined power, Kieran and Geeta were no match for the pair. They were down to their last two Pokémon: a Hydrapple and a Flying type Terastallized Kingambit.

On their side, Juliana and Nemona had Clodsire and Milotic out, both waiting for an order from their trainer. The girls exchanged a look and nodded in unison, communicating without words.

Nemona took the lead. "Clodsire! Use Stone Edge and take down Kingambit!" She called to Juliana's Pokémon.

"No you don't!" Kieran reacted. "Hydrapple, cover him with a Fickle Beam!"

"Milotic!" Juliana shouted. "Ice Beam!"

The attack hit Kieran's Pokémon before it could fire off its own, knocking it out instantly with a four times super-effective move. Nothing could stop her Clodsire from launching itself towards Kingambit with surprising speed.

To Geeta's credit, the Pokémon did its best to avoid the blow. Even so, it wasn't prepared for the sheer ferocity of the seemingly slow and carefree Spiny Fish Pokémon.

The attack hit critically, and Kingambit lost consciousness before it even hit the ground.

They had won.

A sigh of relief escaped Juliana's lips as she happily scooped up Clodsire, while Nemona was busy cooing over a surprisingly smug Milotic. Across the battlefield, she could see Kieran quietly thanking his downed Hydrapple. He looked almost glad

to have lost. Carmine made her way to the boy, the both of them talking in hushed tones.

Next to him, Geeta simply returned Kingambit to his Pokéball. She was silent, an unreadable expression on her face. Then, slowly, she began to clap her hands with an eerie smile.

“Once again, you two have managed to exceed my expectations. It seems that Paldea still has two wonderful trainers to be proud of!”

“It’s over Geeta!” Juliana said. “You’ve lost! You can’t stop us now. I’m getting my Pokémon back, whether you like it or not!”

The woman closed her eyes and folded her hands behind her back.

“No. I’m afraid I can’t allow you to go on like this, Juliana. This has to stop, now-”

A sudden, violent tremor shook the room. Juliana barely managed to hold on, thanks to her Pokémon, while Nemona, Carmine and Kieran fell to the floor. Geeta didn’t even flinch.

A device on her belt rang three times. She picked it up and looked at the information on the screen.

“... Area Zero is now deeply unstable. The experiment is putting too much strain on the crater. Your ‘distraction’ up there cost the manpower needed to keep things safe.”

She looked Juliana directly in the eyes, expression unreadable.

“We must change course.”

She clicked a button on the device. An alarm sounded throughout headquarters.

“Please, Juliana, follow me inside.”

Geeta quickly left through the door she had come from, which began to close of its own accord.

Juliana’s breath caught. It was a trap.

It was so, *so obviously* a trap.

Geeta **wanted** her to follow her. Alone. And the door was already closing, adding a sense of urgency.

Juliana was painfully aware how much it was a trap.

…

But Geeta was her only lead on Koraidon and Terapagos.

Once that door closed, it was over. She wouldn't be able to open it again.

She looked around. With the tremor, Juliana was the only one still standing. The others wouldn't make it.

She'd be the only one fast enough to get through that door before it closed for good.

But she would leave them all behind.

She would go alone.

Exactly what she had promised not to do.

In the future, looking back on that day, Juliana knew she had made a mistake. There were many things she could have done differently: her Pokémon could have held the door open for them, or they could have found another way in. Heck, she'd even bet that Tinkaton could smash the door open with a good Gigaton Hammer.

But at that moment she panicked. Her legs moved on their own, her fingers clutching Clodsire tightly to her chest. Juliana made a decision that she would go on to regret.

Carmine reached for her. Kieran yelled her name. Nemona watched without a sound, a thousand words in her gaze that broke her heart.

She ran through the door just as it closed behind her, ignoring the muffled cries of her friends.

Hungry.

The beast was hungry. That was all it could feel.

No, that was wrong. It also hurt. Its legs hurt, as did its whole body. Especially its head.

Why did it hurt? It didn't know. It was content to just lie there for now, trying to ignore the pain pulsing through its body as it drifted off to sleep.

Still, its mind was active, if a little foggy.

Where was it? Everything was dark, it couldn’t see beyond the metal bars of its prison.

What had happened? It remembered falling from the sky, trying to protect… something.

Something it had never seen again.

Concern grew in the beast’s foggy mind. What was this thing? Was it safe? It couldn’t understand how worried it was about something it couldn’t remember.

A loud sound interrupted its thoughts. It whimpered.

It knew, just by the smell. Someone was approaching. A human. They would try to hurt it again, to subject it to their strange crystal. But it wouldn’t let them. It would continue to drive them away, just like last time.

It rose lazily to its feet, stretching out its crystallized paws with a yawn.

It was ready.

It would make whoever came in regret ever having faced the Winged King from a past long gone.

Juliana had lost Geeta.

She swore under her breath. Of course the whole damn facility beyond that stupid door had to be completely in the dark! Somehow that obnoxious woman had disappeared without a trace while she was left stumbling into every single wall trying to follow her.

She rubbed her head. It was a miracle she hadn’t suffered a concussion from running so hard into the corner of a doorway.

Her phone vibrated in her pocket. That was right, her phone! How stupid she was, she had a light source! Why hadn’t she thought of that before!?

She reached for her pocket, but stopped when a thought came to her.

Penny had said that someone she trusted had betrayed her. Could it have been Geeta? The Top Champion was certainly in a position where it would be easy for her to install spyware on her phone. And she was working with Team Rainbow Rocket, but… would she do that?

Could she really be responsible for the attempt on her life?

Juliana was brought out of her reverie when her phone rang again, almost more angrily. Right.

She fished it out of her pocket to see that someone was calling her. The screen was beyond cracked at this point after everything she'd been through, she couldn't recognise the number. Still, she answered. It could be her friends, needing help.

"Hello?"

"Hi, Juliana. Do you have ANY idea what kind of mess you've all gotten yourselves into?" A weary sounding Rika asked.

Juliana swallowed but continued, using the light from her phone to guide her through the corridor.

"Well… I…"

"You," Rika interrupted. "Are in **serious** trouble now. What don't you understand by 'do not go into the crater'!? It's a simple rule, I couldn't have made it any clearer!"

Juliana turned around a corner and spotted a faint light in the room at the end of the corridor. Probably a monitor. She walked towards it.

"I told you to rest, and now I learn that **not only** did you somehow break into the crater again, but you've also brought along half of Paldea with you! I can't even get a hold of Clavell! Why is the director of one of the most prestigious academies in the world as irresponsible as a child!"

Juliana tuned out of Rika's ranting as she approached the suspicious room.

To say it was messy was an understatement. The state of the room was even worse than the Professor's lab, or even Arven's bedroom on a bad day.

The only light in the lab came from a cracked computer screen sitting on a desk filled to the brim with random papers and documents. Medical equipment was strewn

about the room: syringes of a suspicious glowing liquid, bandages and potions littered the floor between several blood splatters. Yet, even that was not what caught Juliana's full attention.

Everything was covered in thick crystal dust, most likely coming from the statue standing in front of the computer.

A person was there, entirely crystallized.

Juliana couldn't make out any distinctive features, the thick layers of crystal covering everything. The person was not moving, not even breathing. They just stood there, frozen in time.

An arm was missing.

It was lying on the ground next to them, completely crystallized as well. Looking at the person's position, it most likely collapsed under its own weight.

Whoever this was, they were clearly pinned against the computer. Juliana couldn't see their faces, but they looked absolutely *terrified*.

She could only imagine their expression, frozen in time under the layers of blue crystal that covered it. What had happened to them? What were they so afraid of?

What did they feel in their last moment, as the crystal spread around their body, preserving their final act for all eternity? Did they pray to their god for a swift death? Did they die alone, surrounded only by the weight of their actions? Were their last thoughts grief for their loved ones, or regret that they couldn't do more? Did-

"...Juliana?"

Right. She was still on the phone with Rika. She didn't have time to freeze up like that. The Elite 4 member must have sensed that something was wrong, because she had stopped her ranting altogether and was now speaking with a worried voice.

"Juliana, are you okay? What's happening?"

"...I- I- I'm sorry Rika, I'll call you back." She answered without thinking, not even trying to hide the waviness of her own voice.

"Hey wait!-" Juliana ended the call there.

She closed her eyes and inhaled deeply. Okay, she could do this. She had to. She just had to ignore her worries and keep moving forward. She wouldn't stop until the work was done.

She opened her eyes and scanned the room once more. Ignoring the horrific statue, the documents and the computer caught her attention. Maybe she could gather some information there. Juliana approached the desk, careful not to touch the frozen person next to her.

The documents were calculations and scientific notes that she couldn't even begin to decipher. Still, she made sure to take pictures of each of them on her phone for later, just in case. From what she could gather, the people here were basing their research on Professor Sada's. Trying to unlock the full potential of the crystals of Area Zero to make Pokémon stronger, but also rebuild and upgrade the Professor's Time Machine using technology and research stolen from Alolan laboratories.

Notes were scrawled haphazardly on the various papers. They all said something along the lines of 'Reality can be whatever I want it to be' or 'I will shape a world of the Professor's dreams'. With nothing else of value to be gleaned from the papers, Juliana moved to the computer.

So much data was stored here. Text and video logs of experiments done in this very lab, tons of data, reports and orders from above. Just scrolling through the files made her dizzy, she wasn't sure where to even start.

That was until she came across a file named "project_terapagos.mp4".

She never clicked on anything faster in her life. A video player popped up, but only sound could be heard.

"Hello? Is this on? It looks like the computer isn't recording video." Said a familiar feminine voice.

"That's because the camera is broken due to yesterday's experiment, ma'am." Replied a polite male voice.

"Ah, that's a shame! Oh well. Let's try to be brief with today's log, shall we? I am already late for our meeting with Miss Geeta afterall."

"Sure ma'am. I'll clean up here in the meantime." She heard shuffling noises as the man presumably stepped away from the computer and the woman took his place.

"So. First things first: we were able to confirm our theory. Terastallization seems to work by rewriting organic matter at the molecular level. Fortunately, the phenomenon

appears to be completely harmless and temporary to Pokémon in small doses. However, we theorized that the nature of any organic matter could be irreversibly changed if exposed to Terastal energy of great duration and intensity."

Where had she heard that voice before? She knew this person. She just knew it.

"If the Terastillized tree discovered in the depths of Area Zero or the numerous spices found around the Paldean Terastal dens weren't enough proof of that, we were finally able to succeed in recreating this phenomenon. As of today, we have completely Terastilized a batch of flowers imported from Kalos. This is great progress! Thanks to that, we should be able to move on to other types of organisms very soon."

Her name was at the tip of her tongue. Where had she met this person? Was it at the Academy? Or in Kitakami?

"It must be stated that this extreme phenomenon is likely to be deeply harmful to the organism that experiences it. If uncontrolled, Terastal energy will quickly spread like an infection, irreversibly corrupting cells. These safety concerns must be considered, but should not stop us from working toward our ultimate goals. Terastal energy still holds so much potential, we can't stop here. We must move forward to continue creating a world of the Professor's dreams. Unleash the full potential of Pokémon, as my dear friend Colress would say."

The woman paused for a second, a wicked smile heard in her voice.

"I wonder what level of power one could achieve with this?"

Someone knocked at the door. She hastily resumed her monologue.

"All of which begs the question: where does this power come from? The answer: Terapagos. I believe-"

A loud noise interrupted Juliana's focus on the recording. She turned around, on her guard, trying to see anything in the darkness of the room.

Another loud noise erupted. Something was banging against metal. Hard. The person in the recording continued her monologue.

"...need the Professor's research, in her lab. Problem is, we can't get the door open. We need the key, which is most likely in the girl's possession. That, along with Terapagos, will have to be retrieved as-"

The banging became louder and louder.

“...Therefore, I will suggest a more radical course of action. She has what we need. Project Terapagos must move on, at all cost.”

Realization hit Juliana. She knew who this was. That-

A crash interrupted her line of thoughts. Dust settled on the opposite side of the room as a shadow slowly approached in the darkness. Juliana held her breath. As the beast moved further into the faint light of the monitor, she fished her phone out of her pocket once again, searching for the flashlight. Finally, she was able to see it.

It was Koraidon.

Tears welled up in her eyes. He- he was safe. They found each other again.

She dropped her phone on the ground and ran towards Koraidon with open arms as she called his name.

That was when she realized something was wrong. Koraidon stood up on its hind legs and unfolded its feathers. She hadn’t noticed the threatening growl it emitted, nor the feral look in its eyes.

She froze, too late, as Koraidon leapt into the air. She barely had time to roll away before it crashed with a *Collision Course* right where she was standing.

Juliana winced as needles and metallic scraps on the ground sliced through her skin. She was thankfully unharmed if not for the cuts that now covered her arms and legs. The entire desk behind her, however, was not; the computer and the statue had exploded into a pile of mismatched fragments while Koraidon recovered from the attack.

Her mind was racing. Okay, she messed up. Koraidon was obviously frenzied due to the scientists’ experiments, and she did not respect its boundaries. The Pokémon looked exhausted, but otherwise unharmed. The only things that worried her were the manic look in its eyes and the light hint of Terastal energy on its forearms and claws.

Koraidon turned on her once again, sending her a look that sent shivers down her spine. There was panic, fear, hatred and confusion in its eyes. But it could still remember her. Despite its aggressive display, there was hesitation in its movements. If she could only calm it down…

“Koraidon!” She pleaded. “It’s me, Juliana! Remember me?”

She jumped back just in time to avoid the swing of a *Dragon Claw*. Right. It was still trying to kill her. Message received.

“Please buddy, I- I’m sorry! I’m sorry I couldn’t be there. I’m sorry you were brought here. But I’m here for you now! Just stop the fighting, everything will all be alri-”

Juliana hurried to take cover behind a table as a *Flamethrower* flew just past her head. She quickly tapped her left shoulder to put out a small flame. She was going to get grilled if she kept this up. But what could she do?

She heard Koraidon leap into the air once more and rushed out of her cover as the table crumbled behind her.

“I- I won’t let them hurt you anymore! Please Koraidon, you have to calm down!”

She sent Clodsire out just in time for the Pokémon to parry the incoming *Tera Blast* like a champ. Ignoring the lingering pain surging up again in her arm, Juliana commanded the Pokémon to use *Yawn* on her partner.

Koraidon roared, showing no sign of being affected by the attack. It charged with Dragon energy and slammed hard into Clodsire, knocking it unconscious. The Paradox Pokémon’s heavy tail slammed into Juliana. She was sent flying into a wall.

She slowly rose to her knees, trying not to worry about her dislocated shoulder, as the Pokémon made its way to her. It walked with the pride of a battle won, the certainty of its victory over its foe. There, the Winged King truly lived up to its name, parading in a show of strength. Finally it arrived, towering over its prey.

The beast roared one last time before raising a claw and prepared to strike down its foe with hatred. It would put an end to the life of one from the kind that had hurt it so. One that had the arrogance to put the Winged King in a metal cage. The prey would plead for its pitiful life, it would try to evade its fate, but it wouldn’t matter. Retribution was inevitable.

But the child did none of that.

Despite the clear terror in the human’s eyes, there was clarity. Acceptance and recognition.

It didn’t speak. It didn’t run. It just watched, frozen in place. Accepting its fate. The scene was familiar, but the beast couldn’t remember why.

It recalled a cave. A child lost among aggressive hounds. Frozen in place.

Koraidon was missing something. Something it wanted to protect, something it cherished. No, not something. **Someone.** Someone with whom it had shared trial after trial. Someone who permitted the King to rise to greater heights than it could ever have imagined.

It was tired.

Darkness overtook its vision. Perhaps the child was right. Maybe it was safe.

Maybe a quick nap wouldn't hurt.

Juliana could hardly believe her eyes as Koraidon collapsed to the ground before her. It had prepared to end her, and to her shame, she had accepted it. And then the beast froze, and then it fell to the ground.

She rushed over to make sure her partner was okay. Thankfully it was just sleeping, peacefully.

She had done it. She was reunited with one of her Pokémon. Terapagos was still missing, of course, but she took relief in having found at least one of them. Safe.

Clodsire hopped next to her, weak from the battle. She gave the Pokémon a quick hug as well as a long tirade of 'thank you' that he probably didn't understand, but appreciated anyway. Juliana mindlessly sat back down next to Koraidon and rubbed his feathers. Only now could she truly see how worn down her Pokémon was. Yet, they were still fighting their captors. She felt sorrow at what had happened because of her, yet also beaming pride at her partner.

In that one moment, alone in a dark lab lit only by the glow of her discarded phone on the floor, Juliana allowed herself to take comfort in her reunion with Koraidon. It didn't matter that he attacked her, she would make sure he never left her sight again.

She was so caught up in the moment that she didn't notice her entire team emerging from their Pokéballs to huddle next to her, or the tears streaming freely from her eyes. She was here now.

Suddenly, her phone started ringing, grounding her once again. Right, okay. She did hang up on Rika before, so she figured the Elite 4 would try to call her again. Without her asking, Ogerpon grabbed the phone from the ground and handed it to her. She winced from the cuts on her hands as she took the device, and shakily hovered her finger over the answer button.

She took a deep breath, and pressed it.

“H- hey again Rika, I’m sorry for-”

“Hi honey, it’s Mom! How are you doing sweetie?”

Juliana put a hand to her mouth to hide a whimper. Mom? What- what could she say? That she was miserable? That she was exhausted, that she feared for her life? That people and Pokémon had tried to kill her several times? That her partners had been taken away from her? That deep down, she had the urge to just run away and let others deal with the consequences of her actions, even though she knew the lives that would be lost?

That she didn’t know who to trust, who to turn to? That her whole world was crumbling all around her and that she was lost? That the only way she knew was forward, but her feet felt heavier with every step? That her heart was still torn by her separation from Terapagos?

Koraidon slowly woke from his slumber and turned back to her. They locked eyes, recognition clear on both sides. Tiredly, Koraidon licked her hand in apology.

For an instant, all her doubts vanished.

“I’m fine Mom.” She answered, for the first time in months, with actual conviction.

“Great! Because I’ve just found a dress that is to die for, you’re going to love it, sweetheart. I’m just not sure about the color…” She started to ramble. Juliana let herself relax and leaned into the comforting embrace of her team as she listened to her mother, closing her eyes and humming along in the dark.

Ch20 - Confrontation / What Power Means

Juliana turned a corner in the darkness.

She was careful where she walked. The darkened hallways were filled to the brim with traps: tricked floorings that gave away beneath her, pressure plates that summoned exploding Voltorbs… She was grateful for Koraidon saving her more times than she could count. The Pokémon couldn't see any better than her in complete darkness, but he generally reacted faster than she did.

She idly put a hand on her arm while thinking, wincing as she was reminded of the many cuts on her skin. She had spent a few minutes resting in that decrepit lab before this, taking her time to recover from what had happened. Though she was feeling a bit better and her team was back at full health, the short rest didn't undo all physical pain. The worst part was a dislocated shoulder that she had to pop back into place.

Thinking about her team she absentmindedly pat her belt, feeling the familiar weight of six Pokéballs. Of course, her usual squad of Skeledirge, Clodsire, Tinkaton and Ogerpon were there. To that was added the frenzied Roaring Moon that she captured a few days ago in the crater, as well as the Titan Great Tusk gifted to her by Nemona. She hadn't been able to use the Pokémon since she got into the facility due to its size, but its presence was reassuring nonetheless.

Yet despite all that, the absence of two still had her heart racing. She still had to rescue Terapagos, and Koraidon's Pokéball was still missing. Not that she'd use it so soon anyway, neither the Pokémon nor her wanted to get separated again for the moment.

She sighed. What was she even doing here? She had lost all traces of La Primera a while ago, and she had been walking in the dark for what felt like hours. All she managed to find was locked doors and empty laboratories. The place looked like it had been abandoned in a hurry, yet nothing of note was left behind. She had abandoned her friends when she promised she wouldn't and she didn't have much to show for it. What was her objective, finding the old guy that Kieran talked about? How!? Was he even here anymore?

"Agias?"

She realized that Koraidon was looking at her with a concerned expression. She had stopped moving, standing in the middle of the hallway. Right, she had spaced out again. She shook her head and resumed walking ahead, thanking the Pokémon for not letting her get stuck in her own head.

It was only a few steps later that she noticed a door, different from all the others. Unlike the lab doors it didn't have a lock nor a reinforced glass window.

It was just a huge red door, sporting a rainbow R on it.

Well, as they say, she thought, *no time like the present.*

Juliana took a deep breath, and pushed through the doors. She entered an enormous room, spacious enough to hold one of Galar's Dynamax Pokémon she saw all the time on TV. Crystals covered most of the side walls, emitting a bright light that lit up the cold, wide empty space. The opposite wall to the door was lined up with various monitors, transcribing scenes from all around the crater.

She could see Team Star, struggling to fend off both Rocket Grunts and Paradox Pokémon. Penny was repairing a Starmobile on the go while Arven drove off a frenzied Sandy Shocks. Clavel was shouting orders from on top of a rock, uniting Team Star under his leadership. Nemona was furiously bashing against a door with her Pokémon, trying to knock it down, while Kieran and Carmine were trying to get her to stop. There was an empty lab, marks of Koraidon's attacks still present among the rubble of medical equipment, paper and crystal. She saw herself, standing in awe in this very room, Koraidon tensed up next to her. *Wait, what?*

She turned to the Pokémon and realized he was looking at a desk standing at the end of the room. A man was sitting in it, his back turned to her. He was stroking the head of a Persian on his lap, looking at the screens.

Giovanni.

"You've kept me waiting, child." He said, venom in his voice.

"Where is Terapagos!?" She demanded.

The Persian jumped away from the man's lap, disappearing behind a crystal. Giovanni turned his chair, facing her with an evil smirk.

"Straight to the chase, aren't we? You would do well not to rush things. We both know how that usually ends." He taunted.

"Answer me." She said, Koraidon growling next to her.

"Careful now." His smirk widened, showing teeth. "You don't want the Professor's Pet to get hurt, do you? Such a shame that her trust in you was so misplaced."

Her eyes widened in shock. How could he know about-

A chuckle from the man interrupted her thoughts. “Surprised? I know all about your actions in this place. The security footage we were able to access from the lab thanks to your generous donation was surprisingly informative. I witnessed that foolish woman sacrificing herself saving that Pokémon from its brethren. I watched your failings at rescuing what was left of her from that machine. You tried so hard, recklessly sacrificing yourself for others, and you still failed. Just like now.”

She stood motionless, Koraidon now standing between her and the man.

“You lacked power. You lacked conviction. And now look at you! A diamond in the rough, molded by outside pressure. But you still have one weakness.”

He took a seemingly common Pokéball out of his pocket, and placed it on the table before him.

Somehow she knew. She could *feel* it. This was Koraidon’s Pokéball.

“You still care for these **tools**. How childish of you. All Pokémon exist only for power. You know that, deep down, don’t you? You know what that power looks like. Because what you have is never enough. Because you always need to do more. To **be** more. You know you long for it: the power to protect, the power to get back what’s rightfully yours.

“You might be strong, child. Perhaps stronger than me, I’ll admit. But I bear no such weakness. Unlike you, I don’t fear power. I embrace it. And that-” He grabbed the Pokéball on his desk, holding it tight in a display of superiority. “That makes me stronger. Your treasures- No. All of Paldea’s treasures are mine to take.”

Juliana’s heart surged with fierce determination. She wouldn’t let him. She squared her shoulders with a steely resolve.

His eyes met hers. The smile on his face disappeared, replaced with a frown.

“This look in your eyes. You remind me so much of another nuisance.” He spat with venom.

Without even thinking she grabbed a Pokéball at her belt, signaling Koraidon to stand back beside her.

“Very well then, child. For your insolence, you will feel a world of pain!”

Two Pokéballs flew through the room at the same time. Both landed between the trainers, the mostly empty room large enough to serve as a makeshift battlefield.

Tinkaton faced an enormous bipedal Pokémon with a thick layer of orange and brown rocks protecting its whole body. A horn on the Pokémon's nose rotated as if it was a drill. She recognized the Pokémon as a Rhyperior. A challenge for any trainer to stand against, and this was only the first of Giovanni's Pokémon.

"Tinkaton!" She called. "Let's open with a *Gigaton Hammer*! Full force!"

Tinkaton wasted no time swinging her giant hammer at the Drill Pokémon. Rocks cracked under steel with a thundering crunch as the rock type Pokémon was sent sliding a few feet away. Barely conscious after the Super Effective attack, Rhyperior was breathing heavily, still standing despite the injury.

Giovanni barely spared a glance at his Pokémon, uncaring about its health.

"*Stealth Rocks*." He commanded. "Then *Drill Run*."

Rhyperior used the time it took Tinkaton to recover from her hammer swing to create pointy rocks from its hands and scattered them around the room. When the fairy type Pokémon went for another swing, the steel hammer was this time met with a rotating drill that easily pushed it back. Tinkaton struggled back to her feet, now breathing heavily too.

Just like that, both Pokémon were back where they started, both of them worse for the wear. Giovanni seemed unbothered by it.

Juliana knew that if she wanted to win this fight, she'd have to pull ahead early on. She knew the man probably still had that Psychic Pokémon, Mewtwo, and she would need everything she had to face it.

She couldn't afford Tinkaton to fall here.

"Tinkaton, return!" A bright light engulfed the Pokémon as she returned to her Pokéball. "Ogerpon! *Grassy Terrain*!"

Grass bloomed across the room as Ogerpon rushed across the newly created field and slammed her *Ivy Cudgel* hard into the Rhyperior's chest. The Drill Pokémon fell here and there, fully knocked out. Juliana sighed in relief as the Grassy Terrain healed the damages Ogerpon had received due to the Stealth Rocks. Good, she had a lead.

Across the room, Giovanni kept the same mocking smirk on his face as he called back his Pokémon, unbothered by his loss. Nothing was decided yet, this battle would be a long one.

“You are as powerful as expected, child. But you are still holding back. Think about it, the true change you could bring to this world.”

He sent another Pokéball to the field. What came out of it was unlike anything she had ever seen.

Although it was her first time seeing one in the flesh, Juliana knew of the species of Nidoking. It wasn't too uncommon for one to appear on televised foreign League Battle as part of a young challenger’s team. But even then, she knew something was wrong with this one.

The Pokemon before her was taller than she was expecting it to be, exceeding even Koraidon in his battle form. The hulking mass of muscles and poisonous spikes was a monster, its slow breathing and tight muscles a testament of its sheer power. Its eyes glared at her and her Pokémon, filled only with unadulterated rage and hatred.

That was what Giovanni meant, earlier. This wasn’t a Pokémon anymore. This was a tool.

Without even a command from its master, Nidoking took slow but deliberate steps towards Ogerpon. Each one shook the room, its shear aura was making all the grass around it wither away.

Her mind raced. What should she do, switch out Ogerpon? It would force her to reveal her hand too early, and even if she dealt with this behemoth she knew the rest of Giovanni’s team would pose just as much of a threat.

She shared a quick look with Ogerpon. The Pokémon nodded her head, she wanted to stay. Juliana made her decision, she would trust in her partner. Just as the behemoth got in range, Ogerpon extended her club, hitting it in the head with formidable strength.

But to their horror, Nidoking didn’t even flinch.

The Pokémon took the damage as if it was nothing. It didn’t even spare a glance at Ogerpon, its eyes fixated on the trainer instead.

The beast was still making eye contact as it threw a heavy punch at a shocked Ogerpon, sending her flying at Juliana’s feet. The Pokémon struggled to get up, coughing up bits of Poison.

Juliana internally admonished herself- she had been wrong to let Ogerpon stay. Doubt filled her for a second as she was reminded of Giovani’s words.

She shook her head. She couldn't let it get to her. Juliana retrieved Ogerpon into her Pokéball and gestured to Koraidon to fill in against the behemoth. The Paradox Pokémon stood in his battle form, analyzing his foe.

Nidoking was still fixated on Juliana, not letting its unnerving gaze leave her for a second. Koraidon roared defiantly as if to remind the beast of its actual opponent. Finally, Nidoking seemed to lose interest in her. The hulking mass roared in turn, shaking the room in the process and forcing Juliana to cover her ears.

By the time she could hear again, Koraidon had raced across the battlefield and crashed into its opponent with the full force of its *Collision Course*. She had seen it topple titans before- it should have been devastating, but to her shock, Nidoking didn't falter. It planted its massive feet into the ground and caught Koraidon with its bare hands, gripping the Paradox Pokémon as if it were a mere football. Koraidon struggled, but Nidoking's grip didn't loosen. Juliana's heart pounded. This thing was stronger than anything they'd ever faced.

Koraidon executed a quick *U-Turn* on her order, bouncing off Nidoking's firm grip and retreating to a safer distance. Nidoking slowly moved forward, trying to close the gap, but before he could take a few steps Koraidon unleashed a *Flamethrower* aimed directly at the behemoth. The flames engulfed Nidoking, licking at its hardened scales.

But Nidoking didn't stop.

Its eyes locked onto Koraidon through the flames. It stood its ground against the inferno, lowering its head. Juliana's breath caught in her throat as its horn glowed with deadly energy and the Pokémon rammed into Koraidon with a brutal *Head Smash*.

Koraidon staggered backward, visibly shaken from the blow. The Paradox Pokémon tried to regain its footing, but Nidoking was relentless. It seized the moment and lifted Koraidon off the ground using *Strength*. Juliana's eyes widened as the hulking beast slammed Koraidon into the nearest wall with enough force to make the entire Crater tremble.

"Koraidon!" Juliana shouted, watching as her partner struggled to get back up. Nidoking wasn't finished. It grabbed Koraidon again, hurling him back into the center of the battlefield like a ragdoll, its sheer force unmatched.

Finally on his feet again, Koraidon roared. Juliana could see the toll the fight was taking on him. Despite everything, Nidoking seemed completely unphased by its own injuries. Every punch, every hit, felt like it barely registered. It was as if it didn't care. But there had to be a weakness. She just hadn't found it yet.

Nidoking charged once more, and Koraidon met its assault head-on. The two titans traded powerful blows for a while. Each strike from Koraidon hit like a truck, but Nidoking absorbed every hit with an eerie persistence. No matter what Koraidon did, Nidoking kept coming, its movements unnervingly deliberate.

Juliana gritted her teeth. She could feel the doubt settling in again. She pushed it aside: there had to be a way.

Eventually, as the fight raged on, she noticed something. The way Nidoking's posture shifted slightly after each blow, how its movements seemed a bit more sluggish. It was subtle, but the injuries were piling up. Nidoking just refused to show it.

There was an opening.

"Koraidon, fall back!" she called, reaching for a Pokéball. "Tinkaton, you're up!"

Koraidon obeyed without hesitation, leaping back to her side just as Juliana's Tinkaton emerged from her ball. A *Poison Jab* from Nidoking hit the Steel type's hammer uselessly. Tinkaton grinned, swinging her weapon with a force that sent shockwaves through the room.

And for a second, Nidoking faltered.

Juliana's heart flickered with hope. Nidoking was strong, terrifyingly so, but it wasn't invincible. It could be beaten. It **would** be beaten.

"Tinkaton, keep it up! We've got this! *Protect*!"

A protective wall appeared right in front of Tinkaton just as Nidoking attacked with a full force *Bulldoze*. The Super Effective Move washed away on its glowing surface, leaving Nidoking open for another *Gigaton Hammer*.

This song and dance repeated a few times, the Nidoking slowly but surely tiring and Tinkaton profiting off every mistake, every opening the beast gave her.

Juliana's confidence returned, a smirk on her face. The battle was now once again turning in her favor. Nidoking was a beast, but she'd get through it soon enough. She'd be ready for whatever came next.

Her smile fell. Why wasn't Giovanni retrieving his Pokémon? He knew the beast couldn't do anything to Tinkaton, that he should let it rest to unleash it again later. So why wasn't he? And why was he still looking so smug? Did it really not matter to him, was this battle just another twisted game of his?

Or was he so confident in his win that it didn't matter to him what happened to his Pokémon?

Nidoking finally fell to the ground, unconscious. The titan had fallen. She remarked that Tinkaton was starting to show signs of exhaustion too, it would soon be time for her to retreat as well.

"Don't you see what I'm able to accomplish with such simple tools?" Giovanni taunted, still so smug about it despite two clean losses in a row. "You could be the same, child. You have no idea what heights of power you could reach if you just started to grow up."

"And why would I need such power?" she asked back, without even thinking. She realized her mistake too late - she was playing right into Giovanni's little mind-game.

"You could save them." He said. Her eyes widened. "It is what you want, little savior, isn't it? To protect them, to protect this region from the likes of me. But you're too much of a coward to do so."

She bit her lip. The words cut in deep, even though she knew what he was trying to do. *It won't work*, she lied to herself. *I won't listen to him*.

Giovanni sent in his next Pokémon. A Dugtrio emerged through the tiled floor, its three heads locked onto Tinkaton. It wasn't as impressive as Nidoking, but Juliana knew not to let appearances fool her.

She reviewed what she knew of the Pokémon. Ground type, very fast, likes to hide underground. She could swear there was another thing, something that made her despise the prospect of facing it in battle, but she couldn't remember what with all the exhaustion and the stress clouding her mind.

No matter. It was a fast Ground type, she knew Tinkaton couldn't take it right now. Not after all the exhaustion she had endured these past few days. She raised a Pokéball and pressed its button, sending a beam of light to retrieve her Pokémon.

Before it could, however, Dugtrio dug underground. The Pokémon emerged between her and her Pokémon and stopped the beam from reaching Tinkaton. Right. *Arena Trap*. That was what she had forgotten, Tinkaton couldn't leave the field anymore. She cursed under her breath.

Alright, at least Dugtrios were generally frail, she could still make up for it if she played her cards right.

“Tinkaton! *Gigaton Hammer*!”

The giant steel hammer crashed hard on the floor, sending dust flying everywhere. But as the dust cleared, only a hole remained in the ground. Dugtrio emerged from beneath Tinkaton using *Dig*, sending the Steel type Pokémon flying backwards.

Juliana bit her lower lip and focused, trying to help Tinkaton navigate this giant game of Whack-A-Mole as best she could. But every time she swung that hammer, Dugtrio vanished in a second and punished her hard for it. It was like what happened with Nidoking, only now the roles were reversed. She glared at Giovanni, who was giving her a mocking look. He ***knew***, the bastard knew. It was all a part of his plan.

Tinkaton eventually went down, unable to hit Dugtrio once due to exhaustion. She finally was able to retrieve her to her Pokéball.

“It’s okay Tinkaton.” She said, eyes closed and forehead pressed against the ball. “You’ve done so well, thank you so much girl.”

“You’re beginning to realize it, don’t you.” Giovanni interrupted, taunting her. “The gap of power between us. You cannot win, child. Give up, surrender yourself and your Pokémon.”

“Never to the likes of you!” She retorted. “I’ve faced worse before and came out on top. You’re like all the others, just another maniac with delusions of grandeur!”

To her surprise, he merely laughed. “That’s some bold fighting words, coming from the desperate little girl who’s about to lose everything.” His smirk widened in mockery. “But fine, you’ll see. I will make you rue the day you crossed me.”

She reached to her belt without a word and took out another Pokéball, throwing it on the field. Clodsire stood motionless on the battlefield, his vacant expression a stark contrast to the storm of emotions Juliana was feeling at the moment.

Dugtrio took no time to bury itself underground once again, planning to hit her Pokémon hard. Juliana smirked despite herself. She had it right where she wanted.

“Clodsire, *Earthquake*.” She commended.

Clodsire obliged, jumping high into the air before descending at high speed and hitting the ground with his tail empowered with the glow of a Ground type attack.

The entire room shook violently under the attack, huge chunks of crystal falling everywhere in the room. Giovanni’s eyes widened in surprise while Juliana focused her attention on the battle, fists tightening as she repressed past memories of a

similar shake in a crystal cavern. Finally, when the dust cleared, Clodsire stood alone on the battlefield, a knocked out Dugtrio at his side.

Juliana examined her Pokémon. It seemed Dugtrio had managed to hit Clodsire before passing out. The Spiny Fish Pokémon looked tired, not having fully recovered from his previous fight with Koraidon.

On the plus side, Giovanni looked pissed. Juliana was relieved that, for the first time of the battle, she had managed to surprise him. It was satisfying to wipe that smug look from his face, the man clearly didn't expect one of his Pokémon to go down this quick.

"You brat. Do you truly believe you can win?" He spat. "I shall **crush** your foolish hopes beneath my heel. They have no place in the real world, kid. It's due time I teach you this lesson."

Another Pokéball hit the field. Out came a Nidoqueen, just as massive as the previous Nidoking, but looking more calm and collected.

"*Blizzard*."

Nidoqueen's eyes flashed, and the temperature in the room suddenly dropped fast. A fog enveloped the battlefield as Juliana's breath started to turn into mist, her body shivering in the cold.

And in an instant, all was chaos.

One could only see the Pokémon' shadows through the fog, Nidoqueen raising its arms with a haunting cry as it summoned immense elemental power. From behind it came a fast wind, transporting vast amounts of snow and sharp ice. Despite being quite a safe distance away from the fight Juliana was forced to duck behind a crystal by the attack, the cold still biting at her recent scrapes and wounds.

After what felt like hours, the attack finally subsided. Juliana peeked from her hiding place to see an ice sheet covering the tattered battlefield. Nidoqueen was breathing heavily, recovering. In the center of the battlefield, Clodsire stood motionless, a thick layer of snow covering him.

Juliana held her breath as she carefully walked closer. *Was… was he?*

Reaching the Pokémon, she put a hand on his back. Clodsire slowly turned his head to face her, gave her a tired smile, then fell forward, unconscious. She scooped the Pokémon in her arms, thanked him in whispers and returned him to his ball. He had fought valiantly.

Returning to her side of the battlefield, she turned to face Giovanni. Weirdly, the man's attention wasn't on her. It wasn't even on his Pokémon. Instead, he was looking at the crystals.

Juliana shivered despite herself. She **really** didn't like these things before, and seeing that frozen man in the abandoned lab didn't help things. Sensing her distress like a Sharpedo smelling blood in the water, Giovanni's gaze fell back to her.

"Don't you find these magnificent? These crystals, I mean. They are testaments of power from a past long gone, they will surely outlast us far into the future." Giovanni held a small fragment in his hand, toying with it.

A shadow passed by a crystal to the right. Juliana's squinted. Was something there?

"I can understand the late Professor's fascination for these- one of Area Zero's treasures. But while I value their contribution to my cause, I cannot say that I care for them. Like all things they are but means to an end to me, a stepping stone to a greater treasure that is now within my grasp."

Juliana recognized his tone. He was still toying with her, trying to instill doubt in her mind. He had a trick up his sleeve.

She shared a glance with Koraidon, who nodded his head. Whatever happened on the battlefield, the Paradox Pokémon could handle it. Koraidon walked forward, his eyes fixated on Nidoqueen.

"What about you child? What are they, to you? Do you relish such power, like the Elites of your region or…"

Koraidon was already a fair distance away when she saw it. There was a feline Pokémon stalking in the shadow of the crystals, preparing to attack. It was too late.

"... do you fear it?"

Giovanni's Persian leapt to her, claws raised and aiming for the throat.

Juliana froze. She wasn't expecting that. Her reflexes reacted just in the nick of time. She jumped away as the Pokémon's claws missed her throat, tearing deep into her right arm instead. She fell on her back while Persian landed on its feet, preparing for another attack.

Koraidon wouldn't give it the chance. The Paradox Pokémon rushed into it with a *Collision Course*, but the Cat Pokémon managed to dodge and ran back into hiding

behind crystals. Koraidon roared as he charged into the maze, intent on protecting his trainer.

Clutching her injured arm, Juliana got back up and saw Nidoqueen charging another attack. Koraidon, having forgotten his previous foe in order to protect her, had his back exposed to it. Dragon energy concentrated into the mouth of the opposing Pokémon, swirling and pulsating dangerously.

Juliana knew on instinct her partner wouldn't be able to dodge it. She needed a solution, fast. Without even thinking she grabbed a Pokéball with her good arm and threw it on the battlefield, hoping to be fast enough.

Nidoqueen's *Dragon Pulse* crashed into a ball of Ghost energy, the two attacks canceling each other. Smoke filled the room while Juliana squinted her eyes, trying to assess the situation. One could clearly see a light through the fog, bright flames piercing through the quickly fading darkness.

Skeledirge, Juliana's first partner, roared defiantly as the room cleared. He wouldn't let anything get past him. Nidoqueen lowered her head, seizing up her new foe. Her cold and calculating glare seemed to indicate she'd take him seriously.

The real battle had just begun.

Ch21 - Reaching a Breaking Point / What Power Means

“Damn it!”

Fists banged uselessly on the metal door. Once again, nothing happened. No matter what Nemona did, neither she nor her Pokémon could get through there.

It was frustrating. She had watched Juliana go through about an hour ago, and still no updates! She had tried everything, but the stupid door was still there. The only thing separating her from her rival, her friend. And… and she had promised! Juliana had promised to her that she wouldn’t go alone, that they’d do it together. But now, here she was. Left behind while Juliana was risking her life, all because of a dumb, stupid door-

She was brought out of her thoughts with a gentle touch on her shoulder. Nemona turned her head to meet Kieran’s eyes. The boy looked obviously worried, not even bothering to try and hide it. He had been with her, trying for over an hour to pry the door open while his sister went looking for help. Nemona took solace in the fact that, at least, she wasn’t alone.

“It will be okay. She’ll be okay.” He said in a shaky voice, as if he was trying to reassure himself as much as Nemona. He cleared his throat. “Juliana is strong, I’m sure she’ll be able to face… whatever is going on here.”

“Yeah, what even **is** going on down here?” Carmine stood in the doorway, having just returned from her little expedition.

“Sis! Did you find anything?” Kieran asked, echoing her thoughts. To their disappointment, Carmine shook her head.

“Nah, the whole base has been abandoned. I couldn’t find anyone, it’s as if everyone left in a hurry. The Rattatas must have fled the ship when the earthquake hit… But I did find this though!” She handed them two bottles of water.

Nemona thanked her and took a big gulp. She had to admit that she was exhausted right now. Her stamina usually wasn’t that great, and running through the whole base and then failing to open this door had pushed her beyond her limits.

“So, you didn’t answer my question. What the hell is going on?” Carmine asked again. “As far as we know, Ms. Briar took us along for her research and then it all went to shit when you two showed up.”

“Yeah,” Kieran agreed. “What was Juliana talking about with Koraidon and- and Terapagos?”

“Well that’s… complicated. Let’s just say that-”

Suddenly, a loud buzz interrupted her. Surprised, she failed to do anything when her Rotom-phone flew out of her pocket and hovered in front of the three of them, responding to a video call.

“...Hello?” She asked, while the screen was still loading.

“Nemona! It’s Arven!” The image finally stabilized, showing Arven and Penny. “We’ve managed to get a Starmobile past the blockade! Where are you two? Juliana isn’t answering her phone. And… are those Carmine and Kieran? Hi guys!”

Nemona gasped as Carmine and Kieran politely saluted, still unsure as to what was happening. “Arven! So good to hear you mate, that’s great news! But… I don’t know where Jules is. We got separated in Team Rocket’s base, and I can’t get past this door-”

“What!?” Penny exclaimed, apparently listening in on the conversation. “But- urgh, I knew this would happen!”

“I- I’m sorry, I-”

“It’s not your fault,” Penny assured her. “It’s Juliana we’re talking about, I knew she’d pull something like this again, she just can’t help it. But no worries, I have just the thing right here…” She started fidgeting with some sort of gadget.

“Wait what are you…” Arven turned to look at what she was doing. “Is- is that… Penny, did you bug her phone so that you could track her location!?” He admonished.

“Of course! What, did you forget what happened last time she went missing? She just can’t be trusted.” She replied.

“But- I… You know what? Fair point.” Arven admitted “So, where is she?”

Penny adjusted her glasses to look at the screen. “Somewhere… way, way deep down. But I think I have a plan… Nemona, meet us in front of Team Rocket’s base. We’ll pick you up there.”

Arven ended the call. Nemona stood up, determined and re-energized. She turned to Kieran and Carmine, still trying to figure out what was happening.

“Let’s do this! Come with me you two, I’ll explain things on the way.”

“S-Skeledirge, *Torch Song*!”

Juliana heard more than she saw her Pokémon launching flames in the shape of a bird while producing an eerie sound akin to a funeral song. She was currently ducking behind a crystal, protecting herself from Nidoqueen’s *Blizzard*.

Although the move wasn’t very effective, Giovanni kept instructing his Pokémon to use it- surely to keep pressure on the trainer instead of the Pokémon. But no matter, Skeledirge could shrug off the attack with ease. As long as he stood, she would too.

The thing that worried her was that when Nidoqueen wasn’t using *Blizzard*, the Pokémon had a whole array of powerful elemental moves at its disposal that it mixed at random, making it pretty much unpredictable: *Thunder*, *Fire Blast*, *Dragon Pulse*, *Sludge Bomb*, and most devastating of all, *Earth Power*. Skeledirge was tanking all these attacks as best he could, but it was clear that he wouldn’t be able to stand forever.

Giovanni would win the war of attrition. They both knew it.

But she had a trump card. A hope that, maybe, could give her the edge she needed. Giovanni underestimated her, and by extension, her Pokémon.

Skeledirge had been building up *Torch Song* after *Torch Song* this whole time. The move had the side effect of boosting his power output. But, if she showed her hand too soon, Giovanni would be able to counter it.

Instead, she played on his ego, instructing Skeledirge to limit himself in order to use it all in one final devastating move when the time was right. It was a risky strategy, one that she had never tried before, but she didn’t even need words for Skeledirge to understand what she was planning.

He was her first partner, they didn’t need words to understand each other.

Finally, the *Blizzard* subsided. As she peeked from behind her hiding place, she saw it. Nidoqueen was breathing heavily, tired from the long fight. Skeledirge was standing proud. Only Juliana could see it, but he was exhausted as well. This was it, it had to end now.

“You still don’t understand, child.” Giovanni called out. “Everything you’ve done, everything you’ve built- it is all but mere pieces on a chessboard. Mine to seize, and mine to destroy. You have no hope of winning this fight. Give in, or I’ll make you-”

“Shut, UP!” She interrupted. “Skeledirge, let’s show that jerkface who he’s messing with. *Blast Burn*, full throttle! Let’s end this!”

Skeledirge let out a roar as he channeled all the power he built up into one gigantic flame that grew rapidly in his mouth. It grew, and grew, fueled by countless *Torch Songs* and its *Blaze* ability until finally, the supernova launched itself at Nidoqueen with the speed of a comet.

The impact detonated with the power of a thousand suns. Juliana was forced to cover her eyes so as not to be blinded by the attack. A shockwave of wind and heat scattered dust across the room, she was barely able to stand on her feet.

When the dust cleared, a literal crater marked where Nidoqueen had once stood. All the ice and snow that had been building up from the repeated *Blizzards* had evaporated in an instant. The Pokémon itself laid unconscious inside at the epicenter, knocked out by the overwhelming attack. Skeledirge stood tall, his sides heaving from the effort but still able to fight nonetheless.

It was a critical hit.

“Agias!”

At that moment, Koraidon emerged from behind a crystal, throwing the unconscious form of Persian at Giovanni’s feet. Their fight was over too. Koraidon returned to Juliana’s side, glaring at Giovanni, as if daring the man to pull a trick like that again.

Internally, Juliana rejoiced. She had done it! All thanks to her Pokémon, to their bond. Thanks to Skeledirge, Koraidon and the others, she now held a considerable lead over Giovanni. The threat of Mewtwo still loomed ahead, but she had the plan and resources to deal with it when the time came. For now, all she needed to do was to handle Giovanni’s next Pokémon with the same resolve.

Speaking of Giovanni, the man’s face twisted in frustration. He looked irritated, no doubt realizing his mistake in underestimating her. His fist clenched around his Pokéballs as he returned Nidoqueen and Persian. Finally, he looked at her with a death stare.

“You… You think you’re so clever, don’t you?” He spat, venom dripping from his words. “But I have seen things you couldn’t even possibly fathom, you intolerable child. I’ve traveled and conquered infinite dimensions, and I refuse to be stopped by another brat. I will **crush you** until there is nothing left, and then rebuild you as I see fit. You will learn the lesson I should have taught all the others that came before you.”

Giovanni pulled out a strange Pokéball- light blue, with golden accents.

“See for yourself, child, the power of an Ultra-Beast! One whose hunger has consumed entire worlds. Come Guzzlord, show this puny infant what happens to those who stand in my way!”

What came out of that Pokéball would forever stay burned into Juliana’s mind. This creature - Guzzlord, as Giovanni had called it - was the stuff of nightmares. Something that in no way could have come from this world, this reality.

Its body was massive, bigger than a Titan Pokémon. It was a grotesque fusion of black and yellow scales that seemed to absorb the faint light of the room. Its gaping mouth was large enough to swallow entire houses whole. Flanking this maw were clawed arms that moved erratically, as if constantly reaching for prey that wasn’t there.

The *creature* emitted a constant low, guttural and alien growl that sent chills down Juliana’s spine. Its glowing eyes were empty, soulless, yet somehow filled with insatiable hunger. It was as if looking at a black hole masquerading itself as a Pokémon, awakening a deep primal fear in her just by looking at it.

Giovanni stood tall, his smirk growing wider at seeing the fear in her eyes. “Behold, child, the perfect predator.” He said, triumph in his voice.

Juliana bit her lower lip. She didn’t like the sound of that. Her mind was racing with strategies. First, figure out the creature’s typing and weaknesses. Then, try to use its massive size against it. She hoped a creature this big would be slow and sluggish, but she couldn’t get over-confident. This **was** an Alien after all.

One thing was for certain though: it was too risky for Skeledirge to stay on the field. Her starter Pokémon was exhausted after its enduring fight with Nidoqueen. Maybe under normal circumstances she could gauge things out by relying on his high endurance and healing with a few *Slack Offs*, but she couldn’t afford to underestimate her opponent.

“Skeledirge, come back!”

This decision quickly proved to be a mistake.

“*Pursuit.*”

The humongous beast disappeared in an instant, surging forward like a speeding bullet. Giovanni’s voice still echoed in her ears when a dark claw lunged toward her Pokémon. The Pokéball's beam had just touched Skeledirge when the claw struck with a sickeningly loud impact, nearly deafening her.

Skeledirge was knocked unconscious before he could even return to his Pokéball. Juliana cursed under her breath- that was unfair! That move was banned from official battles by the Leagues years ago. Still, she should have known better. *Focus, Juliana*. *Quick thinking*.

First off, with **that** move now in the playing field, switching out mid-battle was no longer an option. Whoever she sent out would have to stay on the field until they fainted. Switching out would be just too risky.

Secondly, she knew Skeledirge well. While her opponent was formidable, her Pokémon wasn't the type to go down in one hit, not even after his grueling fight with Nidoqueen. That meant only one thing: the beast had to be at least part a Dark type. It was the only way it could hit that hard with *Pursuit*. Still, she didn't know its other typing, and that knowledge would be crucial for her next move.

Who to send in? Tinkaton would be perfect right about now- if she wasn't already out of commission. Koraidon? Not an option, the Pokémon wouldn't leave her side ever since that Persian's sneak attack. Great Tusk? Not a bad choice, but more a finisher than a scout. Ogerpon?

Why not? Poisoned or not, she had faith her Pokémon would be able to dance around the beast long enough for her to form an actual strategy. Maybe she could even set up terrain to give Great Tusk an edge when the time came.

The entire thought process lasted for less than a second. As Juliana clipped Skeledirge's Pokéball back onto her belt, she already had Ogerpon's in hand. With a flick of the wrist, Ogerpon was summoned upon the field, standing strong despite her previous injuries.

The Ogre wasted no time setting up a *Grassy Terrain*, green energy flowing through her body and impeding the effects of the poison. Guzzlord launched itself at her like a predator targeting its prey, but Ogerpon easily dodged the attack, punishing it with a *Grassy Glide*. The attack collided with the beast's back in an instant, and Ogerpon retreated to safety just as fast, gliding on the grass as if she was ice skating.

As the pattern repeated and Ogerpon kept dancing around the beast, Juliana took the chance to observe it. The alien didn't seem to have much of a brain, motivated purely by its ruthless hunger. As such, it was easy to predict its movements. At least, while Giovanni wasn't commanding it.

She gazed toward the man, standing confident at the other side of the room, his cold eyes fixated on the battle. What did he have planned?

A sudden *THUD* snapped her attention back to the battle. Ogerpon was using her speed to tangle up Guzzlord's claws, creating an opening to slam a nasty *Ivy Cudgel* into its belly. The impact of the move seemed to reverberate through the beast, the ground crumbling beneath it. Despite that, Guzzlord didn't seem fazed. Juliana cursed once more under her breath- of course, she had suspected it but now confirmed it: this thing was a Dragon type.

This was bad. Ogerpon wouldn't be able to do much here. But maybe, if she played it well…

"*Dragon Rush.*" Giovanni called from the other side of the room. Dragon energy surrounded Guzzlord as the creature charged once more toward Ogerpon, barely slowed down by the lush grass in its way. The charge was wobbly though, Ogerpon saw it coming and would have no trouble dodging it. Perfect- this was her chance.

"Ogerpon! *Grass Knot!*"

Ogerpon playfully danced around the charging beast, manipulating the foliage to form a knot at the height of its feet. Unable to change direction, the massive beast tripped and fell forward, crashing hard into the ground, its speed and mass working against it.

"Yes!" Juliana cheered. Now, all she had to do was press her advantage while the thing was down. "Let's not waste any time, *Brick Break!*"

Ogerpon carefully stepped forward, avoiding the thrashing claws of the struggling beast that was failing to get back up. Her cudgel glowed with Fighting Type energy, prepared to deliver its full power. Everything was going to plan, Juliana thought.

But she failed to see Giovanni's smirk in time.

"*Stomping Tantrum.*"

Suddenly, Guzzlord's thrashing intensified, fueled by the unbridled rage that had been building up throughout this fight. The ground splintered around the beast, the entire room shook, sending tremors up Juliana's legs. Small debris began to fall from the ceiling as the thrashing grew more and more violent. Despite the chaos, Juliana could clearly see Ogerpon losing her balance and falling to the ground. The Pokémon was panicked, disoriented. Juliana needed to-

"*Boomburst.*"

Amidst its frustration Guzzlord let out a deafening roar. The sound was horrific, like a human scream twisted into something inhuman.

Even with her hands clamped over her ears, she could hear it as if it was emanating from her skull. Images flooded her overwhelmed mind.

The Rocket Scientist, frozen in place and covered in glimmering crystals.

Kieran, eyes filled with both hatred and terror as a chunk of the ceiling fell toward him.

Professor Sada, what was left of her, her robotic body disintegrated into a shining dust as that accursed time machine absorbed her.

The screams in her throbbing head blended with Guzzlord's, the cacophony almost incomprehensible.

When the sound finally stopped, she found herself on the ground. Her knees had buckled beneath her without her realizing. Her throat was raw, as if she had been screaming herself. Maybe she had- she couldn't even tell. But wait, what about-

One look at the battlefield confirmed what she already knew. Ogerpon lay sprawled on the floor, knocked out.

She raised her Pokéball and recalled her Pokémon, giving it a deserved rest as she forced herself back to her feet, helped in part by Koraidon. Guzzlord was back on its feet, a dangerous aura surrounding it as though empowered by its fallen foe. Empty eyes fell on her, as if waiting for its next opponent.

Juliana reached for another Pokéball. This one, a gift from her friends. She had never fought alongside this Pokémon before, one that had once stood as an obstacle in her path but was now her salvation.

She sent a silent prayer to whatever twisted god was watching over her as she released the Titan Great Tusk. The Paradox Pokémon roared triumphantly, its tusks gleaming as it locked eyes with Guzzlord, sizing up its opponent.

Guzzlord was weakened. Brute force would have to finish the job.

"Great Tusk!" She shouted, willing her voice to be steady. The Titan Pokémon tilted its head slightly, as if to show it was listening. "*Headlong Rush*- full throttle!"

Great Tusk roared as Ground-type energy surged through its tusks, the air around it charged with raw power. Across the tattered battlefield, Giovanni's commanding voice rang out.

“*Dragon Rush*.”

Both Pokémon launched forward at the same time. Great Tusk charged like a juggernaut, the tiled floor quaking with each step. Guzzlord messily barreled ahead, pulsating Dragon energy darkening its footsteps. Juliana held her breath as the two goliaths hurled toward each other.

The impact between the two was brutal. Great Tusk and Guzzlord locked together in a struggle, their massive forms braced in a brutal contest of raw strength. Great Tusk’s tusks drove forward, attempting to bruise the Ultra Beast’s belly, but they were caught and held firm by Guzzlord’s massive claws.

She needed to act fast. Even though it was injured, Guzzlord somehow matched Great Tusk’s strength perfectly. The last attack had taken its toll on both Pokémon. This could end quickly, one way or another. She couldn’t afford any mistake. Not now.

“Pull away with a *Rapid Spin*!” Juliana called out.

Great Tusk obeyed instantly, using its trunk to stabilize itself as it pulled back from the clash with surprising agility.

“Keep up the pressure Guzzlord. *Dragon Tail*.” Giovanni commanded.

With the new gap between them Guzzlord spun around with astonishing speed. Its massive tail lashed out with Dragon energy, trying to catch Great Tusk mid-retreat.

“*Rollout*!”

Great Tusk curled tightly into itself, its body hardening like stone. The tail struck its scaly back, sending the Paradox Pokémon hurtling through the air. In its ball form, Great Tusk bounced off a wall, then a crystal, and then another wall - each bounce building speed before it redirected itself back toward Guzzlord.

Giovanni snarled. “Stop it with a *Hammer Arm*.”

As Great Tusk was about to collide with the Ultra Beast, its claws shot out and slammed down, cancelling the Paradox Pokémon’s momentum. The force sent Great Tusk bouncing off the ground and into the air. Uncurling in surprise, the Titan quickly regained its composure, glaring fiercely at its opponent even while airborne.

Juliana bit her lip. That wasn’t a good spot- and Giovanni was sure to press his advantage.

As if on cue, the man smirked. “*Outrage*.”

Guzzlord roared with fury as its claws thrashed with Dragon energy, trying to catch Great Tusk mid-air.

An idea flashed through Juliana’s mind.

“Great Tusk! *Head Smash*!”

Stone encased Great Tusk’s head as the Paradox Pokémon tilted forward, turning its body into a projectile. It charged headfirst through the air, smashing through the claws and Dragon energy like a missile - just as Nidoking had done earlier with Koraidon’s *Flamethrower*. Juliana couldn’t help but smirk, sending Giovanni a knowing look as his own strategy was turned against him.

The impact shook the room. Great Tusk and Guzzlord both crashed to the ground. Slowly, Great Tusk pulled itself back to its feet, its breathing labored, the pain from the exchange evident. Across from it, Guzzlord rose shakily, its posture hunched. Though the same hunger burned within its eyes, it was clear the creature was near its limit.

For a moment, the battlefield fell silent. The two titans locked eyes, ready for one final clash.

Juliana and Giovanni’s voice rang out simultaneously, echoing through the room.

“Let’s end it! *Close Combat*!”

“Finish the job. *Giga Impact*.”

Guzzlord was the first to move, launching itself with all its might. Its gigantic form barreled across the battlefield, the energy surrounding it so intense that it left a trail of flames behind.

But Great Tusk was ready. The Paradox Pokémon planted its feet firmly, its body radiating Fighting-type energy. With every ounce of strength it had left, it prepared for one final, decisive strike, its trunk and tusks glowing with raw power.

The two attacks collided with each other, creating an explosion in a blinding flash. When the light faded Juliana squinted, her heart pounding as she searched the battlefield while wiping away sweat from her brow.

The outcome was clear.

Both Great Tusk and Guzzlord laid unconscious. It had been too much for both of them.

Juliana returned Great Tusk to its Pokéball, closing her eyes for a moment to silently thank the Pokémon and her friends for their support. She was going to see this battle to an end, and it was only thanks to them.

She had a chance to win. She knew it.

Opening her eyes, she fixed her gaze on Giovanni. The man had already retrieved Guzzlord without a word, his confident smirk unchanged, betraying nothing of his emotions. But it didn't matter.

He knew it. She knew it. His ace was coming.

Mewtwo was next.

"So," he declared as their eyes met. "This is it then. My final Pokémon."

She did not respond. Instead, she reached for her own last Pokéball without breaking eye contact. A tense silence sat between the two.

Giovanni raised his chin. "I'll admit, you've come far, child. Further than I anticipated. You're persistent, I'll give you that. But you're still **weak**. Prancing around with faulty tactics and improvised orders- foolish and naive."

He paused.

"All for naught," he continued, his smirk widening, "because you lack the **guts** to do what needs to be done. But this is it. You will see what true power is all about."

In a flash of light, Mewtwo appeared, hovering silently above the battlefield. Its mere presence seemed to shift the atmosphere of the room, the air thick with suffocating energy. Its intelligent eyes fixed on Juliana, flashing with recognition. Hatred and superiority burned within that gaze- towards what or who, she could not know.

But most unsettling of all was what the Pokémon could see. When their eyes met, it felt as though it was staring directly into her soul. It saw everything - every sacrifice she had made to get here, every piece of her that had broken along the way. It knew the ghosts of her past, the weight of her regrets, and her fear for the future.

It knew how terrified she was.

“I believe you’ve already met.” Giovanni taunted, his voice dripping with poison. “Your struggle is futile, child. You will end just as you did that night: powerless… and alone.”

Juliana recognized the sound of her heart beating wildly in her chest as fragmented images flashed through her mind. Her vision blurred, her body trembled.

She closed her eyes, drawing a deep, steady breath. Her free hand rested on Koraidon’s back, grounding her. *Not this time*, she told herself. She couldn’t afford to break down here, she would not fall to his tricks again.

She forced her thoughts away from the unpleasant memories, focusing instead on her friends that were waiting for her. Her team, with whom she had fought through countless battles. Her mom, who will surely soon be home again, in Paldea.

Without opening her eyes, she raised her final Pokéball to her brow.

“C’mon,” she whispered softly. “Let’s go all out, just like we practiced. Showtime.”

Ch22 - Under Pressure / What Power Means

A heavy silence fell upon the room as the trainer's eyes met for the last time.

The battlefield between them was a complete mess. What was once a very nice tiled floor was now filled with shattered tiles, lingering ice and scorching marks of all sizes. Crystal pillars, fallen from the ceiling, littered the room. Juliana forced herself not to dwell on them, their faint glimmer sending shivers down her spine.

Despite all that, she stood her ground. She looked like a complete mess. Her skin was marked with rough scrapes and her Naranja Academy uniform was shredded here and there. Blood trickled from a particularly nasty gash on her right arm but she ignored the pain, lifting a Pokéball with her uninjured left hand. Beside her, Koraidon growled softly, his eyes fixed on Giovanni.

On the other side of the room, the man stood with his usual smirk, calm and collected. Unlike Juliana, he looked untouched by the battle. He was spotless, and unshaken. While her own face betrayed exhaustion and determination, his expression was as smooth as when the fight had begun. His black costume didn't have so much as a speck of dust on it.

Next to him was a small desk, somehow untouched by the destruction. On it lay a bag. **Her** bag. The stolen Scarlet Book and Tera Orb tucked safely inside. A Pokéball sat next to it. Koraidon's.

Mewtwo hovered in the middle of the room, calmly waiting for Juliana's move. Its piercing eyes only served to unnerve her even more. The Pokémon terrified her- she knew it, and it knew it too. But even still, she refused to back down.

Julianna focused. Once she would throw this Pokéball, all would go very fast. That was part of her plan after all, she just hoped it would work. So many things could go wrong and unravel everything she worked for.

But if she was to move forward, she had to put her worries aside and trust in her Pokémon… No. Her friend. They had only truly fought alongside once, and humiliatingly so, they lost that battle. It was only a few days ago, but since then they both had grown. This would be their test.

Juliana took a deep breath, closing her eyes to focus on her plan one last time. When she opened them, her Pokéball was already flying through the air. All eyes in the room followed its arc as it burst open in mid-flight, releasing the beast.

Roaring Moon emerged with a powerful roar, its unusual green scales shining in the bright light of the room. In a blink, the Paradox Pokémon flew through the air at top speed, rushing towards Mewtwo with almost murderous intent.

The Legendary Pokémon wouldn't let it get close. Mewtwo raised its hand, purple energy coiled around its fingers. A psychic aura surged outward, enveloping the charging Roaring Moon, aiming to seize the Pokémon mid-flight and slam it into the ground.

The aura flickered, and then dissolved into nothing.

Mewtwo's eyes widened in shock while Juliana smiled - her plan had worked! She had hoped that, rushed, the Psychic Pokémon would react on instinct and not realize her Pokémon's Dark type. And it *worked*.

Mewtwo's shock only lasted only a fraction of a second before it adapted though. With one hand, it quickly created psychic barriers using *Reflect*, stacking them in Roaring Moon's path to slow its approach. With the other it lifted a large crystal from the wrecked battlefield, using telekinesis to turn the shard into a weapon.

It didn't matter.

As Juliana called for a *Brick Break*, Roaring Moon crashed through the various walls as if they were nothing, shattering them. Juliana's Pokémon was nearly upon its target, and Mewtwo's expression tensed as it realized there wasn't enough time to wield the crystal. The Psychic Pokémon let it fall, shifting its focus to an emergency teleport.

Juliana's grin widened. If Giovanni could play off the books, so could she.

"*Pursuit*!" Juliana commanded.

Dark energy gathered around Roaring Moon's wings, propelling it forward with incredible speed. Before Mewtwo could react, the Paradox Pokémon closed the distance and seized the Legendary Pokémon by the throat. With a fierce roar, Roaring Moon slammed Mewtwo headfirst into the wall. Holding tight, it then dragged its prey along the jagged surface of sharp crystal shards, before throwing the Psychic Pokémon to the ground. Without giving it any chance to recover Roaring Moon pounced with a flurry of *Night Slashes*.

But Mewtwo wasn't finished. Exploiting a brief opening, it levitated the crystal from earlier and pulled it. The sharp shard smashed into Roaring Moon, sending it flying. The Paradox Pokémon recovered mid-air and shot back toward Mewtwo, who this

time, was ready. A *Focus Blast* erupted from its hands, shooting it directly toward its attacker. Juliana's eyes widened.

"Dodge it!" she yelled.

Roaring Moon twisted in the air, evading the glowing ball of Fighting type energy while razing the ground with an *Acrobatics*. It was back right in front of Mewtwo in an instant, assailing its opponent with tooth and claw. The Legendary Pokémon was overwhelmed- Roaring Moon never left no opening. It never stayed in one place too long, always finding a new angle to strike. The pressure kept building up and up until-

**** ENOUGH!***

The telepathic scream cut through Juliana's mind, forcing her to stagger back in shock. Mewtwo, did…

Did it just talk?

Her hesitation gave Mewtwo the time it needed. Surrounding itself with psychic energy, the Legendary Pokémon teleported high into the air, glaring down at Roaring Moon with an enraged expression. It extended its arms and *Auraspheres* shot out of its hands in rapid succession, all aimed at the Paradox Pokémon.

"Go low! Don't get hit!" Juliana shouted in panic. Getting hit by even one of these could turn the tide of the entire battle.

Roaring Moon darted forward like a bullet, flying through the air at unmatched speed while staying close to the ground. The Paradox Pokémon nimbly evaded every single ball of Fighting type energy, each crashing on the ground and creating clouds of smoke that obscured its path. Roaring Moon got closer and closer, until suddenly, it closed the gap.

With a sudden burst of speed, Roaring Moon grabbed Mewtwo's tail mid-air. The Legendary Pokémon had no time to react as it was swung violently in a wide arc and hurled into a crystal formation. Before it could recover, The Paradox Pokémon smashed into it with a devastating *Dragon Rush*, the force of the impact shattering the crystal and slamming Mewtwo into a wall.

Roaring Moon didn't let up. It grabbed the Pokémon again, dragging it from the rubble before throwing it to the center of the battlefield.

Mewtwo staggered back to its feet but fell to its knees, breathing heavily. Roaring Moon was flying back towards its target, prepared to finish the fight with one last *Dragon Rush*.

Juliana held her breath- **this was it**. One more blow, and it would all be over. She would win. After that she could get her bag back, make Giovanni reveal Terapagos' location, find her friends, apologize for leaving them behind, rescue her Pokémon-

A dark chuckle interrupted her thoughts.

"Very well!" Giovanni had a manic look in his eyes. "A real challenge then! I haven't felt this alive in years. I must thank you, child!" He gestured toward Mewtwo. "But I'm afraid that this is where your journey ends. Behold, Champion of Paldea, the power of **Mega Evolution**!"

Juliana watched with confusion- then horror as Giovanni raised a hand to a rainbow button on his sleeve. A sudden wave of power surged through the room as a blinding light enveloped Mewtwo. The Legendary Pokémon changed form, becoming bulkier and heavier. Its legs planted themselves into the ground while its arms flexed with newfound strength, preparing itself for what was to come.

Roaring Moon finally reached the Legendary Pokémon, Dragon energy surrounding him as he collided into his target. Juliana was forced to cover her eyes as smoke temporarily filled the room following the impact - but when she could see again, her heart skipped a beat.

Mewtwo was holding her Pokémon in place with only one hand, its strength impossible to comprehend as Roaring Moon was left thrashing uselessly in its grasp. *It* sneered and looked at the Paradox Pokémon with disdain as it charged up a *Focus Punch*, hitting it square in the jaw. The impact echoed through the room like a gunshot.

Despite that, Roaring Moon's thrashing grew more desperate- biting and clawing, everything it could do to try and free itself. Slowly but surely, Mewtwo's grasp weakened and the Paradox Pokémon was able to fly away, crash landing at Juliana's feet.

Juliana's mind was racing. *Okay*, she thought, this form of Mewtwo was way bulkier. Maybe even a Fighting type now. There was no overwhelming it with raw strength like before. But from the looks of it, what it gained in pure strength and defense, it lacked in speed and range.

New plan: hit and run. Death by a thousand cuts as they say: wear it down without ever lingering too close to it, and it would do the trick.

“Roaring Moon!” She called. “*Aerial Ace*! Be careful!”

Roaring Moon barreled forward at high speed, its wings glowing with Flying Type energy. But just as it was about to reach Mewtwo, the Legendary Pokémon’s form shifted with a bright light, becoming sleeker and its tail fusing with the back of its head.

In an instant the Pokémon vanished - not with teleportation, but sheer unmatched speed. Roaring Moon was left clueless as Mewtwo appeared behind its back and mercilessly shot a *Focus Blast* out of its hand. The Paradox Pokémon never stood a chance. It let out a sickening cry of pain before collapsing to the ground.

Juliana couldn’t believe it. Just like that, it was over.

Mewtwo raised its opponent’s broken form with telepathy and threw it at her feet, its glare piercing with fury.

Juliana’s hand was shaking when she raised a Pokéball to recall her fallen partner. N- no, it wasn’t over! It couldn’t be! She couldn’t afford for things to end here - people depended on her, she had to win! She had to save the day! What good was she if she didn’t?

**** When will you stop pretending to play the hero part?***

She shook her head, trying to ignore the static clouding her brain. No, not yet. There was still hope! Roaring Moon had hurt Mewtwo pretty bad but maybe… maybe Koraidon could still finish the job. Yeah, that was her angle!

“Koraidon!” She yelled. In sync with its trainer’s thoughts, Koraidon was already on the move. It was all or nothing, they both knew it. The Winged King rolled into a fiery ball of pure energy as it launched in a *Collision Course* with the Legendary Pokémon.

But Mewtwo was ready. Psychic Energy surrounded her Pokémon and sent it hurling straight into a wall. Koraidon didn’t have time to recover as Mewtwo slammed it over, and over, and **over** again, each impact sending tremors through the room. The ceiling shook with each impact, crystal dust flowing everywhere.

Finally, when Mewtwo let up, Koraidon stood motionless under a pile of rubble. Its eyes were shut, its body limp.

That was it. She lost. Juliana had lost this battle.

Giovanni chuckled- then let out a full out laugh across the room, but her ears were ringing, her vision blurry. She couldn't hear him, couldn't see him, only staring in sheer disbelief at her fallen Pokémon. Her partner, her friend, unconscious once again.

She had lost.

Giovanni's voice felt distant, she couldn't make out his words - surely he was taunting her again, as he had done before. Had he been right all this time?

**** Pathetic.***

That voice - again, it filled her mind. It wasn't her own, was it? It was Mewtwo's, she heard it during the fight. She glanced away from her fallen friend and at the Legendary Pokémon. It had reverted to its base form, anger behind its eyes. And… a hint of disappointment?

Giovanni said something, a command to his Pokémon. She didn't care anymore. She felt so, oh so tired. Even standing up was becoming too much. Her knees felt like they were giving out under her. But soon, she realized her feet weren't even touching the ground anymore.

Coming out of her daze, she was lifted off the floor with telekinesis by Mewtwo. The Psychic Pokémon's eyes glowed with an ominous glint as she was slammed into a wall, held up against its ragged surface of jagged crystals by an overwhelming Psychic force.

She was forced to close her left eye as her vision blurred with red. The wound on her forehead had reopened and left blood dripping down, obscuring her sight.

Despite everything, she welcomed the pain. It grounded her, helped her focus back on the present. She struggled against the gravity holding her in place. It was useless, she could only watch as Giovanni slowly made his way towards her.

"Give up, child. You've lost this battle fair and square. Contrary to what you believe, I do not wish to end your pitiful existence."

She glanced at him. "*Really? Could have fooled me."*, she wanted to retort. She couldn't of course, due to the extreme pressure and pain she was feeling at this instant. She was pretty sure that if she could even open her mouth, the only thing coming out of her throat would be garbled sounds.

"You are far too valuable of an asset for that. I could use a tool like you, unlike these dimwits I have to keep around in this organization. Give up this fight, and you can

become something more as part of Team Rocket. Refuse and, well, things will go unpleasant.

He paused and smirked. “Maybe I’d be forced to use Nihilego venom to force you to cooperate just like that woman, Geeta.”

Her face must have betrayed her emotions because a sharp laugh came out of the man.

“Surprised? How did you think the Paldean League came under my thumb? I must really thank this woman’s researches. But think about this, Champion. Accept this deal and you will be given the chance to right your wrongs.” He made wide gestures with his arms. “You could rewrite history: save the Professor, become the hero you’ve always pretended to be. Refuse, and I **will** break you down - I have the means to. I will make you destroy everything you have sworn to protect. What will it be?”

She clenched her fists. A wave of nausea ran past her: the idea of serving him, of being robbed of her free will… It was agonizing. Terrifying, even. What would happen to her Pokémon? To her friends?

She should have been fighting back, she knew it. Even though her Pokémon were down for the count she should try to run, do everything to get back to them. But she felt so, oh so tired. She was beyond exhausted after months of fighting without any end in sight. Would…

Would it be so bad to let go?

What if Giovanni was telling the truth? Could she… could she write a better world? One where Arven could have his parents, where she could make sure Nemona never was alone? Where Penny and the rest of Team Star would have never been bullied? Where she wouldn’t have robbed Kieran of his dreams?

She- she had done so much. Tried to fix so much, all in vain. The pains of the past would always taint the future. Could a second chance change all that?

Her head hurt. Professor Sada, would she have thought highly of her now? Trapped as she was in a hell of her own making, trying desperately to amend what was broken? Could her spirit have lived on, if she had done the right things?

A distant rumbling could be heard in the distance, blending into static in her mind.

She was so tired. Her mind was cloudy, right and wrong mixing together so much that she couldn't discern anymore what was truth or lie. Dreams of a better tomorrow were intermingling with her crushing guilt, all making **his** offer so, so sickly enticing.

The rumbling was getting louder.

'His offer,' she remembered. That was right- this was Giovanni she was thinking about. This was a crooked man who had done so much to hurt her, to hurt her friends! She didn't know what was right or wrong anymore. But one thing was clear. She could not accept anything he offered.

The rumbling grew even louder now. Clearer too. She realized the sound was real, not just existing within her mind.

Giovanni felt her shift in resolve. He scowled. "Do you still cling on to your futile hopes? It's over, child. No one will come for you. Your supposed 'friends' all have abandoned you, left you to die in vain."

The sound was oddly familiar, she was sure she heard it before. Where did it even come from? Outside? Whatever it was, it was getting closer and closer.

"Don't you understand now?" He continued, oblivious to the sound. "'Friends', 'Pokémon', these are just tools for one's own gains. And when a tool is broken, they are discarded. That's what they've done to you. I've shown you myself the futility of holding on to these childish hopes."

She recognized it. It was the sound of an engine- accompanied by screaming. Her attention snapped to Giovanni, the man still monologuing. He didn't suspect a thing. But Mewtwo, with sharper senses, seemed to start to realize what was happening. The Pokémon tensed up, looking past her.

"But still, I believe that what is broken can be remade into something greater." Giovanni said, pulling a syringe containing a colorless sludge out of his jacket pocket. "It just requires a bit of effort, and encouragement."

Juliana felt sick to her core. Nihilego venom, just like he said. She was ashamed even considering giving in to his offer before. But she was powerless, left only to hope that whatever was coming her way would be fast enough.

Giovanni moved forward, ignoring the clear tension in his Pokémon, still talking his nonsense even now. He didn't hear the engine roaring even louder and louder, the vehicle now clearly approaching fast. Too fast even, until-

CRASH

The wall **exploded** right next to her as a Starmobile crashed through, right into where Mewtwo and Giovanni were standing. The psychic pressure held on Juliana faded as she was hurled away from the blast, debris narrowly missing her. The room was chaos, dirt and crystal dust obscuring everything.

Juliana landed painfully on her bad shoulder. Ears ringing and coughing up dust, she awkwardly pushed herself back up using her last strengths. She was scared, she had no idea where Mewtwo and Giovanni had disappeared to.

She feared the worst. Trying to discern the dark figures moving through the settling dust while clutching her shoulder. Her vision was blurry. Her ears were ringing. Her head hurt. Yet, slowly but surely, the world around her started to clear itself, until…

“Juliana!”

She jumped when she first heard her name being called. She didn’t recognize the voice at first, but something about it felt familiar. Desperate, even, yet still friendly. A whole bunch of similar calls were made, all looking for her. She considered hiding away for a second, unsure of who it could be, but she ultimately answered.

“...Here!” Her voice cracked. It felt weak, hesitant. She wasn’t even sure anyone had heard her until one figure seemed to stop in its tracks. The person yelled something indiscernible, and then started running towards her at full speed. It was only a matter of seconds before Juliana could make out the details: a Naranja Academy Uniform, black hair tied in a ponytail with two green streaks, a red arm brace to help compensate for an old injury.

No, this couldn’t be real. She couldn’t be here. Not here, not now, not after everything. This had to be a fragment of her mind, a hallucination. A trick. She felt like she was going to cry, her knees buckling. She fell, but didn’t hit the ground. Instead she felt warmth, comfort, strong but caring arms had stopped her, held her, and there was something wet on her shoulder.

“N… Nemona?” Juliana questioned. A tear-struck face pulled back from her shoulder, smiling gently at her as Nemona pushed some hair out of her face.

“Jules I- I- I was so scared! You disappeared behind that door and I tried to follow you but it shut, and I tried to open it, for so long, but I- I-”

“Is…” Juliana gulped, eyes wide. Nemona all but forgot her rambling, looking at her with deep concern.

“Is this real?” Juliana asked, still in shock. “I- I can’t… I don’t know if…”

Nemona suddenly pulled her in a bone-crushing hug, holding her close to her chest. “Yes.” She whispered in her ear. “Yes it is Jules. I’m here. We’re here. It’s okay now.”

Juliana reciprocated the hug. The dam broke as she wailed in her friend’s uniform- forgetting all about Giovanni or Mewtwo. She didn’t notice her other friends finding them like this, watching the scene with a relieved smile and giving them space.

She’d be okay.

Ch23 - Losing Oneself / What Power Means

Juliana didn't know just how long she stayed like that. Wrapped in Nemona's arms, breathing in the scent of sweat, smoke, and sun-warmed fabric. She didn't care.

But eventually, reality crept back in. The stench of scorched plastic. The crackle of flames. The heaviness of crystalline dust in the air. The distant, familiar voice of Penny muttering something about 'stupid security systems' and 'how are we not dead?'. Arven coughed loudly nearby, kicking a chunk of crystal aside.

It wasn't over yet.

She sighed heavily, pulling back and meeting Nemona's eyes. Her heart clenched- they both knew. She had still more work to do. Nemona knew that she couldn't sit still. But that didn't stop the desperate worry in her eyes, the pleading look to just stop. To take a break. And how Juliana would like that, her entire body *screamed* at her not to continue with this. To rest. But she couldn't.

They didn't say a thing as Juliana stood again on her own, Nemona supporting her. She glanced around the room, finally able to take it all in. Rubble was everywhere, thick crystalline dust beginning to spread out. Giovanni and Mewtwo were nowhere to be seen, the man's desk (and her bag) buried under large rocks fallen from the ceiling. A Starmobile was lunged inside a wall, Eri and Carmen investigating potential damage to the vehicle and trying to unstuck it.

Penny and Arven kept themselves busy combing through the rubble, trying very hard to hide 'subtle' glances at her and Nemona, as if making sure she was still breathing without being overbearing. She appreciated that. By the look in their eyes, they were going to have a conversation after all this. She didn't look forward to it, but she knew she owed them as much.

She closed her eyes. She needed to focus. What now? Giovanni was out of commission for the moment but he could be back at any minute. She needed to know where Terapagos was. Scrap that, she already had a hunch. So, that left her bag, with the Scarlet Book in there. If she could find it she could heal her team-

Koraidon.

She opened her eyes and rushed towards where she remembered him landing after Mewtwo dealt with him. He had to still be there, buried under rubble. She barely registered Nemona's startled cry or the footsteps of her friends chasing after her, blood pulsing loud in her ears.

Not again- she couldn't lose him again. She just had gotten him back, *please, please be okay* she pleaded. As she reached the rubble she didn't waste time, frantically pushing rocks and crystals away, ignoring the dulling pain in her arms and the shivers she felt when catching glimpses of her own reflection. No wonder everyone was so worried for her, she looked half-dead on her feet. Her friends gave up trying to stop her, instead helping her clear out the rubble.

Finally, bright red scales appeared through the cracks. In no time, the limp form of Koraidon was unearthed, still breathing. She didn't remember moving- but suddenly, she was there, arms wrapped tight around him, whispering frantic thanks to whatever god was still listening.

Still, Koraidon was so… unmoving, it unnerved her. She didn't know what to do. She looked helplessly around her. Penny and Arven were rummaging through their respective bags as Nemona put a comforting arm around her shoulders, her trained eyes scanning over every injury the Paradox Pokémon had sustained, no doubt committing them to memory so as to treat them properly. Only now Juliana realized that she must have looked at her the same way when they first reunited.

Finally, Penny handed Nemona an array of medicine - Hyper Potions and Full Restores galore - and as she set off to work, Arven knelt next to Juliana, a sandwich in his hands.

"Hey there, bud. It's going to be okay. Remember our good old days of Herba Mystica hunting? I made a sandwich, just like back then. I'm sure, if it worked so well for Mabostiff the last time, Koraidon's going to be up and running in no time."

Penny approached her too, putting a shaking hand to her shoulder. Juliana couldn't shake the lump in her throat but she put her own hand on top of hers, thanking her physically without taking her eyes off of Koraidon's still limp form.

They stood like that in silence, watching Nemona work.

Minutes passed. It felt like hours.

The silence was heavy, sacred. No one dared to talk. Juliana couldn't look away even if she wanted to, as she watched Nemona tending to Koraidon.

She had *promised* it wouldn't happen again. That she'd never leave his side again. But she had. She failed. And it hurt. It hurt far deeper than any wound. It felt like she could suffocate. His and Terapagos' absence had weighed so heavily on her for so

long, like part of her was missing. Damaged. Broken. And even after finding him again, she couldn't protect him.

She sat slumped against the wall. Arven and Penny had left her a few minutes ago, offering quiet words of comfort and a tight squeeze. They'd taken her other Pokémon for healing, whispering with Eri and Carmen about the Starmobile situation.

As she sat there in silence, she couldn't help but look back on everything that had happened so far. The Juliana she was a few years ago, when she first started her adventure, felt so foreign to her now. Distant, a complete stranger.

Since then she had risen to Champion Rank in the Paldean and Blueberry League, uncovered the truth about Team Star and helped them reintegrate to society. She had fought Titans and Paradox Pokémon alike, explored Area Zero and saved the region from ecological doom by stopping the Professor's Time Machine. She had travelled far and wide, went to Kitakami and revealed the truth of Ogerpon's tale, befriending the Legendary Pokémon. She had delved into the depths of Area Zero, catching an ancient and forgotten Pokémon, the origin of Terastallization itself, Terapagos.

But despite everything she accomplished, all her titles and claims to fate, she couldn't help but think back on everyone she failed, to everything she lost. She'd watched what was left of Arven's mother vanish into the Time Machine. She'd pushed Kieran away, robbed him of his dreams, and left him a hollow shell, obsessed with power, hating her for it. She had been disowned by the League, betrayed by someone she trusted. She had fallen prey to Team Rainbow Rocket, losing pieces of herself. She had stood against wicked power and corruption, and **failed**. In the end, despite her struggles, she had lost to Giovanni. She wasn't even sure she would have declined his offer, if it wasn't for her friends.

She had nearly died so many times, 'death' didn't scare her anymore. Yet Terastallization still terrified her. The image of the man from the lab, turned into a crystal statue, was burned deep within her mind. She could still see him every time she closed her eyes. Felt the same way too, crystals progressively enveloping her, restricting her movement, stopping her breathing, covering her face and body until all that was left of her was a glimmering statue forgotten in a cave somewhere.

Why was she still here?

How was she still alive?

Giovanni had always spoken of power like it was a weapon, something to wield. She'd spat his words back in his face, refused to be shaped by them.

But they clung to her. Not because he was right, but because the question **was**. What **is** power?

That is what this was always about, wasn't it? Team Star, the Pokémon League, Professor Sada, Kieran, Giovanni… It all led to this. The power to choose fate, to change things. To make a difference. The power to be ourselves in the face of adversity. The power to stand against something bigger than oneself. The power to take back something that is yours, to rise above your own condition. The power to **take**, to seize control. Power for a greater purpose, or even for power's sake.

She had needed power, time and time again, on her journey. To protect who she could, to prove herself to the world, to stop a bigger threat. But that same power was always double-edged. It **took** from her just as much as it gave. It stripped away her innocence, her identity, her dreams. It brought pain to others. It invited challenge. It corrupted people.

Who was she now?

A Champion? A Hero? A Failure? A Tool? A Child?

What *was* she?

A yawn escaped her mouth.

Tired. She was tired.

At this point, it might as well have been days since last she had been able to get a good night's sleep. Months, if you didn't count her passing out after jumping off a cliff.

She had fended off exhaustion as best as she could for a while now, but she couldn't do it forever.

She slowly closed her eyes and slowed her breathing, as a dreamless sleep overtook her.

The first thing Juliana felt upon waking up was that something was wrong. She had felt it before, this oppressive atmosphere, the slight ringing in her ears, the way crystal particles seemed to suspend themselves in the air, all signs that preceded a powerful psychic force.

The second - and oddest - thing she felt, was just how comfortable she was. Opening her eyes, she was mildly surprised to find herself slumped between Nemona, Arven and Penny in a mess of limbs. Koraidon had curled up around them, the crumbs on the ground the only testament of the Herba Mystica sandwich he must have finally eaten.

He looked better. At peace. Healed. She felt a weight vanish from her chest.

Looking around, the Starmobile in the wall was gone, as well as Eri and Carmen. They were still in Giovanni's ruined room, but the two were gone. No doubt her friends had stayed to make sure she would be okay, hesitant to move her during her sleep - because of her injuries or simply because they didn't want to wake her up, she could not tell.

Regretfully, Juliana pulled herself away from the group embrace, gently but urgently trying to awaken them. She could still *feel* it. Something was wrong. Nemona was the first one that stirred.

"...Juliana? What's wrong mi corazón?"

Juliana blushed at the use of the nickname - evidently, Nemona was still groggy waking up, she still didn't know what she was saying. She shook her head, focusing back on the task at hand.

"I… Something's wrong 'Mona." She stood in front of her friends - slowly awakening one after the other - and looked around the room, trying to discern where the source of the psychic force was situated.

Then she saw it.

A pile of rocks and crystals shook by the entrance. At first, it was just a light tremor, barely enough to stir dust. Then, a low rumble. Pebbles tumbled, a fracture spidered through neighbouring crystals, and with a sudden explosion, the pile collapsed.

Light dust covered what was left of the rubble, but Juliana could still tell by the shape, the sheer presence. Mewtwo.

By now, the group was barely alert, still groggy from their nap. Koraidon was in no fighting shape. She put a hand to her belt- she needed to be ready to battle if she had to.

It was empty.

She cursed under her breath as she looked at her missing Pokéballs in despair. Her Pokémon were still healing. She didn't stand a chance against Mewtwo without their support. Without them, they were just sitting Duckletts-

Then she noticed something on the ground, right next to them.

There, underneath rubble, between her and the Legendary Pokémon, a round white and purple object stood innocently on the ground. A Master Ball. Mewtwo's Pokéball.

She looked at the Pokémon once again. The dust had cleared and revealed his weakened form. It was heavily injured, breathing heavily and standing on one knee.

It didn't attack, didn't make a move.

It just watched her, its piercing eyes locked with hers in silence. Wary but defiant, proud, even in its broken state. It waited for her next move. It knew, somehow, what she would do next.

Juliana nodded. She understood what was asked of her without the need of words. She took a few steps towards the object, stumbling along the way. Her knees buckled under her when she reached her destination. She ignored the oppressive atmosphere suffocating her, the pressure weighing heavily on her every muscle, the confused shouts of her friends, finally beginning to come back to reality.

She ignored the shaking in her arms as she grabbed a sizable crystal. Ignored her reflection in its shimmering light. She **slammed** it as hard as she could against the Master Ball.

The first strike echoed. The crystal slipped from her grip, but she didn't let go. Her hands shook. She hit it again. And Again. Pent up desperation, anguish, even anger fueled every strike. Emotions she spent months suppressing. She swung the heavy crystal until she couldn't hold on to it anymore, until it fell heavily next to her in a deafening noise.

The Master Ball was reduced to scraps.

Tears flowed freely from her eyes, her throat felt raw. A heavy silence filled the room once again. Juliana wiped her face using her arms and stood up on shaky knees, turning back to Mewtwo. The Legendary Pokémon closed its eyes and nodded silently. A deep voice echoed in her head, brushing against her mind. Gentle, yet powerful.

**** Thank you, child of man.***

At this point, she had expected the Pokémon's telepathy. It had been difficult during the battle to discern just what part was Mewtwo's words from her own mind betraying her, but with some rest and a calmer state of mind, it was clear. Telepathy was weird: on top of words, so many emotions and feelings were projected onto her. Gratefulness, determination, anger. It wasn't just a dialog, but a real connection controlled by the Legendary Pokémon in front of her.

She looked at her friends. Judging by their reactions, they heard Mewtwo's words too. Nemona was in awe, Penny's eyes widened behind her glasses, Arven was in total shock, almost falling over if it was not for Koraidon. The Paradox Pokémon himself ignored everything, its eyes locked with Juliana's in worry.

It's okay, she communicated silently with a gesture. *I'm safe. Stay with them.*

Her partner seemed unsure, but ultimately decided to trust her. Grateful for his support, she turned back to the Legendary Pokémon. Mewtwo had recovered enough and was now levitating in the air, eyes closed as its skin glowed weakly in the aftermath of a *Recover*. The voice once again echoed in her head.

**** You have done well, human. Though, loathe as I am to admit it, you have earned my respect. Despite the transgression and arrogance of your kin. Do not worry about you or your allies. Now that I am free, I behold no wish to harm them.***

Juliana released a relieved breath she didn't know she even held.

**** But do not mistake my mercy for acceptance, human.***

Mewtwo's eyes opened and pierced through her with a terrifying light.

**** I still hold nothing but contempt for your wretched kind. You are but a hungry infection in this world, corrupting and consuming everything you touch. I do not forget ; nor do I forgive the past actions of humanity. One good act of kindness and compassion does not absolve you of your sins. After all, to humans, Pokémon are nothing more than tools.***

The Pokémon closed its eyes once again, crossing its arms.

**** Though you freed me from this man's grasp, I hold on to these memories. My birth in that lab, my design as a tool for power. Control. My own enslavement, the atrocities I was forced to commit, trapped by what your kind refer to as "Poké Balls". I know that, you too, understand what I am referring to. I have seen within your own mind the horrors that haunt you. Betrayal. Corruption.***

Death. The patterns you and your wretched kind are but doomed to repeat. We are similar in this way.

Mewtwo shook his head, his anger diminishing. He opened his eyes, pity in gaze. They locked eyes in silence for what felt like an eternity, Juliana refusing to back down.

Images flooded her mind. Past mistakes. Regret, fears. She still held his gaze. His slowly morphed from judgemental anger to a quiet understanding.

Eventually, Mewtwo closed back his eyes, turning his head. Juliana felt like she could breathe again.

**** Because of your hardship, your resilience and your kind actions, I have come to tolerate you, child of man. You are different from the ones I have known. Softer. Stronger.***

When he opened his eyes again, he was looking towards the tail end of the room. Where Giovanni's desk once stood, now a mess of crystal, rocks and various rubbles that had crashed there with the Starmobile.

**** Now, champion, stand aside. You can rest easy while I destroy the embodiment of all the sins committed by mankind.***

With the flick of his wrist, psychic energy exploded. Crystal dust and debris flew everywhere, revealing a broken desk, by which laid an unconscious man. Giovanni.

Blood marked his otherwise untouched face, the sight strange for Juliana who had never even seen a speck of dust on the man. A rock must have fallen on his head, knocking him out for an unknown amount of time. Broken glass laid in a puddle by his feet. What remained of the syringe of Nihilego venom he tried to inject into her. Juliana shuddered. She didn't even want to think what would have happened to her if he managed to reach his goal.

Mewtwo hovered in silence at the sight, then began to draw closer. His anger was palpable, his power surrounding him like an aura as he prepared to strike the unconscious man. Only now did it strike her: he intended to kill him.

Mewtwo was going to **kill** Giovanni.

She stumbled over herself before she even realized it. In this moment, she did the most stupid, reckless, irresponsible thing she could do.

She moved to stand in his way.

His gaze snapped to her in an instant, piercing glowing eyes staring through her soul once again. She hated it.

He paused in front of her. She heard it again. His voice in his head, tainted with hate, anger, righteousness and unwavering determination. It took all of her willpower not to stumble.

**** Move.***

"... No." She answered. Her voice came wavering, raw. She felt like she hadn't spoken in an eternity. Her throat was sore. Despite it, she stayed, challenging the gaze of the Legendary Pokémon.

**** Move, child. Or I'll make you.***

"No! You- you can't kill him. Please."

He seemed slightly surprised by her pleading. Mewtwo crossed his arms, tilting his head slightly as she felt him invading her mind.

**** Why protect him, mortal? This tyrant who caused such strife? I have seen what he's done to you.***

His gaze lingered on her various injuries, ranging from scraps to the still deep and untreated gash left by claws on her right arm. It didn't go unnoticed by Nemona, who still watched by the end of the room with the rest of her friends, protected and held back by a hesitating Koraidon.

**** I have seen what he took from you.***

Juliana put an unconscious hand at her belt, where Terapagos' Pokéball should have been.

**** And you and I both know what he planned to do with you.***

She shifted her weight without even thinking, moving slightly to hide the shattered syringe on the floor between her and her friends. Too late by the look of it, if the somber and surprised expression of Arven and Penny was anything to go by.

**** You have witnessed first-hand the depths of this man's malice. The pain he's willing to inflict on others for his sake and his sake alone. His greed, his hunger for power knows no bound. So, child of man, why do you stand for him?***

“I… It’s wrong. He’s- he’s unconscious, defenseless. Please, don’t do this.”

She gulped. Truth was, even she didn’t know why she was protecting him. Only that it felt **right**.

**** He did not hesitate to do much worse to you when you were more vulnerable. He must pay for his crimes. So, I ask again, why do you stand for him?***

“I- I stand because it is my duty. He must pay for his crimes. You’re right. But he can only do so in life! We are not judge, jury and executioner, we cannot decide who lives and who dies based on our whims. That’s what **he** does. I refuse to believe in his way, I refuse to let him win. We are better than that. We are better than him!”

She met his gaze, forcing herself not to flinch. For a moment, the only sound was the gentle hiss of falling dust. Then-

**** I am not.***

A sudden psychic force pushed her violently to the ground. The Pokémon floated onward, unconcerned by her existence.

**** I was created for power, a tool for my human captors.***

**** Power is all that I am, all that I stand for. And I have achieved this purpose. I am the paragon! The epitome!***

He stopped above the unconscious man, raising a hand to Giovanni’s head. Energy pulsed in a devastating attack, aimed to kill the man. Juliana could only watch in horror, powerless, from the other side of the room.

**** Born from the sin of mankind’s arrogance, I have long since ascended above your gods! So let this be my decree. You, who too, stand for power, I shall condemn-***

A thunderous roar interrupted his speech, echoing through the room like a primal eruption. Mewtwo froze in place, his hand hovering over Giovanni as his glowing eyes shifted to the side. He watched warily the massive figure taking heavy steps towards him.

Koraidon.

The Paradox Pokémon stood high in his battle form, his feathers bristled, his muscles tense. Koraidon placed himself between Mewtwo and Giovanni, his gaze defiant against the Psychic type.

Mewtwo's expression didn't change. The air thickened as the two legends gaged each other.

**** ... You would challenge me, winged king of a past long gone? Even untethered from the chains of their enslavement? For her? For him?***

Koraidon lowered his head, a deep growl in his throat. The message was clear.

Juliana pushed herself to her elbows, pain all over her body. Her vision swam but through it, she saw Koraidon looking back at her. A silent confirmation. *I've got you*. Juliana nodded back, grateful.

**** You who basked in freedom, long before the shackles of humanity. Why protect them? Why stand against my divine judgement?***

Koraidon expended his feathers as he looked Mewtwo in the eyes, communicating the way only a Pokémon could. Mewtwo lowered his hand and crossed his arms, deep in thoughts.

Juliana painfully stood up, limping to pull herself next to Koraidon. She put a comforting hand to his back while he shifted his tail to help her stand up. The Psychic Pokémon didn't spare a glance.

**** I… I see. You speak of bonds, of trust. Concepts that I don't know of, qualities perverted by that man. Yet, despite your pain, despite your captivity, you would put your faith in her.***

His gaze darted back to her.

**** And you, still you will stand? Bruised, broken, beaten, between death and the one who wronged you?***

She didn't answer. She couldn't. Her body trembled with exhaustion, but her eyes stayed locked on his. Koraidon stood tall beside her, ready for anything.

For a long moment, there was nothing but silence, and a crushing pressure.

Then, a deep laugh echoed through her mind. The pressure subsided.

**** Fools.*** The word echoed without venom. ***Your conviction is misplaced. Yet, not without merit.***

He looked at Koraidon with what could only be described as strange curiosity, fascination.

**** We couldn't be more different. You were not made, you just 'were'. And still, you would protect her. Time and time again if you were given the choice, you would still make the same decision. You would always choose this mortal. Maybe there is more to it that I cannot yet see, blinded by the sins of my birth.***

Juliana swayed on her feet, heart pounding. "Does- does that mean?"

Mewtwo nodded. ***I will not end him. Not here. Not now.***

She nearly collapsed from relief. Koraidon put his weight under her with a panicked yelp.

Mewtwo hovered higher in the air, turning away from her.

**** But understand, my mercy is not yours. It is not his. It is mine. Here and now, just like you, I chose my own fate. But do not think I've forgotten the sins of creation.***

She nodded, grateful. "I- I understand. Thank you."

He looked back over his shoulder, a shadow of a smirk on his face.

**** Do not thank me yet, human. Behold.***

Psychic energy swirled in his hand as he lifted an object from the rubble next to Giovanni. It landed at her feet with a soft thump.

Her bag.

The fabric had seen better days, but it was still there, the object of her quest, just in front of her. She stood in shock before rushing it open, rummaging through it.

Koraidon's Pokéball. Her Tera Orb. It was all there.

She gazed back at Mewtwo, tears in her eyes, her throat tight. "Wh- why?"

His eyes flashed and a vision flashed through her mind. The lab. That cursed lab with the Time Machine. She yelped in surprise at the sight.

**** You sought to preserve life. Yours. His. Even mine, by granting me freedom. So I shall give you the means to continue on your quest. You must confront your fears, your past, child.***

He turned away, hovering closer to the ceiling. He looked upwards and reached with his hand, as if trying to hold the unseen sun above in his hand.

**** I wish you well on your quest, human. See this to the end. Do not disappoint me.***

With a purple flash, he vanished as if he was never there to begin with. Juliana stared at his afterimage for a while before her knees buckled under her, her body finally collapsing as the adrenaline slowly faded away.

She felt more than she saw Koraidon supporting her, her friends rushing to her side. As the ringing in her ear deafened her and her vision blurred in front of her eyes, she stopped fighting it- still clutching her bag like a lifeline.

Someone asked her a question. She didn't know what it was. Only one thing was on her mind though. So, she responded.

"I know where Terapagos is."

Ch24 - Breathing Out

“...and I can’t believe you would do that!”

Juliana winced as Arven dabbed at another cut with rubbing alcohol. The worst of her injuries - especially the nasty gash left by Giovanni’s Persian - had already been bandaged, but there were still dozens of scrapes and shallow wounds to disinfect. It sucked.

Worse still, Arven and Penny had chosen this exact moment to stage an intervention. While treating her wounds, they’d begun *’the talk’*, which consisted in a back-and-forth of exasperation, disappointment, and cautious reproach. She’d already apologized profusely, but they weren’t letting it go this easily this time. Juliana found that she couldn’t especially blame them considering… everything that happened before. How she broke her promise, the state they found her in, and the whole ordeal afterwards with Mewtwo. But still.

At least Nemona was by her side, a comforting hand on her back. Juliana could feel her watching, dissecting, reading her like a hurt Pokémon. She couldn’t meet her gaze. She wouldn’t. If she did, she knew she’d break. Nemona’s concern, the hurt on her face- it would shatter her.

Giovanni’s words still echoed in her head. He was wrong about her friends. He had to be.

She also avoided looking at her reflection in the massive crystal across from them. After Mewtwo’s departure, they had regrouped near the professor’s lab, meeting up with Kieran and Carmine. The siblings stood a little ways off, choosing not to intervene, though she could feel their eyes on her too. Kieran had claimed to be keeping watch, but she knew better. They were worried. She couldn’t blame them - Nemona had told them everything. Plus, she looked like hell.

She couldn’t meet their eyes either. Last time she did in this place, Kieran blamed her for all the wrongs in his life. He hadn’t been wrong to.

Team Rainbow Rocket had mostly cleared out from these lower levels, leaving a chaotic aftermath. Penny had explained that the tremors from earlier had stirred up the entire crater, sending Paradox Pokémon into a frenzy. While Team Star and Director Clavell were still holding the upper levels, trying to contain the worst of it, Penny had quietly suggested that maybe it was time they left too.

Juliana didn’t mean to tune her and Arven out, unresponsive as she still could vaguely see their mouths talking through her unfocused vision. But her mind was trapped elsewhere.

Terapagos was ***so close***, she just knew it. Mewtwo had all but confirmed it: her Pokémon must be in the place from where all her worst memories stem from.

The room underneath the Professor's lab. Her biggest failure. The place that still haunts her memories every night.

The room of the Time Machine.

She clenched her hands. Now, standing still, she was alone with her thoughts. She was consumed by the guilt of not being able to protect her Pokémon. Her responsibility. This Pokémon of ancient power that acted like a baby, that looked up to her like a mother.

She had to get to him. Who knew what they planned with him, especially after witnessing the experiments with Terastallization in the Rocket labs, after seeing how they treated Koraidon.

Another tremor shook the cave, more violent this time. Penny interrupted her rambling with a yelp as she was supported by Koraidon, the Paradox Pokémon hovering protectively around the group the entire time. Now that she thought about it, the way he looked at her, he wasn't exactly disagreeing with Penny and Arven. She made a mental note to have a long conversation (apology) with her entire team once all of this was over.

The tremor continued to shake the room. Juliana narrowed her eyes, looking at the door to the Professor's lab. These were getting worse and worse. If- if a rock or a crystal fell from the ceiling and blocked the way, what could she do? Terapagos would be stuck down there. Alone and frightened, in the hands of the one person that orchestrated this whole nightmare.

Without even thinking, Juliana pushed herself to her feet.

"Where do you think you're going!?" Penny exclaimed.

"I have to-" Juliana began.

"You only 'have' to rest." Arven butted in. He had his arms crossed, looking tired.

"But- You don't understand!" She exclaimed, trying her best to reel in the desperation from showing in her voice. "Terapagos could be **right there**, beneath our feet, in that lab. I have to get him. And with the tremors, I have to do this now! I can't- I can't fail him too."

Arven visibly winced at her words. She could feel Kieran look away from her. Penny's eyes sharpened. She was about to retort when Nemona stood up next to her.

Juliana didn't look at her.

"Jules, I… I can't watch you do this to yourself anymore." Her voice trembled. "It terrifies me, how little you seem to care about your own life. You almost- you could have died today. Not just once, but multiple times."

Nemona took her hand. Juliana's breath caught. She still didn't look at her, eyes fixated onto the entrance to the Professor's lab.

"I was so scared when we got separated. I didn't know if I'd find you, if you'd even be breathing. And even now, I keep thinking about what would've happened if we hadn't gotten there in time. If that man had-" Nemona cut herself off, voice cracking. "If he'd finished what he started."

Juliana gently pulled away, not daring to look her way.

"I- I'm really sorry about all that 'Mona. But I'm fine now. I have to keep moving."

"Bullshit." Penny called, exasperated. "That's exactly our point, you don't."

Juliana shook her head, her voice raw. "I really have to. Terapagos is down there. He is my responsibility. **I** started this mess, so **I** need to finish it. I have to get him back." She put on a shaky smile. "I'm fine."

"Oh come on bud', stop pretending." Arven interjected, rolling his eyes. "You're NOT fine, we all know that. It's too late for this charade buddy, we've seen you in there. The masks are off, that creepy psychic Pokémon made sure so. We've seen you, it's okay. We know you're strong, but you don't need to be. Remember what you've told me? 'You need to take better care of yourself' and all that."

Her emotions got the better of her. Juliana didn't even notice the tears flowing down her face as she raised her voice. "But- but if I'm not fine, if I'm not strong anymore, If I can't do this, then who am I? ***What*** am I? When- when all is said and done, if I stop here, if I stopped at any time before, what would I have left?"

"US! YOU HAVE US!" Nemona snapped.

The group fell silent.

Juliana stared at her, eyes wide. Her breath caught. Nemona's eyes shimmered, brimming with unshed tears, desperation threading through her voice.

"You have us, Jules." She repeated, softer now, almost pleading. "I- I know you're used to doing everything alone. I know you've had to be strong. But you don't have to anymore. We're here. We *want* to be here. You don't have to protect us. Just… trust us, please. Let us in."

Their eyes caught. Juliana was left speechless, transfixed in Nemona's glare. Just like she predicted- the emotion, the pleading, the ***care***- it was all too much, she felt like she was unraveling in real time.

She tried to speak, she wanted to retort, but she couldn't. The lump in her throat blocked out any words, any sound she could make. She was drowning in her eyes, her mind stopped. Overwhelmed. It took everything she had left not to collapse in tears, not to let herself fall into her arms and try to dry her watery eyes.

"But…" She managed to croak out despite everything. "...Terapagos…"

"We'll get him." Nemona put a gentle hand on her shoulder, a smile on her face so bright it shone through the darkness, banished fears and doubt from her mind. Her exhaustion melted away in an instant. She felt as if something tore open in her chest.

Nemona turned her gaze to the rest of the group and nodded. "Together".

It took a herculean effort from Juliana to tear her eyes from her face. Arven looked proud, Penny gave a confident thumb up with a cocky grin, Carmine had a strange fond look on her face, Kieran was wiping away tears, trying and failing to cover up his watery eyes. Her friends all looked at her, that same hope in their hearts.

"Together," Juliana echoed in awe. She wiped away her own tears. She started feeling that hope too, growing from the hole inside of her. "Thanks guys, I- I don't know what I would have done without you."

Arven shrugged. "I know, you're hopeless without us-" he joked, before receiving a light punch on the shoulder from Penny.

"Ouch! Hey, what was that for?" He complained.

"'Cause you're an idiot." She replied, pouting while crossing her arms.

The elevator was silent.

Well, as silent as it could be.

Juliana shivered in the cold light of the ride, sitting on the floor. The first time she'd been in this exact same place, Professor Sada told her about the Time Machine.

She'd been told to be prepared to end her life.

The last time she'd ridden this elevator wasn't exactly great either, but Kieran looked sheepish enough not to remind her of that, lost in his own thoughts.

She sighed. Coming back into the lab had been… weird.

She'd remembered the messy, abandoned look of the place both times she was here. How could she forget? This whole building haunted her every night after all.

So it felt… uncanny to see the place in order.

Every paper and research element once spread across the ground now neatly sat on the desk. Not a speck of dust could be found. Even Sada's family photo had a new frame.

It was eerie. The person that opened the lab, the one that orchestrated everything had occupied the place. A lot of care went into restoring it.

She hated it.

It felt like a spat in the face of all that she lived. It felt like a taunt directed at her, for not upholding the legacy of the copy of the Professor she failed to save.

One look at Arven's face there told her he felt the exact same. Probably worse, this was still his mother after all.

Juliana let out a deep breath. This place sucked. It awakened every single bad memory she had. But she needed to get over this feeling. The elevator would soon get them to the Time Machine. It would be even worse there, she needed to be her best. None of her Pokémon had fully recuperated from Giovanni's fight, except for Koraidon, sleeping next to her. She didn't dare move an inch, scared to wake him up.

She couldn't spare thoughts for the corrupted crystals covering the Professor's bot as she faced it in battle. For the emptiness and sorrow in her eyes as she tried to kill her and doom the region. For the helplessness she felt seeing her vanishing into the machine. For-

A hand squeezed her own. She was pulled from her thoughts by Nemona, sat next to her, smiling warmly while wiping a stray tear on her face with her thumb.

“We’ve got you, Jules.” She said gently, but with so much hope. “Don’t worry, we’re doing this together.”

Juliana swallowed a lump in her throat, forcing her gaze away from her best friend.

“Right.” She said, unable to hide a smile on her own face. “Thanks.” She squeezed Nemona’s hand harder, not letting go. It felt like a lifeline.

Next to her, Kieran sighed heavily. He turned to her, face red and his eyes fleeting. He looked just about ready to pass out from nervousness.

“J-Juliana I… just wanted to say that, I’m, really, really sorry about everything. I should have taken your side back there. From now on, I’ll always have your back. You can count on me!” He almost shouted with determination.

Oh. So that’s what he was so worried about, fussing on for hours. It had taken a lot of courage for him to build up the confidence to tell her this.

“Thanks Kieran. Don’t worry, I’ve never blamed you-” she winced at her own words, not the better phrasing. “I- I mean, I really appreciate it. Really.” She smiled, tiredly but honestly.

Kieran’s face lit up, then went back to embarrassment as Carmine took the opportunity to tease her little brother. Penny soon joined in the fun, followed by Arven. Playful banter soon filled the elevator as Juliana watched in silence, unknowingly leaning on Nemona’s shoulder, her warmth stopping her shivers.

She loved her friends, she thought.

She didn’t know how much time had passed - seconds, minutes - when the elevator finally stopped and the door opened, stopping all conversation.

Juliana sat with her eyes wide open at the light pooling from the next room, frozen like a Deerling in headlights.

This was it.

Nemona turned to her, eyes betraying her nervousness, but still with that same smile pushing her forward.

“Let’s do this together, Jules.”

She nodded, letting the girl pull her to her feet as she followed her into the heart of the Professor's lab.

As Juliana and Nemona led the group through the elevator's door, the first thing that struck the champion was the lighting. Or rather, the lack thereof.

Back when she *~~failed the Professor~~* stopped the Time Machine and saved all of Paldea, she had at first been overwhelmed by this very room. The walls had been covered in crystals, all shining with the blinding chromatic light of a thousand bulbs. Not unlike Giovanni's room.

Now? The crystals still covered the walls top to bottom. But the light they emitted was infinitely more subdued, softer. It wasn't dark per se, just dim.

The second thing that struck her was the absence of sound.

The only thing she could hear were their collective steps on the cold metallic floor. Koraidon's low growl, like reassuring purring. Every single sound the group made reverberated on the crystal walls, echoing loudly.

Then, of course, there was the massive machine at the center of the room.

Standing high, the Professor's Time Machine was here, straight out of one of Juliana's nightmares. This enormous pyramid of dark pillars made out of some kind of alloy that shone in the dark like the distant stars of a clear night sky. The 'gate' on the ceiling that, in her dreams, swirled with Terastal energy and opened the portal to the distant past Sada disappeared to, was closed. Unlike her night terrors however, the machine had been further modified somewhat.

Some kind of device was embedded into the base of the Time Machine, so eerily out of place that her mind refused to acknowledge it until she couldn't deny it. Cables and wires connected the two machines together, sparks flying haphazardly from everywhere. Multiple screens and keyboards were thrown together on whatever kind of box, chair or pile of books could be found. All centered around a multifaceted crystal orb, looking as if it was ripped straight from Blueberry Academy's Terrarium. A miniature version of the Core that she was used to seeing hang from the ceiling. And in it, amidst pulsing water reminiscent of Kitakami's Crystal Pool, slept a blue and cyan creature.

Juliana's heart missed a beat.

Terapagos.

She wanted to cry, to *scream*. After all of this, he was **right here**. But Nemona's firm hand, still in a death grip, held her back.

Typing frantically at the keyboards was a person, mumbling something incomprehensible to themselves. Whoever they were, they were so preoccupied with their tasks that they didn't even notice their arrival.

Whoever they are - It hit Juliana all at once. This had to be it. The contact on her phone that betrayed her. The voice in the video log of the ruined lab, the one who took over the late Professor's research.

There they were.

She didn't notice how tense she had gotten until she heard Koraidon's low growl, responding to her emotions.

The person heard it too, raising their head in surprise. They turned around.

Miss Briar faced her with a manic smile on her face.

"Ah, welcome children! You've arrived just in time!"

Juliana couldn't move.

Or at least, it felt like it.

She was looking into the eyes of a crazed woman, a researcher and a teacher she ***trusted***. The same teacher that had used her for her own devices, took everything from her.

She couldn't say she didn't see it coming. She had a hunch ever since she first stepped into Area Zero that she had to be connected somehow. But still - Miss Briar had written a book about her, damn it. They delved into the core of Area Zero, discovered the 19th Tera Type and Terapagos together.

So, yeah. She wasn't exactly handling it well. Sue her.

"Miss Briar? What- what are you doing here?" Kieran asked as he stepped forward, lost. "And, what do you mean 'just in time'-"

“Ah, yes!” She ignored him, clapping her hands together. “Please children, I would tell you to take a seat, but I’m afraid this will have to be a standing class. Now, who can tell me what this is?” She gestured to the center of the room.

“The… Time Machine?” Arven answered, arms crossed.

Briar looked pleased, smiling brightly. “Why yes! Very good, Arven!”

Arven was taken aback. “You- you know my name?”

Briar merely giggled to herself. “Of course I do, silly! I know all your names! After all, you’ve made quite the reputation for yourselves.” Juliana could swear she looked at her with the eye of a predator.

The device behind her buzzed. Briar regained her composure and looked at the group like a teacher would her class.

“Ah, please pay attention, children. As you’ve correctly identified, this device is a Time Machine, built by the late Professor Sada. Using the power of Terastallization, this brilliant mind was able to breach Time and Space to pull ancient beasts from a primordial past-”

“We know what it is.” Juliana interrupted. She had let go of Nemona’s hand, fists clenched. Her voice came dry, tired. “Cut the bullshit, Briar. Hand over Terapagos.”

Briar wasn’t offended whatsoever. “Not yet! But you’re in a rush, I understand. I’ll make this quick! So, looking at the Professor’s research, she soon ran into a power problem. And, as you know, the Terastal phenomenon was the solution.”

She opened her arms wide, gesturing at the entire room. “Yet the thing is, despite its success, the Time Machine was never able to operate at full power! This entire room is designed to feed it as much energy as possible, but the process was uncontrolled and unpredictable, resulting in random objects being pulled from the past. But, what if the energy source was pure? If it was stronger? More focused?”

She paused, turning to the orb containing Terapagos.

“We could reach any point in Time and Space that we want, with **precision**.”

Juliana’s mind went to Giovanni. Was this what the man had mentioned when he beckoned her to join him? When he told her about changing the past, righting her wrongs?

“This is why I needed Terapagos! The origin of Terastallization itself, the purest source of energy you could imagine! Think about it, children. We could pull anything back.” Briar continued. “Or, if you prefer, ***anyone***.”

Juliana’s eyes widened in shock. She couldn’t mean-

“We could bring her back!” Briar exclaimed. “The Professor! We could reach beyond time and space and bring her back! We could even reach into different timelines, alternate universes! We could-”

“Why!?” Juliana almost yelled. “You’ve- you’ve brought Team Rocket here, kidnapped Terapagos and Koraidon, hacked my phone - all for this!? So that you could, what, resurrect someone you’ve never met? Why!?”

Briar looked confused for a second, then gently bent forward and booped her nose.

“But for you, my little hero!” She replied with a smile that was somehow both motherly and unsettling at the same time.

Juliana had no words. Her mind drew blank.

“I felt so terrible about what happened in the Underdepths. I pushed you and Kieran too far. And I remembered how sorrowful you looked when we found the Professor’s research papers. So, what better way to make amends than to bring her back?”

She had the nerve to look apologetic. Briar pulled back, facing the group.

“Of course, I’d be lying if I said there weren’t… other reasons. This research-children, it’s extraordinary.”

She locked eyes with Juliana. “You, you opened my eyes with Terapagos. The way you wielded Terastallization, the raw power you stood against… I thought I knew what power was. But I saw what it could become.”

Briar’s tone turned acidic, her expression rageful. “And yet, the Paldean League? They locked it all away, like frightened children hoarding treasure. The glimpses I had of the Professor’s brilliant mind, her research, kept a secret from the world. I appealed time and time again to that accursed woman, but she wouldn’t budge.”

Her face became peaceful once again, as if that moment never happened. “So yes, I used my contacts. And look how far I’ve come!”

She paused.

“Truthfully, I never intended for things to go this out of hand. Yet, associating with Team Rainbow Rocket has proven to be the best decision of my life! I don’t know how they’ve done it, but I could access anything I wanted thanks to them! Achieve my dream- as well as the Professor’s dreams. All I had to do was prove the usefulness of my research to Giovanni and tell them exactly what it would take to make it real. Sure, they had their… methods. But you’re still standing, aren’t you?”

She smiled, like it was all justified. Then turned back to her keyboards, humming.

Juliana’s limbs felt like stone. She couldn’t move.

“Anyway, with the lack of competent personnel, it’s been difficult calibrating the machine without qualified personnel - that was the source of the earthquakes, if you were wondering. This thing is really unstable!” She exclaimed, as if it was the funniest joke she’s heard in a while.

Juliana stayed unmoving while her friends all interjected. Their arguing felt like background noise. She couldn’t move, couldn’t think.

She did it for her.

Somehow, it was all her fault again.

A pression on her shoulder brought her back to reality. Nemona gave her a look.

“You okay?” She asked, worried.

Juliana shook her head. She needed to keep it together. Now was the time for action, the blame could wait until later-

“It’s not your fault.” Penny stated from behind, as if reading her mind. “She’s a grown ass woman who can make her own decisions. You’re not to blame for her fuck ups.”

“Yeah,” Arven added, pulling an arm around her shoulders. “Just like I’ve never blamed you for my robot Mom’s decision to abandon me again. ‘Cause that would be stupid. You get that?”

Juliana pulled away from their embrace. “But, Arven, if- if she could bring her back. Would you…?”

He smiled sadly with a fleeting look for a moment, before shaking his head without any hesitation. “Nope. I don’t care either way. I’ve made my peace with it.”

“And there has to be a hidden cost.” Penny added, narrowing her eyes at Briar. The woman ignored them, discussing with Carmine and Kieran.

“We won’t take it.” Nemona stated with finality. “And we have your back, remember?”

Juliana nodded, wiping away the tears in her eyes.

She turned to Briar, and reached for her wrist.

“I’ve made my choice, Miss Briar. Please stop, I don’t want this. I want Terapagos back.”

“Oh, but it’s already done, little hero.”

What.

Briar smiled. “I only needed to stall you long enough for the calibration to end.”

She pressed a button with her free hand.

And all hell broke loose.

Ch25 - Garden Paradise

Juliana awoke - not for the first time this week - with a ringing in her ears and a dull, throbbing pain in her head. She tried opening her eyes, but the light only worsened her headache.

What happened? Briar had activated her machine and… there was this… white flash.

The entire room shook. Terapagos emitted a blinding light, powerful as the Sun, that was magnified by the contraption and powered the machine. The light reverberated on the crystalline walls, making the room impossibly bright.

The sound was the worst of it. Terapagos had let out a painful cry, his voice powerful enough in suffering and volume to make her temples bleed.

She had begged Briar to stop the machine, to end things now. The scientist couldn't hear her over the cacophony of pain and machinery as Time and Space were ripped apart. She was fixated only on Terapagos, her gaze between morbid fascination and pure horror as she realized what she had done.

Juliana had pulled her arm - hard enough to hurt - to force her to meet her eyes. She saw wonder, yet also desperation and regret hiding behind a manic smile. The woman was realizing in real time that she was living her dream, but also what it was going to cost.

Her mouth moved, but Juliana couldn't hear her over Terapagos' cries. "I can't stop it," she read on her lips. "There is no going back now."

Juliana didn't have time to process any of it as Terapagos had surged in energy, machinery and cables absorbed into his legendary Terastal form.

Koraidon rushed to her side with a panicked yelp. She acted on instinct, sensing something was wrong, and called the Pokémon back to his Pokéball.

A wave of energy shook the room emanated from Terapagos, leaving behind a smooth crystalline surface on the ground as it spread. When the surge reached them both, the various keyboards, screens and machines in front of them overloaded and pulsed dangerously with too much power.

Juliana barely had time to react when they started exploding.

Yes, that felt right. And certainly explained why she felt so much like shit. Though, considering the past few days, not as bad as she expected.

As she shifted, trying to regain her footing, she realized she felt something warm beneath her.

Briar had seen the explosion coming, moving at the last moment to shield her with her own body.

Briar laid unconscious beneath her, still breathing.

She had protected her. Cushioned her fall as they were sent flying into a wall.

After everything she'd done, she still tried to protect her. Juliana felt conflicted about that.

Slowly, all her senses started coming back to her. The ringing subsided in her ears, replaced with an eerie silence, broken only by muffled sounds of machinery and a low crystalline hum.

Then, she was able to reopen her eyes without feeling she'd pass out from the pain. She could confirm she was indeed laying on top of Briar, a quick lookover confirming her the woman didn't suffer any major injury.

Looking around the room, she surveyed the aftermath of Terapagos' surge of power. The room was lit by the crystals, pulsing with a deep red hue that reminded her of bad memories. Thick crystalline dust hung in the air.

Her friends all were fine, being far enough from the explosion to not be affected in any major way. Nemona and Penny were helping up Arven - his oversized backpack making him look like an upside-down Avalugg. Kieran and Carmine were already on their feet, having noticed her and Briar and rushing to their side. Carmine went to check the Professor's pulse and injuries while Kieran pulled her in a hug.

"Juliana! Are you-"

"Yes, I'm okay Kieran." She interjected weakly. "Briar protected me. Please let go, you're killing my ribs."

"Oops! Sorry!" He let her go with a sheepish smile.

Whatever he said next didn't reach her ear as Juliana diverted her attention to Terapagos.

As dust cleared out, the Pokémon was floating above the ground in its Terastal form. His eyes shut, he floated gently as if dormant.

Somehow, machine parts had integrated his outer shell. Cables still connected him to the time machine. His whole body pulsed with the room, red lights blaring as a slow heartbeat.

In front of the Pokémon however, were two figures, standing confused and studying the room, both wearing lab coats.

The man wore the futuristic violet jumpsuit beneath his, bearing a face shaped by a clean shaven beard. The woman wore a primal caveman attire beneath hers made out of pelts and scarlet furs, her wild hair pulled back, flowing like a mane.

Juliana didn't recognize the man, but seeing the woman - her mind was stuttering. Was any of this real? Was this another flashback, an hallucination from her shattered brain?

Could it be that Briar had actually succeeded?

Because if she did, then this was Professor Sada.

She realized she had stopped breathing when her body almost fell to the ground. She could only reel in shock as she tried to find her footing again, mind assailed by thoughts and visions she had tried to suppress.

She had seen her die in this very room. She had failed to save her. She was responsible for this. Arven didn't have a mother because of her. She wasn't enough. She didn't deserve them. Their praise. Their comfort.

A hand clenched in hers. Arven looked as shaken as her, but he gave her a patient smile. As if to say 'we're in this together'.

She dared once again a glance towards Terapagos. The Pokémon was still in an eerie slumber, growing agitated as if he was having a nightmare. The two figures now crowded him, conversing between themselves.

Juliana pushed her doubts and fears away with a deep breath. It was time to end this once and for all. She was going to get her Pokémon back.

She let go of Arven's hand, stepping towards the Professor(s?). She was able to overhear their conversation as she got closer.

"...the true Treasure of Area Zero. Its power, the way it reacts to the Time Machine. It's fascinating, truly." The woman stated.

“I agree. If only I had discovered it sooner I…” The man trailed off.

Juliana made her presence known with a scoff. The two figures turned towards her in an instant, a dangerous glint in their eyes that subsided in a second. The way they moved, the fact that their torso didn’t move with respiration… These were AIs.

“H- Hi! I-”

“Hello, Juliana.” Sada(?) interrupted her. “You look older than my memory banks suggest. It seems your theory stands correct, Turo.”

“So it seems, Sada.” Professor Turo responded, deep in thoughts. “Tell me, child. Have I put you in charge of the Iron Serpent?”

Juliana frowned, confused. “N- No? If anything, Professor Sada did trust the Winged King into my care.” She put a careful hand to her belt, ready to have Koraidon out anytime.

Sada turned an inquisitive gaze at Turo as the man kept studying her.

“How fascinating,” he pondered, mechanically rubbing his chin. “and you look so similar to that boy, Florian, that I was about to meet. So my theory **was** correct.”

“So it seems, Turo.” Sada interjected. “A displacement from our original timelines into an alternate universe. And that Pokémon is truly, deeply fascinating. It seems Terapagos was the key to our research in more ways than anticipated”

Juliana was growing impatient with their back and forth, tuning their scientific argument out as she stared at Terapagos. She pushed past the Professors, intent on getting her Pokémon back.

She didn’t make a step before she was stopped by cold metallic hands clinging to her shoulders. She turned her head to see both Professor holding her back, their sclera a deep black contrasting with the ominous L.E.D. of their iris.

“What do you think you are doing, child?” They both demanded in unison.

“I- I’m getting Terapagos out of here.” She struggled to sound confident, pulling away from their hold- a little too harshly, she realized as she fell backwards. The only reason she didn’t land ass-first on the ground was because her friends had followed her, and so Nemona caught her with a yelp.

“Don’t rush yet, Juliana.” The Sada AI admonished. “Terapagos’ presence is the only reason we are still discussing. Even now, this Pokémon is using its power to keep us here.”

“We must take this chance to study it as much as possible,” The Turo AI added. “This is a once-in-a-lifetime opportunity that we can’t allow to go to waste.”

Juliana felt numb as her friends started to argue with the two AIs, standing unmoving and staring them down without a word. Behind the Professors, Terapagos started to grow more and more agitated in his sleep. Terastal energy ominously hovered around him in the air.

“Your presence is interfering with the parameters of the next experiment, children. Please, leave.” Turo ordered.

“If you don’t, then you will be moved by force.” Sada added.

Juliana shot up from Nemona’s arms. “I’m bringing Terapagos home!” She shouted, determined. “I’m getting my Pokémon back!”

The AIs merely gave her a cold unfeeling glare in response.

“‘Your’ Pokémon?” Sada questioned. “Don’t be selfish, child. Terapagos has lived for thousands of years before you were even born…”

“...And he shall live eons more after your passing.” Turo added “You are but a drop of sand among the hourglass of time.”

“You are destined to be forgotten with time, champion. A mere footnote in the grand history of the world. With our research, Terapagos will shape that history, bringing the past and future to our present.” They stated in unison.

Juliana put a hand to her belt and unleashed Koraidon from his Pokéball. The Pokémon stood before her, attentive and protective. Without hesitation, the rest of the group summoned a Pokémon each: Nemona’s Pawmot, Arven’s Mabostiff, Penny’s Sylveon, Carmine’s Sinistcha and Kieran’s Hydrapple. All stood at the ready, awaiting input from their trainers.

Juliana felt Nemona put a hand to her shoulder, releasing some of the tension she had. *We’ve got your back*, she seemed to say without a word.

“**Engaging protocol ‘Lost Paradise’**” the AIs said robotically. Terapagos cried out with a surplus of energy as the room shook and the Time Machine roared to life. The

crystals lining the walls pulsed frantically with a deep red. The gate on the ceiling opened slowly, revealing the swirling sea of stars of a rift through space and time.

The Professor's bodies were glitching with erratic movements as Terastal crystals leaked through joints, more notably around their face and eyes. Six Master Balls fell from the rift, landing into their hands.

"**At long last,"** they said in unison. "**Our dream is within reach… And you're not getting in our way!**"

Juliana stiffened at the sight. She had to be ready.

She assumed her opponents would be random Paradox Pokémon from the Past, like last time. She was wrong. Nothing could have prepared her for what she saw.

Sada's were the most familiar. They clearly exuded the same primal aura that was common to all past Paradox Pokémon, their sheer presence making her feel like a prey. She didn't recognize any of them though, they reminded her of the tales she saw in class about the three Legendary Beasts of Johto. But twisted.

'Suicune' had the body structure of a Tyrantrum, its elegant mane now wildly covering its whole body, adorned with orange spikes. Its maw held teeth sharp enough to tear through steel, its twin white ribbons now tails that swayed with trepidation like wuthering waves.

'Raikou' was a towering beast, a sauropod whose head reached half the height of the Time Machine itself. Its mane formed clouds around its mouth, as if electricity bolts would strike out of it. 'Entei' had the rectangular head of a Bastiodon, shining golden and with the addition of spikes as well as a sharp horn. Besides its crown, its front paws displayed razor sharp claws that looked like they could tear her body in half without any effort.

Turo's Pokémon were different, though. Unlike anything she had ever seen in her life. She guessed easily that these were the future versions of Paradox Pokémon, considering the man's whole vibe and parallel obsession from Sada's.

His trio resembled the three Swords of Justice that Juliana knew from one of Penny's TV shows, except straight out of a dystopic cyberpunk-ish nightmare. Their presence felt cold, calculated, devoid of any emotion.

Their skin was replaced with a metallic alloy, each limb connected with artificial joints that permitted them to rotate at 360 degrees. Their bodies were sleek, every inch with a design and purpose. Plates of coloured digital lights covered their limbs,

shaped in V-like patterns. Their colour matched their digital eyes as well as their horns, each of them shaped like weapons.

Yet, despite their robotic appearances, they were still unmistakingly truly alive and real Pokémon. It was uncanny to say the least, and put in question a lot of things about nature and existence itself.

“**Children,**” Sada called without recognition, “**Whoever you are, meet Walking Wake, Raging Bolt and Gouging Fire…**”

“**... As well as Iron Crown, Iron Boulder and Iron Leaves.**” Turo interjected. “**The inheritors of a distant future…**”

“**... and the power of an ancient past.**” Sada concluded.

“**Splendid, isn’t it?**” Both asked, standing firmly as Terapagos once again began thrashing with pain in its sleep, the energy from the machine feeding back into itself.

“Go to hell!” Juliana responded. Her heartbeat raced, cold sweat betraying her nervousness. She was about to throw a command to Koraidon when Penny pulled her arm, tapping at her phone rapidly.

“Don’t rush into this.” She admonished. “The Machine is malfunctioning, we need to shut it down.”

Juliana nodded, getting a grip on herself. “Okay - here’s the plan: defeat the Paradox Pokémon, get past the AIs, reach the control panel, shut down the machine, save Terapagos and maybe all of Paldea. Again.”

She looked at her friends. “All in?”

Nemona and Kieran nodded enthusiastically. Carmine glared daggers at the Professors, Penny frowned at her phone screen, but both gave a distracted thumb up. Arven talked without taking his eyes off the Professors, looking conflicted.

“... Of course, of course we are, buddy.”

Juliana turned back to the AIs, who were awaiting her first move. Terapagos was full on screaming now, his eyes open and filled with a white light.

She closed her eyes. Took a deep breath. She loosened the tight grip she had around Koraidon’s Pokéball.

And issued her first command of the battle.

“Koraidon!” She cried out. “Use *Collision Course*!”

Koraidon roared out as he launched himself through the opposing Walking Wake’s *Hydro Steam*. Juliana had to dodge out of the way of the remaining splashes of highly pressurized water that shot her way like bullets.

The Walking Wake intensified its attack under the AI Sada’s order, focusing it on Koraidon instead of letting it spread. As a result, the water stream gained enough power to stop and reverse Koraidon’s kinetic energy, and send him flying back to her feet. The Winged King landed smoothly, soaked but ready for his next move.

Juliana quickly surveyed the ever-changing battlefield, thinking about her next command.

Kieran and Penny had found themselves in the left corner of the room, Hydrapple and Raging Bolt engaging in a long distance shootout while Sylveon and Iron Leaves danced elegantly around each other, each trying and failing to land the finishing blow.

Carmine and Arven were to her right, Mabostiff tanking Iron Crown’s *Sacred Sword* with a pained expression but shooting back a *Payback* while Sinistcha distracted a surprisingly nimble Iron Boulder. When the Matcha Pokémon used their small size to scurry off between its legs, the Future Paradox Pokémon merely **flipped its own torso** to continue giving chase without losing momentum. It was terrifying.

Nemona was the closest to her, as Pawmot wrestled a charging Gouging Fire in his grasp, wincing as the Pokémon’s crown caught on fire. The Hands-On Pokémon held on despite the pain, the only thing standing between the fiery beast and its trainer.

Juliana thought for an instant that she had never seen this look on Nemona, totally unlike her battle face in their friendly competitions. Not only intensely focused on a battle, but struggling between the high adrenaline of a good challenge and the terror of losing. It wasn’t a good look on her, she decided.

She shook her head, focusing back on more urgent matters. The fight had already gone on for a few minutes, but it was already clear they were fighting a losing battle. The AIs were cold, but terrifyingly efficient. Each move, each attack was precisely calculated. Juliana and her friends couldn’t make an inch of progress towards the Time Machine, every possible move instantly matched with a Paradox Pokémon.

Koraidon yelped, breaking her concentration. Juliana looked in his direction and cursed under her breath - she had taken too long, Walking Wake was already back on the move. She winced at the look Al Sada gave her. No doubt, she had figured out she was trying to strategize, and of course she wouldn't let her.

"**Do you imagine you can best our wealth of data with your human brain?**" The AI taunted.

"**Children.**" Turo continued. "**Everything is proceeding within my expectations. I'm afraid the probability of you winning is zero.**"

These prewritten lines of dialogs resonated within her mind as she ordered a counter-attack against Walking Wake. Until it struck her.

They already had the whole battle figured out. These were AIs - they saw through every single possible outcome, and selected the one more favorable to them.

Simply put: they could not win.

Her world froze around her for a second.

They could not win.

She only did last time because luck was on her side, and because she had an ace hidden up her sleeve.

She stopped breathing.

Terapagos screamed in pain behind the Professors. Raging Bolt landed a paralysis on Sylveon, leaving the Pokémon unable to dodge the Iron Leaves' *Leaf Blade*. Penny shouted in shock, using her last potion, while Kieran covered her with a *Fickle Beam*. Its power wasn't enough, the Paradox Pokémon were closing in on them.

Carmine shouted a curse when the Iron Boulder pushed through a *Shadow Ball*, landing a clean hit on Sinistcha. The Pokémon knocked Mabostiff off-course as it was about to land a critical *Crunch*, leaving the both of them exposed to retaliation from Iron Crown.

Pawmot was unable to hold on to the Gouging Fire's burning mane any longer, getting thrown between the Paradox Pokémon and a panicking Nemona.

They could not win.

She needed an ace up her sleeve.

Juliana jumped back into action so fast her arm flared with pain. She put her bag to the ground, rummaging through its contents while Koraidon held its ground against Walking Wake. She needed something - *anything* to turn the situation around. To save her friends.

She couldn't give up now. She had to do it.

For them.

Searching her bag, she couldn't find anything useful right now. The rest of her team still wasn't battle ready, she didn't have any healing item left, only expired food, course papers from the Academy and various trinkets she collected from her adventure.

She went through every pocket, growing ever more desperate… Until she found something.

Her Tera Orb.

The item was cold and heavy in her hand.

The cause of so much strife, so much pain. The representation of her worst nightmares. Still here.

She didn't even realize it, but her whole body was shaking looking at the device. Her grip was too tight, her palm was hurting. She didn't care. She hated the thing.

She remembered, only days ago, when she couldn't look at it without being thrown into a hallucination of all her fears and repressed trauma. She had sworn not to use the item for a while. To avoid it, until she got better.

Then, she remembered Mewtwo's words: *"You must confront your fears, your past, child."*

She had thought he meant the room of the Time Machine. But now she saw.

She ripped her gaze away from the empty Tera Orb, and back towards the screaming form of Terapagos, about to unleash another wave of Terastal energy.

It was now or never. She knew what she had to do.

Juliana left her bag on the ground, taking the Tera Orb in her hand, and shot off running towards Koraidon as fast as possible.

“Cover for me!” She shouted to her friends without losing speed.

Nemona was about to retort when their eyes met. Her expression turned from a frown to a smirk. Her rival knew that look, she smiled at the glint in her eyes that she hadn’t seen for months. Juliana had a plan.

“Will do!” Nemona shouted back with a happy wave. “Be careful!”

Juliana simply nodded with a mirrored smile as she kept her pace. In a few strides, she was at Koraidon’s side.

“Help me up buddy!” She called.

Koraidon lowered himself, powerful muscles coiling, then thrust upwards with strength. His shoulder caught her foot just long enough to give her an explosive boost, launching high into the air. Far above a stunned Walking Wake.

Of course, the AIs saw her and rushed into action as soon as they realized her plan. Sada commanded Raging Bolt, who charged a *Thunder* to knock her out of the sky, while Turo instructed Iron Leaves and Iron Crown to forget their current target and intercept her.

Penny countered immediately however, her Sylveon knocking Iron Leaves off course and sending it crashing hard into Raging Bolt’s elongated neck, interrupting its concentration. She felt Kieran’s Hydrapple’s *Fickle Beam* shoot past her shoulder, barely avoiding her to hit Iron Crown back to the ground in a sizzling crater. It was a critical hit.

Juliana landed past Walking Wake with a roll, stumbling a bit but keeping up her course despite the pain in her legs. During her time in the air, the AIs had directed Iron Boulder and Gouging Fire to stand in her way. But before they could reach her, Pawmot and Sinitcha rushed past her. The former hit Iron Boulder with a *Nuzzle* and the latter shot thick sticky matcha at Gouging Fire’s paws, effectively trapping both Pokémon in place.

Juliana dashed past them, but grew worried when she heard Walking Wake barreling after her. And by the sound of it, he was way faster than her. When she risked a glance beyond her shoulder, she found the Pokémon’s maw much too close for her liking.

But before the Paradox Pokémon could get to her, it stopped with wide eyes. Behind it, Koraidon grabbed its twin tails with his claws, and with enough strength to crack

the ground beneath his feet, he pulled the Pokémon back and sent it flying into a wall.

She grinned and gave the Pokémon a thumbs up, continuing running.

Terapagos and the AIs were just in front of her now. If she could *just* keep this up-

The crater suddenly shook like never before. Terapagos was accumulating way, way too much Terastal energy.

He couldn't control himself anymore, she realized. And the surplus of energy **had** to go somewhere.

So, Terapagos screamed, and the crater shook.

The Professors didn't seem bothered. Juliana had to get there. Faster. She ignored the earthquake, ignored the protest of her knees, pushed past the falling debris and dust.

That was when her foot caught on something.

Was it a rock, a crystal, some piece of machine equipment, she couldn't know. But the result was the same: she was falling forward. She wasn't going to make it. She closed her eyes, bracing herself to smash on the cold, hard, ground.

But it never came.

A familiar weightless sensation surrounded her, like she was floating in space.

She dared to open her eyes. Juliana found herself surrounded by a familiar psychic energy, floating gently just above where she almost had fallen over. Without her even realizing it, the aura broke and she landed on her feet.

She looked back quickly at her friends and caught a glimpse of the one who helped her, floating high above the group.

Mewtwo had joined the fight, helping her.

**** Go.*** he instructed mentally, his eyes blinking white as he continued to use his power.

She nodded a quick thanks and sprinted forward, easily passing the surprised Professors who were still reeling in shock at the sudden appearance of another Legendary Pokémon.

As Juliana got closer to Terapagos however, it was getting harder and harder to move. The Terastal energy was fighting against her, it felt like trying to walk through a raging blizzard. She put a hand to her brow, trying to shield her eyes from the Pokémon's blinding light, while doing her best to ignore how much just **everything hurt**. Each step was heavier than the last one, her ears ringing with the cacophony of Terapagos' agony.

Two metallic hands shot to her shoulder, preventing her from moving. Sada and Turo stepped effortlessly through the Terastal storm, ignoring the phenomenon that was tearing their own bodies apart. Crystals grew quickly through their joints, their synthetic skins were pierced by sharp shards, revealing complex machinery beneath. Sada lost an eye, and Turo the front of his jaw. These nightmarish bots shouted in unison with incredible loudness and yet she could barely hear them through the storm.

"**STOP HERE, CHILD. THE TERASTAL STORM IS NOT SAFE. YOU WILL FALL HERE, WITHIN THIS GARDEN PARADISE. AND ACHIEVE NOTHING IN THE END.**"

"I DON'T CARE" she shouted back with determination, easily breaking out of their grasp. "I JUST WANT MY POKÉMON BACK!"

The AIs said nothing, their limbs unmoving, as she resumed walking past them, ignoring how the light left their eyes.

Terapagos screamed yet even louder somehow.

That was when she realized. He was dying.

She marched onward, ignoring the crystal shards cutting her skin and clothes, the numbness in her body, the weight of her legs. She kept moving.

Until she reached Terapagos.

The Pokémon didn't see her, couldn't perceive anything beyond pure pain and uncontrollable power. She tried putting a hand to his shell - and regretted immediately.

It **hurt** like hell.

The sensation was indescribable, somehow both impossibly burning and freezing at the same time. Like her whole limb was dissolving in real time.

So, no touching directly. It didn't even look like it had helped with anything.

She looked at the Tera Orb in her hand with her teeth clenched. This instrument of her nightmares was now her only hope.

She looked back at Terapagos. His gaze was so empty, yet overwhelmed, it hurt even more. She was losing him. Her own strengths were rapidly being drained, just standing here in this storm took everything she had left. And Arceus knew that wasn't much.

Without leaving herself time for further hesitation, she took the ball in her right hand, and pressed it on top of Terapagos' shell.

She screamed in pain as soon as it made contact. The sensation was just like before, barely softened by the presence of the Orb.

Manageable. It felt impossible, but it could not be. She bit her lower lip hard enough to bleed, ignoring the tears rolling down her face. She held on.

Slowly - way too slowly - the Tera Orb worked. The storm was growing in intensity, but Terapagos' screams began to soften. The excess power was absorbed back into the device.

Blinking through her tears, she saw the Terastal energy swirling all around them. Like the Universe itself was watching them. It was beautiful. It was impossibly painful. It was paradise. It was hell.

She saw colours she had never seen before, heard sounds she had never heard before. She saw through the ages. The birth of everything, and the end of everything. Everything died. Yet, everything lived. The song of life echoed both loud and quiet within her mind.

Through it all her body was collapsing upon itself. Every inch of her screamed in pain. But she held on, using her left arm to support her right one, pressing the Tera Orb to Terapagos. The Terastal energy was being absorbed by the Orb… But it wasn't enough. The process wasn't perfect. Some spilled.

Juliana watched in pure horror as shimmering crystals formed around the Orb and began to spread. Slowly. First to her fingers. Then her palm, and her whole hand. Her wrist was encased next, locked in place as Terastal surface *fused* with her skin. Then it continued to spread like an infection to her forearm, then her elbow, and finally seemed to stabilize at her upper arm.

The whole process was agony, impossibly painful and slow. Like a thousand needles were tearing apart every square inch of her skin, fusing it with a crystalline alloy that shimmered with an infinity of colours, of possibilities.

She couldn’t breathe. Her mind couldn’t help but drift to her nightmares, to the statue in the ruined lab. She couldn’t move.

Still, Juliana held strong through it all. With a mixture of shock, horror, mind-numbing pain and pure determination. She would save her Pokémon.

She didn’t realize when the Terastal storm disappeared, leaving her, Terapagos, and the lifeless bodies of the Professors’ AIs bare for all to see.

She didn’t notice when Terapagos stopped shining, looking at her with innocence and concern, all light drained out of its body and secured tight in the Tera Orb that fell from her palm.

She didn’t hear the panicked shouts of her friends when she collapsed to the ground.

The world turned dark. The night called to her, and for once, she willingly joined her embrace as pain and suffering gave place to nothingness.

Ch26 - A New Dawn

Consciousness came to her in blurry, dream-like waves. Flashes of vision, sounds and pain that just didn't make sense together.

One moment she was lying on a cold floor, familiar faces crowding her, the weight of Terapagos on her torso.

One moment she was carried through a metallic chamber that was quickly rising, a comforting warmth making her snuggle against whoever held her.

One moment her vision didn't work properly, but she couldn't contain a whimper as a deep agony seized her right arm. It felt **wrong**, somehow. Someone took her left hand. She focused on that sensation as the darkness consumed her once again.

One moment she was propped against a wall, agitated conversations in the background, while someone was whispering comforting words into her ears. She was pulled in an embrace, and drifted back to sleep.

Juliana only truly came back to the living the fifth time this happened.

It came slow, first with sound. People were talking in the distance, wind was blowing gently on grass, water was dripping from the ceiling, dropping with a steady rhythm in a pool of water. Various Pokémon were asleep: a snoring sound that she identified as Tinkaton's, a low deep rumble noise that sounded like Skeledirge's.

She felt good, warm. Snuggled tight on the grass among multiple other bodies.

She couldn't feel her right arm.

That realization felt wrong, painful. Her eyes shot full awake in panic as her breathing got quicker.

She was lying on grass in a cave. Brown boulders surrounded her, dimly lit by an opening in the distance. She recognized the place easily: the cave was situated at the top layers of Area Zero, the place where she met her very first wild Roaring Moon back then.

She was curled up against her full Pokémon Team. Skeledirge was snuggled against her, his warmth emanating like a low heater in the cold of the cave, one lazy eye open to watch her waking up. Tinkaton and Ogerpon were sleeping tight, the former snoring loudly while hugging her shoulder, the latter on her back with a drool coming out of her mouth as she rested against her left ankle. Clodsire was held comfortably

in her arms like an oversized plush. The weight of Terapagos on her torso indicated to her the small Pokémon was using her as a bed, recovering from his adventures.

At the entrance of the cave, Koraidon sat straight like an Arcanine statue, staring outside and keeping watch for the group. He hadn't noticed her awakening yet. Not too far away on his left, a giant boulder turned out to be the Titan Great Tusk in a deep slumber. On top of it, Roaring Moon was grooming his fur.

Juliana relaxed fully at the sight. She was with her team, safe. She looked at her arm.

The entire thing was scarred with crystals, shimmering in the dim light of the cave. It wasn't painful as of now, it just felt…

Numb.

Like her limb was dead weight. She had trouble moving it, her muscles slow like it was under water. But it wasn't painful. It wasn't anything actually. She just couldn't feel it, like it was a foreign object.

It was difficult to just move her fingers. She tried to hold a Pokéball in her hand, gently shifting Clodsire under her left arm. She couldn't grasp it correctly, it landed in the grass with a soft thump.

She stared at it for a few minutes, reflecting on all the choices, the strife that led to this. On the Terastal storm she faced with Terapagos. The scarring felt wrong. And yet, appropriate. The logical ending point of all of her mistakes, of all her sacrifices. If this was the price to pay for choosing to preserve instead of conquer, then so be it. In time, she would make peace with it.

She pushed herself off the ground, settling into a cross-legged position. Clodsire rolled on to her lap, joining an undisturbed Terapagos.

If the change was definitive, she reflected as she used her left hand to scratch Skeledirge's back while supporting her head with her right fist in a thinking position, then she'd work it out.

Sure, it was stressful and deeply disturbing - her arm didn't work anymore. How could she continue her Champion duties? What would she say to Mom? What if it wasn't the end of it, what if it spread to other parts of her body?

She lied back down, staring with a neutral expression at the ceiling, without breaking the scratches. Her crystal arm barely visible in the grass. Heavy.

Why did it have to remind her so much of her nightmares? Would she ever be able to look at it without thinking back to the statue in the lab? To the collapsing form of the AIs, torn apart by the storm? To her own surreal experience, to the agony she endured?

She sighed, closing her eyes. For now, surrounded by her family, she couldn't get herself to worry too much. She physically couldn't get worked up right now, she was too comfortable and tired for it. Her right hand shimmered in the dim spotlight, and for once, she allowed herself to appreciate its strange, eerie beauty.

It seemed her agitation had not gone unnoticed however, as she heard a familiar yelp at the entrance of the cave. She sat up, eyes widening as Koraidon came barreling toward her. He pushed her right back to the ground, somehow without disturbing the other sleeping Pokémon, and licked her face while happily wagging his tail.

"Haha- gross!" She exclaimed with a smile, trying and failing to roll out of his grip without disturbing her team. "Koraidon, stop! Stop it! I'm happy to see you too bud!"

The commotion attracted more people to the cave as Koraidon slowly started to back off, proud of himself. But not before a flash briefly illuminated the room.

"That's adorable." Penny cooed, phone in hand. "This is going into the album!"

"Send the picture to the group chat!" Arven asked with a bright grin. The traitor. "I'm sure the others want it too!"

"You are horrible people, the lot of you." Juliana lamented as she sat back up, a hand to her brow in mock despair. "Shame on you for exploiting me in my time of woe."

"It's payback." Penny stated matter-of-factly. "For all the fright you gave us."

Juliana sighed dramatically, shrugging her shoulders and shaking her head in resignation. "Well, I guess I owe you as much then. Go on, rejoice at my misery, fiends and friends."

Behind the two *traitors*, Clavell made his presence known by clearing his throat. He was looking at the group with what could only be described as a mixture of relief and fondness, yet still somehow professional. Another man was standing beside him, a warm smile and comforting confidence in his eyes. He was wearing a brown trenchcoat over a formal suit.

Her focus went back to Clavell as the Director kneeled to her level.

“How are you feeling, Juliana?” He asked. Gentle. Careful. Caring. For the first time, she didn’t feel like she was a broken thing for him to fix when he asked that question.

She swallowed the lump in her throat. “Better.” She answered honestly. “It- it doesn’t hurt.” She gestured to her arm. “It… it isn’t anything actually. It’s numb. I don’t- I don’t…” Her breathing grew faster as her crystal hand tensed up.

The Director put a comforting hand to her right shoulder, a gentle smile on his face. He looked back to the other man who nodded back, seemingly confirming something they discussed earlier with a glance. The man exited the cave in silence, a hand rubbing his chin.

When Clavell looked back at her, Juliana thought she had never seen the man look so old before.

“... It’s okay, Juliana.” He said, swallowing his own emotions. “We’ll take care of it.”

She nodded, not noticing how her eyes were starting to get wet. Then she paused- a thought occurred to her.

“Say, Clavell, if you’re here then, does that mean that Team-”

“JULIANA!” A familiar shout interrupted her, echoing through the cave.

She turned towards the entrance. Nemona was standing there, panting heavily with her hand on her knees like she had run all the way here from the Academy.

“Nemo-” Juliana didn’t have time to finish her sentence as Nemona recovered in record time and ran towards her at astonishing speed. The girl launched like a bullet and crashed into her with a hug that sent the both of them barreling on the floor. Somehow, the Pokémon around them were still unbothered and merely shifted to compensate for this new arrival.

“DON’T-” She began shouting, stopping to wipe her eyes with her forearm before taking her back into a Bewear hug.“Don’t… Don’t ever do that again Jules. I was so scared. Please.”

Juliana tensed at the memory. The reminder of her right arm, hanging awkwardly limp on her side while she did her best to reciprocate the hug with her left.

She closed her eyes and let go of the tension with a sigh. She knew the girl didn’t disagree with her plan back there, but she still hated that she got hurt.

“... I promise, ‘Mona. I’ll take better care.”

“Good!” Nemona pulled back, still holding her. She looked at her directly in the eyes, fierce determination behind unshed tears and a genuine smile on her face. “‘Cause I need my greatest rival to be at her best, you know!”

“Besides,” Penny added. “We’re not leaving you alone even for a second during the coming months. You’re like a toddler with a death wish, I swear. Every time we turn our heads you end up even worse than before somehow.”

“You’re stuck with us, Little Buddy!” Arven concluded with a smile. “Cheer up, at least you’ll be eating good food.”

“Well, I can’t argue with that.” She responded with an exaggerated shrug as Nemona sat next to her, an arm on her shoulders. “Thanks guys. Really. I love you all.”

“We love you too, dumb-dumb.” Nemona answered easily, poking her cheek with a grin.

They stayed like this for some time, chatting, joking and laughing together comfortably, sitting among their Pokémon. For a moment, every worry, every trial she had faced, was forgotten. Even Clavell joined in after a while, clearly proud of the group of children he had the honor of calling his students.

Eventually, the conversation died down. As they enjoyed the quiet together, Juliana lied on her back, staring at the cave ceiling.

So much had happened in the last few hours, it felt kind of overwhelming now. She had raided Team Rocket Hideout, faced Giovanni, Mewtwo, Briar. The AI Professors.

They had died again. In a horrifying way.

It felt like days since she last saw any kind of natural light. The moon, the stars, the sun.

Despite her comfort, she was growing sick looking at that rocky ceiling. She needed air.

“Hey, is it- is it okay if we go out for a bit?” She asked tentatively.

“Of course Jules!” Nemona bounced to her feet, gently and slowly helping her up. Juliana winced when her feet touched the ground. She hadn’t realize how badly injured she was. Luckily, Nemona was there to catch her, putting an arm around her torso while Juliana threw her own over her shoulder. Together, they slowly made

their way out of the cave, followed by Penny, Arven, Clavell and a good chunk of her team.

The fresh air hit Juliana in an instant. It was colder outside, but *Arceus* did it feel good. Granted, they were still in the crater. But as of now, things were surprisingly peaceful.

It was early morning, and for once, no clouds covered the Great Crater of Paldea. A clear light blue sky greeted her, the sun shining on her skin like an old friend. Her right arm caught the reflections and shimmered with a thousand colours against the shadows of the nearby trees. Fresh wind brushed the plains of the highest level of Area Zero, small Pokémon curiously standing a respectable distance away.

People were scattered just about everywhere. Team Star students celebrating, conversing, sleeping. The Starmobiles were lined up against a wall, each looking worse for the wear, various students and Star Bosses investigating the damage. Among them, several adults wearing uniforms with badges were chatting amicably, taking care of injured people and Pokémon, and surveying the environment. One of them had thrown a sheet over two sleeping teenagers - she recognized Kieran and Carmine, propped against one another.

Next to the cave entrance, the man in a brown coat from the cave was chatting with two other people. Rika and Geeta.

Her stomach dropped. She had forgotten about La Primera. For a second she was back in Clavell's office, the League president relieving her of her functions while siding with Giovanni.

She shook her head. The man had said it himself, she had been manipulated. She couldn't blame her. Plus, by the way the woman looked at her, it was clear she was now consumed by guilt and regret.

The three of them noticed her when she left the cave. The man made his way towards her with a quick pace as Rika flashed her a quick wave before whispering something to Geeta.

She braced herself when he reached her. He spoke first, with a gruff but friendly voice, marked by a foreign accent.

"Ah, you must be Juliana, mustn't you?" He reached with his left hand and a confident smirk.

She shook his hand, confused but appreciative that the man had taken into account her newfound disability. "Y-Yeah, that's me. And you are…?"

“My code name is Looker.” He answered quickly. “I am a globe-trotting elite of the International Police. Your friend at the local League, Rika, called us in. We arrived as soon as she informed us of the situation.”

Juliana couldn’t help but glance at Rika. Clavell sensed her hesitation. No one could blame her for having trust issues after all that happened.

“It’s true”, the Director provided. “Rika gave me his contact, and I personally provided him with information. They helped turn the tides of the battle against Team Rainbow Rocket, as well as containing the more dangerous Paradox Pokémon to Area Zero.”

Juliana felt relieved at that. If Clavell trusted the man and his story, then she could too. Looker simply nodded to the older man. “*Merci*, Director Clavell.” He looked back at her.

“Rest assured that we will have everything taken care of. Giovanni and most of Team Rainbow Rocket have been taken into custody. Miss Briar has also been arrested and placed in medical care. As for the AI Professors your friends testified about…”

He closed his eyes, crossed his arms and shaked his head in sorrow.

“...I’m sorry, but there wasn’t anything we could do about them. Their robotic body had suffered irreversible damage when we got there, and slowly phased out of this reality.”

Juliana knew, deep down, this would be coming. Her hand still shook. Her head still throbbed in pain. The shock still came. She had failed to save the Professor. **Again**.

Arven put a gentle hand to her shoulder, giving her a sorrowful but hopeful look.

“It’s okay, bud’. I’m glad, at least, I was able to see them one more time. Even though this wasn’t them.”

She took a deep breath.

She looked back to Looker, the man clearly awaiting her questions. She switched back to ‘serious mode’ without even realizing it, her glare not one of a broken child but of a Champion.

“What about the Time Machine? Mewtwo? Team Rocket’s experiments? The other Paradox Pokémon? And Terapagos?”

The man had an easy smile, like he was prepared for the bombardment of questions. He gestured a lot with his hands as he talked.

“The Time Machine is shut down for good. Its key is in our custody, found with Miss Briar’s possessions, and the whole thing seems to have broken down after the whole affair with Terapagos. Speaking of which, your Pokémon will be fine. He, along with the rest of your team, will just need a few weeks of rest. That’s all.”

She felt immense relief, tension leaving her body all at once, the champion facade breaking instantly. She couldn’t help but have a dumb smile on her face, a nervous laugh escaping her. That was such good news, it washed away her worst fears. Koraidon and Terapagos’ health after the experiments was her biggest concern, especially seeing firsthand the agony they suffered. She would make sure they’d rest. All her team.

On top of that, the Time Machine was **done**. It would never come back to haunt her again. She didn’t have to deal with the Scarlet Book anymore.

All around good news. She noticed that Looker had paused to let her take it all in. She appreciated even more how considerate the man could be, gesturing to him to go on.

“As for the Rocket’s experiments, we will cooperate with the Paldean League to ensure the health and safety of every Pokémon affected.” He gestured towards Rika and Geeta. “We already are in contact with the best of the bests, like Alola’s Aether Organization.”

Juliana nodded. The man continued. “As for your last question, well…”

He sighed.

“I haven’t met the Pokémon your friends described. It seems he saved you down there, stabilized your condition somehow, and vanished. We weren’t able to find him, track him down or talk to him.”

That… wasn’t surprising, Juliana thought, considering what she knew of the Pokémon. She was deeply grateful toward him, but it made sense he would just vanish as soon as possible to avoid the police.

“And-” She struggled to keep her voice from shaking. *Keep it together*, she thought to herself as she clenched Nemona’s hand with an iron grip to ground herself. She swallowed a lump. “A-about my condition?”

“Ah.” Looker’s eyes filled with sympathy and sadness. “According to our medics, it looks about as stable as it can be. You shouldn’t be feeling anything in there for a while - nerves are frozen - but you can still move your arm around, somehow. The Terastal won’t spread further, if that is what you were worried about.”

Juliana let out another sigh of relief.

Looker kneeled, a gentle look in his eyes as he put a hand on her shoulder.

“*Ma fille*, I don’t know if you will ever gain back the use of your arm again. I can’t promise that. But I will ensure you will get in contact with the best experts there are.”

She was speechless. Incredibly thankful, but speechless. Without moving, he fished a card from his pocket and gave it to her.

“Here is my contact info. If you ever need anything, call me. I’ll keep in touch.”

A woman with purple hair and a classy black suit approached them and shouted at Looker. The man yelled “Coming, Boss!” and got back up, starting to follow her.

“Wait!” Juliana called suddenly.

The man stopped, looking at her over his shoulder with a quizzical look.

“Why- why are you doing this?” She asked. “You don’t even know me. Why go to all this length to help me?”

He just smirked, fondness in his eyes.

“I’ve met my fair share of child prodigies and Champions over the years.” He said. “Let’s just say, you remind me of some of them.”

Without another word, he turned his back, hands in his coat pockets, and walked towards the woman.

Juliana looked back to the card in her hand. It was simple, just a phone number written on a piece of paper. She shoved it in her left pocket.

She stood there for a while, unmoving, watching the wind brushing the grass.

Not thinking, not working herself up over some philosophical question about power, not retracing the wrongs and rights of her journey, not figuring out her next move.

Just, existing. Allowing herself to empty her mind, and bask in the morning sun.

Her friends' discussion turned into background noise, as her Pokémon surrounded her. Skeledirge had stayed sleeping soundly in the cave with Terapagos hunched over him and Clodsire serving as a cushion, but the others had followed her out. Koraidon was sitting next to her, observing silently as Ogerpon and Tinkaton were play-chasing each other in an elaborate game of tag.

"Juliana?"

Her peace and quiet was interrupted when someone called her name tentatively. It was a familiar voice, but filled with emotions that didn't match it. It was raw, vulnerable. She turned to see Geeta, standing there, her eyes studying her every wound. Her arm.

La Primera had her usual professional, unreadable posture. The mask was on, her hands crossed behind her back. But her face… It was unlike the ever cold and intimating woman she had always known. Geeta looked conflicted, but also tired. There were bags under her eyes she never noticed, her complexion a bit paler than usual. She stared at everything but Juliana, evading her glare.

"... Yes?" She enquired, harsher than she intended.

Geeta was nervous, hands unseen but clearly fidgeting. "I… wanted to apologize. For everything."

She felt as if the world had gone still. Geeta was always so self-assured, so composed - she'd never have imagined hearing these words coming from her of all people.

"I was manipulated by that man using an illicit substance," the woman continued, unaware of her shock, "but I am not exempt from blame."

Geeta closed her eyes and took a deep breath.

"The formula he used only made me more complacent, easier to manipulate for him. But I still should have believed you."

She opened her eyes again, this time fiercely determined, a hand on her heart.

"I don't expect forgiveness, but I will work tirelessly to earn back your trust, if you allow me to."

Juliana eased up. She didn't know if she could either. But rebuilding trust? She could make this work. She wanted to. She nodded with a tired smile.

“Thanks, Boss. I- I really appreciate that.”

Geeta eased up as well, deep relief unwinding her tight posture in an instant. She had a bright smile on her face that reached her eyes. “No. Thank you, Juliana.”

Then again, nervousness creeped up, as she pulled her other hand from her back. She was holding black gloves in it. League gloves. The woman seemed tense as she held them to her.

“By decree of the League, you are hereby restored to your previous rank and duties. If you would accept, I would be truly honored to work again with you, Juliana. After a two month rest period, of course.”

Juliana was, for the second time today, speechless. She took the gloves from Geeta with a mixture of shock, awe and uncertainty. She stared at them for what felt like an eternity, pondering her options, before turning back to the League president with a grateful, bright smile.

“Of course I accept, Boss. You won’t get rid of me that easily! Just… please tell me you’re not bringing back the *mandatory* karaoke nights for ‘team spirit’.”

“Oh, woe is me!” Another voice lamented dramatically, growing closer. “And here I thought you loved my beautiful singing voice!”

Rika stepped next to Geeta, waving lazily two fingers.

“Hey, kiddo.”

“Rika!” She exclaimed with bright eyes. The secretary kneeled and pulled her into a tight hug.

“I’m glad you’re okay, kid.” She said when she pulled back. “You had me worried sick after the stunt you pulled.”

Her stern expression melted with fondness as she ruffled her hair. “Come back anytime. Poppy would love to see you again. Hassan will probably drown in tears. Even Larry misses you, you know?”

She pulled her in one last embrace before getting back up, taking Geeta by the wrist.

“We have work to do, but enjoy yourself kiddo!” Rika called back as La Primera waved Juliana goodbye with a light blush on her cheeks. “Take care, spend time with your friends, rest. And I mean it this time.”

With one last wave, she pulled Geeta with her and walked off in the shadow of a tree.

She yelped in surprise when an arm wrapped around her shoulders, and immediately her face reddened. With everything that happened, she had forgotten her friends were still here.

“I don’t know about you,” Nemona exclaimed from her shoulder, “but I’m famished!”

She turned her head to the rest of the group. “Hey Arven!” She called. “You got any sandwiches left?”

Arven shook his head, already unfolding a picnic table from his bag. “Your metabolism is a monster. Your stomach is a black hole, you know that!? You’re as bad as Koraidon, I swear.” He complained loudly while taking out multiple ingredients.

Koraidon himself was saliving, tongue out at the thought of sandwiches. The mention of his name brought him back to reality, with a confused “Agias?”

Juliana smiled despite herself while Nemona doubled up in laughter. She moved to go and help Arven unpack, but was immediately shooed away.

“Nope! Shoo!” He exclaimed. “You’re not doing everything! Park your butt in the grass somewhere young lady, you’re resting!”

He turned towards Penny, already sitting in a chair next to the table and scrolling on her phone. “Hey, can you search for any recipe with these ingredients? Nemona, I’ll need a steady hand to cut the tomatoes!”

Nemona gently patted her head as she walked by, already seizing a knife and getting to work, tongue out. Juliana pouted and went to sit in the grass, next to Koraidon and Clavell, who were both watching over the group.

“Can you believe that!?” She complained, lying down with arms and legs spread wide.

Clavell responded with a barely hidden smile. “Yes, what tragedy you face, forced to do nothing while your loved ones take care of you.”

“Exactly,” she crossed her arms with mock-offense, unable to contain a bright smile on her own face. “A bunch of traitors, I tell you.”

Clavell shook his head with a chuckle.

“As much as I would like a piece of that sandwich,” he said, “I believe I’m needed elsewhere. Rest well, Juliana.”

She sat up, waving him off. “Later Clive! I’ll make sure to bring you something!"

The old man walked off towards a group of Team Star students, laughing and conversing amiably.

Juliana sighed, lying back down.

The air was still fresh on her skin, the fading morning dew clinging to her crystalline arm.

It felt good.

Her friends chattered in the distance, Nemona arguing with Arven over ‘Which Paradox Pokémon is the strongest’ while Penny interjected occasionally, scrolling her phone with a smile. Carmine and Kieran had woken up and joined them, Carmine loudly yawning with her elbow on the table as Kieran picked up a knife and helped prepping the meal.

The sunlight was warm, a contrast to the cool wind brushing her clothes.

She felt good.

Koraidon sat next to her, grooming his scales. Tinkaton and Ogerpon had stopped their game, taking a break by sitting under a tree. Tinkaton in particular was glaring at a Corviknight flying in the distance like it owed her money.

Skeledirge walked out of the cave she woke up from, a deep grumble as he lay back down next to her and closed his eyes under the light of the sun. On his back where, somehow piled up on top of one another, Clodsire and Terapagos. Clodsire had a bright smile as he snorted peacefully. Terapagos opened his eyes with protest at the sudden light, yawning adorably.

Juliana chuckled, scratching the poor baby’s head with her left hand without getting up from her sprawling position. Terapagos closed back his eyes, content at the sudden attention, and went back to sleep.

She sighed fondly. She loved them. And now, laying down in the grass, surrounded by that same love, it felt good. For the first time in months, she genuinely felt good.

She pondered, staring at the sky.

What next?

She had worked so hard to get here. Had so many crises, She never got around to thinking about what to do when all that would be over.

She closed her eyes.

For now, she wouldn’t worry about that.

For now, she’d rest.

For now, she’d accept that the future was out of her control.

She would sleep. And for the first time in months, she didn’t worry about past failures or possible nightmares.

She wasn’t always like this. She had changed.

But she wasn’t scared anymore.

And as she drifted to sleep, Juliana allowed herself to let go of her guilt, even for a moment, under the bright sun of Paldea.

Ch27 - Epilogue

“Are you okay, Jules?”

Juliana jumped suddenly at the question, too deep in thought to have noticed Nemona having sat right next to her, a hand over her right shoulder. The bright girl looked at her carefully, obviously worried over her jumpiness.

They were sitting next to Rika’s office, at the League HQ, waiting for her appointment. It was just her, Nemona and Koraidon today.

“Y-yeah ‘Mona! I- I’m fine, don’t worry.” She waved her off with a smile.

Nemona gave her *the look*. The one with a raised eyebrow that she had learned from Penny, the one Juliana received when she lied about her own well-being. She wished she didn’t see it as much as she did… But old tendencies die hard.

Juliana sighed, closing her eyes and letting her head fall as she rubbed her crystal hand nervously.

“I’m… nervous.” She confessed. “It’s been a long time.”

“Cheer up!” Nemona answered with a bright smile while putting her hand on top of hers. “It will be fine. Think of it as a chance to catch up!”

“Agias!” Koraidon put his head in her lap, looking for attention. Her and Nemona chuckled as they petted the Paradox Pokémon.

“Juliana?” Rika stepped out of her office, holding the door open, her glasses on with an amused look on her face. “Come in, please.”

Juliana nodded wordlessly, getting up from her seat and walking towards her with Koraidon in toe.

“Oh! Don’t forget Jules!” Nemona called, waving from her seat. “Meet me at the Academy for our battle when you’re done!”

Juliana grinned fondly at her rival’s antics. “You’re on!” She called back, before stepping into Rika’s office.

The place was familiar, with a homely scent and a cozy lighting. It was still early in the morning, a bright sun visible through the windows on the right wall. Rika had already sat back at her desk, searching for a paper in her drawers. She found it just

as Juliana closed the doors and sat in the chair in front of her, Koraidon lying on the floor next to her.

“So, it’s been a long time, kiddo.” Rika said, examining her with a grin.

Juliana gulped. It had been.

After Area Zero, a lot had happened to her. One of the new things in her life had been therapy.

She had been hesitant at first, but she wanted to give it a shot. And all of her friends and family had *begged* her to at least try it. She would have been more offended if she didn’t see their point, considering the few months beforehand.

As it turned out, Rika had a psychology diploma - a shift in her studies when she was younger before reorienting and ultimately becoming the League secretary and member of the Elite 4 she knew today. Though, surprisingly enough, she was actually the school therapist.

So, when Juliana eventually caved and wanted to give it a try, Rika had been ecstatic.

Yet, Juliana felt guilty. She had only been able to lock a couple sessions with Rika before her own plans and Rika’s schedule interfered too much with one another.

“Yeah, it’s been.” She answered, swallowing the lump in her throat.

Rika gave her an easy smile. “Let’s catch up then! What have you been doing?”

“I’ve been travelling, mostly!” She answered, smiling fondly at the memories. “Mom took me back to Galar along with Nemona, Arven and Penny. We visited my family, did some tourism in the region, it was really fun.”

She snickered. “We met Penny’s family as well. They’re really nice! Nemona found out her dad used to be a gym leader before retiring - and you know how she is. It was like, 11pm, we were playing Uno around the table, and she just got up and slammed her hands to the table. Demanded a battle here and there.”

Rika chuckled at the image. “Thankfully, Mister Peony himself is quite the character.” Juliana continued. “So, they just ran outside and battled. Nemona won, obviously, but the man taunted that she wouldn’t have been this lucky if Dynamax was in play. It took me and Arven physically holding her back to prevent her from running headfirst into a stadium, while Penny basically grounded her own dad.”

Rika grinned. “Sounds like them.” She admitted. “And after that?”

Juliana recounted her subsequent travels: going back to Kitakami, reuniting with Kieran and Carmen. Bringing the whole group to the Blueberry Academy, with Nemona instantly challenging the entire BB League at once. Visiting other regions together: Kalos, Unova, and even Alola.

“... So yeah, I’ve been busy.” Juliana chuckled as she finished, settling back into her seat.

“I can see that!” Rika answered, writing something down on her notepad. “And I’m sorry for the scheduling issues, my own agenda has been a pain recently. But it’s all been cleared up, so please, call anytime kiddo.”

Juliana nodded wordlessly as Rika put down her pen and hunched over her desk with *the pose*. The one from her League interview, with her elbows on the desk and hands crossed in front of her face.

“So.” She paused. “I imagine the date of this appointment isn’t a coincidence.”

Juliana shivered at that. Of course she’d had to talk about it, despite how much she dreaded this subject.

“Yeah. I- it’s been-” She took a pause, breathing deeply to calm the shakiness of her voice. “As of today, it’s been a full year since Area Zero. A year since…”

She looked away, rubbing her crystal arm mechanically.

The silence was heavy. Rika didn’t move for what felt like hours, studying her.

Her voice eventually broke it, gentle. “How do you feel about that?”

Juliana thought about it - *really* thought about it for a moment. “... Bad.” She responded. “I haven’t- I- I- I’m not…”

Koraidon sensed her distress and emitted a low purr while brushing her left hand with his head, grounding her. Rika reached over the desk and took her right in hers.

“It’s okay, kiddo.” She said with a reassuring smile. “Take your time.”

Juliana nodded, her throat closed off. After a few minutes of collecting her thoughts, she eventually felt good enough to continue.

“... Nemona didn’t notice the date for the moment. I feel bad for not telling her. But- I don’t want to worry her even more than I already did. I’ve had a lot of good days recently. I didn’t want to break that streak.”

Rika nodded, scratching something on her clipboard. “You talked about ‘good days’ there. I assume that means there are bad days as well?”

Juliana nodded, stretching Koraidon’s head. His presence made her feel stronger than she was.

“... Yeah.” She answered honestly. “Everything after that event has been a succession of good and bad days. Sometimes all I have is bad days. Then I feel fine for a while. It- it doesn’t really make sense.” She laughed nervously.

Rika shrugged. “I think it does, don’t worry.” She hit her pen on the clipboard rhythmically, thinking. “Can I ask you to describe a bad day to me, if you don’t mind?”

“I feel like shit.” She answered immediately. “That’s a given. But mostly… I don’t really know, actually. It depends. Sometimes I wake up and feel bad for the entire day, going through the motions without even being entirely there, like someone else is piloting my body for me.” She gulped, stopping her scratches to rub her right arm.

“Sometimes I feel fine for the entire day and then, boom. Either something happens, either I hear something that reminds me of it, but I find myself back at the crater. I feel weak. Giovanni is telling me how much of a coward I am. I see that dead man, trapped in crystals in that lab. Geeta is demoting me. I’m flying with Koraidon, and get knocked out of the sky, falling down.”

She didn’t even notice when tears started leaving her eyes. She wanted to stop there - but she couldn’t. She forced her next words out of her throat.

“I fail to prevent Briar from activating the Time Machine. I lose again to Giovanni, he uses Mewtwo against me. I see the AIs in that Terastal storm, ripped apart to bits as they reach for my neck. I can’t breathe. Or- or… I use the Tera Orb to save Terapagos. This one is the worst, ‘cause I feel the pain all over again in my arm. Even though I can’t, even though it’s not real.”

She sighed, brushing away her tears with her sleeve. “... It’s always one of those, or sometimes multiple combined. These… Visions? Panic Attacks? They happen at random. And they’re overwhelming sometimes. I don’t get them as much anymore anyway, it was mostly during the months directly after. But it still happens from time to time. And I still have nightmares, sometimes.”

She paused. “I’ve- I’ve talked about it with the others already. They’ve been good. Really. Ever since Area Zero - I don’t know how they’ve done it - they have this *system* where one of them is always with me at all times. I’ve never been on my own for more than a few minutes at a time since then.”

Juliana laughed humourlessly. “I’ve not slept alone until then either. It doesn’t always prevent the bad dreams… But it helps. Really.”

She stared into the distance, still painfully aware of Rika’s scrutiny. It felt incredibly good to say all that out loud. But she couldn’t shake the uneasiness. “That’s why I… I feel really bad about not telling it to Nemona today. They’ve been really comprehensive with everything. Even calling me out on my bad behaviours. So, they want to know when I’m having a good or a bad day. I- I don’t know.”

“What-” She gulped. “What do you think?” she asked, tentatively.

“I think you should tell her, kiddo.” Rika said with finality, stopping her writing to look her in the eyes. “She loves you. We all do. You not feeling too well on the anniversary of one of the most traumatic events of your life isn’t going to change that. You’re allowed to feel bad, y’know?”

Juliana considered and nodded. “... Yeah. You’re right. And, you know… Despite what I’ve said, I **have** been getting better lately. Really.”

“Oh?” Rika raised an eyebrow. “How so?”

“I…” Juliana cleared her throat. “Well, just as I said earlier. I’ve had a lot of good days lately. Days where all these worries don’t cross my mind, where I genuinely feel good. Where I can look back at all that I’ve done and be proud. Where I don’t feel regret for the past, but only love for my friends, family and Pokémon. Now, these days, they outnumber the bad ones.”

She smiled, despite herself. “I’ve been really… confronting, stuff. Y’know, stuff that I’ve avoided in the past. Opening up and talking to my friends. The whole ordeal with Kieran before everything happened, or my first battle with the Professor in the Crater. It’s been helping, really. Even my… troubles with Terastallization. I mean, with this arm, I kind of had to.” She slowly waved her right hand.

“And- and I don’t wake up screaming in terror every night anymore. I can actually rest, pace myself and feel like I don’t have to carry the burden of the whole region on my back. Letting go and accepting that I can’t control everything.”

“Agias!” Koraidon agreed, sitting up next to her with a smile.

“Yeah, and he’s been helping too.” She cooed the Pokémon.

She giggled at Rika’s raised eyebrow.

“Koraidon basically became my emotional support Pokémon.” She explained, giving pats to the Pokémon. “Like, officially. Geeta arranged for it and Larry did the paperwork while you were working overseas. He rides with me on the plane and all. Makes for one hell of a discussion with my neighbour and her Skitty.”

Rika laughed at that. “That’s amazing!” She exclaimed. “What does he do, exactly?”

Juliana pondered while still scratching Koraidon’s head. “He’s a reassuring presence, mostly. He responds well to my emotions and asks for scratches. He’s… good at grounding me back to reality whenever I lose myself.”

She sighed. “More importantly, he’s awfully perceptive - sometimes to a fault. Whenever I put on the ‘Champion mask’ and shove down all the bad feelings, he sees right through it. I’ve had a meeting with Geeta end this way actually, I felt nervous, so the big guy decided to jump on my lap and licking my face. It was embarrassing.”

Rika laughed loudly, picturing the scene. “The best thing is,” Juliana continued, “He’s strong. So, whenever I’m out and not feeling good, he hangs back in battle form and intimidates any would-be journalist that looks for a good story. One time, there was this crowd in Unova, and I started feeling bad. So, he just scooped me up in his arms, jumped to the facade of a building, and put me down on the rooftop. I had trouble explaining myself to the police after that." She chuckled.

Rika whistled, taking notes. “I can imagine!”

“So yeah,” Juliana said. “He helped.”

She paused for a moment, unsure how to continue. She slowly released the tension in her body as she thought for a while, taking in the weight lifted from her chest after her confessions.

She watched through the window as Vivillons twirled about, flying through the air together. On the ground, baby Mausholds ran from patch of grass to patch of grass under the supervision of their parents.

“And…” She turned back to Rika, the woman currently pointing to her right arm with her pencil. “What about that? How has it been going?”

Juliana took her crystal arm with her left. A reflex, as if to hide it from view. “I’ve been… getting used to it.” She answered truthfully.

By the way Rika looked at her, she guessed her answer wasn’t enough.

“I’ve already met with every expert Looker could give me the contact to, and nothing can be done. I’m stuck like this. So, I’ve been getting used to it. It’s not… *as* bad as it looks, truthfully. I can still move my arm around. It’s just… slow, uncoordinated. Numb. I can’t feel a thing in there.”

She sighed. “It’s been hard for a while. I’m right-handed, so I’ve had to adjust to a lot of things in my day-to-day life. But the others are helping with that. At least, it’s been confirmed to be harmless.”

“... So,” Rika was still writing in her notes as she spoke. “You’re accepting it?”

Juliana looked out the window, shrugging. “Yeah, basically. I’ve… made my peace with it. It’s been hard. And it hurt. Still does from time to time. But, I’ve made my choice, you know? I don’t regret doing what I did, I’ve saved my family. If that’s the price I have to pay, so be it.”

“... I see.” Rika said. Juliana turned back to her. She had an unreadable expression on her face. “That’s very mature of you, Juliana. I’m proud. But it’s also okay to **not** be okay with it, you know?”

Juliana flushed at the unexpected compliment, but nodded anyway. “Y-yeah. Thanks.”

Rika looked through her notes. “Oh, yes- you’ve mentioned Looker? I take it that you stayed in contact after everything?”

“Yes!” Juliana answered, smiling. “Yes we did. Looker has been… really helpful. On top of the experts he recommended to me, he also gave me a tour to Aether Paradise when we were in Alola. When- when Giovanni was arrested, his Pokémon team was taken there for rehabilitation. To be taught how to live as Pokémon, not weapons.”

She looked back to these days with a bright grin. “During our stay in the region, I kept myself busy thanks to him. Interacting with the people there, and helping them with the Pokémon. It’s been a great experience, and I think it helped a lot with getting closure on all of this.”

She shook her head, coming back to reality. “On top of that, it turned out he gave my contact to a lot of other people he knew. Other champions in other regions, who

faced similar difficulties around my age. I've been able to meet them, talk with them, I'm even lucky enough to call some of them my friends. It's been deeply helpful."

She chuckled at a memory in particular. "Deeply strange at first too. You've never had THE Cynthia of all people show up all of the sudden at your vacation home in Unova. I swear, my heart was beating so fast - I thought I was going to die. I think I scared the woman to death with how pale I looked, she must have thought I was going to pass out."

They laughed together at the anecdote.

The rest of the appointment went fast- too fast to Juliana's opinion. They shared light stories of the past few months, anecdotes about their Pokémon teams and families. How the League was handling the fallout of the Crater situation, the reveal of Paradox Pokémon to the public. Soon enough, they were interrupted by a knock on the door. Rika yelled at the person on the other side to enter, and in came Penny.

"I have come to collect my due." She stated dryly as she entered the room.

"Penny!" Juliana stood up like a bullet and rushed towards Penny, taking the girl in a hug as Rika chuckled at her misery.

"What are you doing here?" She asked with a bright grin as she pulled back. "I thought I was supposed to meet Nemona at the Academy?"

"Change of plans." The girl answered. "She remembered the day."

"... Oh." Juliana deflated in guilt.

Penny's eyes softened. "Hey, cheer up. It's more on us if anything. Still- you're both having your battle if you want later today. For now, we're going to the beach."

She took her by the wrist, almost dragging her out of the room while talking mostly to herself. Juliana let her, with a relaxed smile on her face.

"Have a good day you two!" Rika called after them with a wave. "Don't forget to call!"

Juliana grinned. "Will do!" She shouted back. "See you soon!"

And as Penny dragged her through the League's front door, she thought only one thing.

She loved her friends.